Hidden Strength, Hidden Heart

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at https://archiveofourown.org/works/73316906.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

Categories:
F/F, F/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Mermista/Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Adora & Entrapta (She-Ra)

Characters:
Entrapta (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Huntara (She-Ra), Netossa (She-Ra), Frosta (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Smut

Language:
English

Stats:
Published: 2025-10-29 Updated: 2026-02-03 Words: 50,652 Chapters: 21/31

Hidden Strength, Hidden Heart

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at https://archiveofourown.org/works/73316906.

Rating:
Mature

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

Categories:
F/F, F/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Mermista/Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Adora & Entrapta (She-Ra)

Characters:
Entrapta (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Huntara (She-Ra), Netossa (She-Ra), Frosta (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Smut

Language:
English

Stats:
Published: 2025-10-29 Updated: 2026-02-03 Words: 50,652
Chapters: 21/31

Hidden Strength, Hidden Heart

by Sashihabachi

Summary

Adora enrolls at Brightfall University to escape the pressures of fame and experience normal college life. She deliberately maintains a quiet, unassuming persona to avoid drawing attention to herself. Soon after arriving, she befriends Bow and Glimmer, who bring out her naturally energetic personality when she's comfortable with them.

Meanwhile, she becomes the target of the campus mean girls, led by the striking Catra. Catra is used to being the center of attention and is irritated by Adora's apparent indifference to her. Their rivalry intensifies when Adora begins outperforming Catra academically.

The turning point comes when Adora witnesses Catra being harassed by a group of men with bad intentions. Adora intervenes, revealing her fighting skills and her understanding of the local language as she protects Catra. Though she doesn't expose her She-Ra identity, Catra sees enough to become intrigued by Adora's mysterious capabilities.

What begins as curiosity gradually transforms into attraction, leading to a classic enemies-to-lovers romance as both women navigate their changing feelings while keeping their own secrets.

Chapter 1: New enviroment

The familiar hum of the boxing gym faded as I unwrapped the tape from my hands. My phone buzzed for the third time in ten minutes. Mom again. I sighed, finally answering.

"Adora, honey, we need to talk about something important. Can you come home early today?"

Two hours later, I sat across from my parents at our kitchen table, staring at them in disbelief.

"Brightfall? You want to move back to Brightfall?" I asked, my voice rising slightly. The name of my childhood hometown stirred something both nostalgic and uncomfortable in my chest.

Dad leaned forward, his eyes crinkling at the corners. "It's a great opportunity, sweetheart. The hospital there has offered me a position I can't refuse, and your mother can transfer her research easily."

"But what about my training? The championship is in-"

"That's what we wanted to discuss." Mom interjected, exchanging a glance with Dad. "After that incident at your last match, and with all the media attention... maybe this is the perfect time for a break."

I winced at the memory, my hand unconsciously moving to my side where the worst of the fractures had been. The "incident", as the sports media had taken to calling it, had left me hospitalized for nearly three weeks. My opponent, Frosta, had been relentless. Targeting injuries I'd been hiding, exploiting weaknesses in my guard. By the sixth round, three ribs were broken, my orbital socket had been fractured, and internal bleeding had required emergency surgery. The sports networks had replayed that final knockout punch for weeks, analyzing how She-Ra, the undefeated rising star, had finally been brought down.

"We think…" Dad continued carefully, "that you might want to consider college for a while. Brightfall University has one of the best athletic programs in the country, and you could study kinesiology or sports medicine-"

"As myself." I finished, suddenly understanding where this was going. "Not as She-Ra."

Mom reached across the table and took my hand. "Just for a year or two. You're only twenty-three, Adora. There's plenty of time to return to boxing. But this way, you could experience normal college life without cameras and fans following your every move."

I ran my fingers through my blonde hair, considering their words. A normal life. Friends who liked me for me, not for my championship titles or the She-Ra persona my manager had crafted so carefully. No more hiding my face at press conferences, no more separate social media accounts and careful image management.

"What about Coach Huntara?" I asked, thinking of my mentor's reaction.

"She agrees." Dad said, surprising me. "She thinks the pressure is getting to you. Says even champions need time to grow as people, not just as athletes."

I stood up and walked to the window, gazing out at the city that had been home since we left Brightfall when I was thirteen. Just old enough to have learned the local language fluently before we moved away.

"Would I... have to go back to the language, the customs?"

Mom's expression turned thoughtful. "That's up to you, honey. Though Brightfall has embraced English for its international programs, you know how proud the locals are of their heritage and traditional language. If they discover you once lived there and understand it, they might never stop testing your knowledge or asking about your connection to the culture."

I considered this for a moment. "So it might be easier to just be the American exchange student who happens to have the same name as a kid who moved away years ago."

"Exactly," Dad added with a gentle smile. "And you'd be surprised how different you look now compared to when we left. The blonde hair, the growth spurt... I doubt anyone would connect you to the skinny kid who moved away years ago. Even if someone did remember us, they wouldn't be surprised that you've forgotten the language after all these years in America. Most people would expect that."

I nodded slowly, seeing the logic. A clean slate was appealing. A chance to be someone without a complicated history or expectations.

I thought about the tattoos now adorning both my arms and back. Another thing to hide at Brightfall University. No tank tops or short sleeves for me.

"When would we leave?" I asked, already feeling a strange mix of anxiety and excitement. "Three weeks." Mom replied. "Just enough time to withdraw from your current commitments and pack." I nodded slowly, mind racing with possibilities. "Okay. Let's do it."

As I headed to my room later that night, I caught my reflection in the hallway mirror. I pulled my hair back into the tight ponytail braid I wore for fights and straightened my shoulders the way She-Ra would. Then I let my hair fall loose again and slouched slightly, softening my expression.

Two different people. And soon, no one in Brightfall would know that the quiet exchange student in baggy clothes was actually She-Ra, three-time junior champion and rising star in women's boxing. For once, I could just be Adora.

The fourteen-hour flight to Brightfall felt like suspended animation, a liminal space between my old life and whatever

waited ahead. I spent most of it watching the in-flight tracker inch across the Pacific Ocean, each mile taking me further from She-Ra and closer to whoever I would become.

Coach Huntara had hugged me goodbye with surprising gentleness for a woman who regularly shouted at me to "Hit harder, damn it!"

"Don't get soft on me," She'd growled, but her eyes were suspiciously bright. "One year, maybe two. Then She-Ra comes back stronger than ever, understood?"

I'd nodded, throat tight. "Understood, Coach."

Now, as our plane began its final descent, I pressed my forehead against the cool window, taking in the lush green mountains that cradled Brightfall against the coastline. The town itself was a striking blend of traditional architecture with sleek modern buildings interspersed throughout. More developed than I remembered, yet somehow still familiar in its essence.

"Look!" Mom said, pointing past me. "They've expanded the harbor."

I followed her gaze to where fishing boats bobbed alongside gleaming yachts, the waterfront lined with what looked like new restaurants and shops. Beyond them rose the distinctive pagoda-style roofs of Brightfall's historic district, and further inland, the sprawling campus buildings of the university stood on terraced hills.

As we disembarked, the humid coastal air hit me like a physical presence, carrying scents of salt water, street food, and something floral I couldn't name. Signs in the airport alternated between the local language and English, accommodating the growing international presence in what had once been an insular community.

"Your father has arranged for a car." Mom said as we collected our luggage. "The rest of our things should arrive by freight next

week." The driver who met us bowed slightly and greeted my parents in the local dialect. I carefully maintained a polite but slightly confused expression, as though I couldn't follow the rapid exchange. In reality, every word resonated with childhood familiarity. Discussions of traffic, weather, and how much the town had changed.

Our new home wasn't in the city center but in a quiet suburban neighborhood about thirty minutes from campus. A spacious two-story house with a traditional-style garden that reminded me of our childhood home. The familiarity was both comforting and strange as the driver pulled into the driveway.

"It's beautiful," Mom said, gazing up at the house.

As we unloaded our luggage, Dad mentioned, "The university offered dorm housing through their international student program, but we thought you might prefer privacy here. Plus, this way you can train without worrying about roommates asking questions."

I nodded gratefully, knowing he was right. A dorm would have made maintaining my secrets nearly impossible. "Thanks, Dad. This is perfect."

My new bedroom was on the second floor, spacious with large windows overlooking the backyard. I set down my backpack and walked to the window, taking in the panorama of mountains in the distance and the neighborhood.

"We'll let you get settled," Mom said from the doorway. "Maybe rest a bit before dinner? The jet lag hits harder traveling east."

Once alone, I unpacked methodically, organizing my carefully selected wardrobe. Gone were the fitted athletic clothes I usually wore. Instead, I'd brought loose-fitting hoodies, long-sleeved tees, and baggy jeans. I ran my fingers over the sleeve of a particularly oversized sweater, wondering if I was overthinking this whole disguise.

Then I caught my reflection in the closet's mirrored door. I turned sideways, lifted my shirt slightly. The cut lines of my abdomen were unmistakable, the result of thousands of hours of training. I dropped the shirt and sighed. Definitely not overthinking it.

My phone buzzed with a text from Lonnie, one of my sparring partners back home.

Did you land yet? Good luck tomorrow. Don't forget who you are.

I typed back: *Just arrived. Thanks. Trying to forget, actually. That's the whole point.*

Her response was immediate: *Impossible. She-Ra is in your blood.*

I closed the message without replying and set an alarm for 5 AM. Just because I was taking a break from professional boxing didn't mean I could let myself get out of shape. I'd need to find training spots where I could maintain my schedule.

Sleep came fitfully that night, my dreams a jumble of boxing rings and classroom desks, of throwing punches and taking notes. I woke before my alarm, adrenaline already coursing through my veins as though preparing for a fight.

The apartment was silent as I slipped into running clothes and eased the front door closed behind me. Outside, Brightfall was just awakening, street vendors setting up food stalls, shopkeepers hosing down sidewalks. I pulled up a map on my phone and plotted a route toward the hills behind campus, where trails wound through dense forest.

The morning air carried the scent of the sea mixed with cooking aromas from early breakfast stalls. A few elderly people practiced tai chi in a small park, their movements fluid and precise. I nodded respectfully as I jogged past, picking up my pace as I reached the trail entrance.

For those few miles, I was just a body in motion, breath syncing with heartbeat, muscles working in perfect coordination.

Reality crashed back as I returned to the apartment, showered, and dressed in my carefully selected first-day outfit: loose jeans, a plain gray hoodie over a long-sleeved shirt, and minimal makeup. I pulled my damp hair into a simple ponytail and stared at myself in the bathroom mirror.

"Hi," I practiced, softening my voice slightly. "I'm Adora. I'm new here." I tried again with a slightly confused expression. "Sorry, I don't understand much of the local language."

It felt ridiculous, rehearsing like this, but I needed to get it right. The girl in the mirror looked... ordinary. Forgettable, even. Perfect.

Mom insisted on accompanying me to campus for orientation, despite my protests that I could manage.

"It's your first day," she said firmly. "And I need to check in with the international student office anyway."

As we approached the administration building, with its blend of modern glass and traditional design elements, she squeezed my shoulder. "Remember, Adora. Take this chance to enjoy life and make friends and live a little bit."

I nodded, though we both knew the irony of her statement. Being myself meant hiding half of who I was.

"Thanks, Mom," I said, adjusting my backpack. "I'll see you tonight."

I watched her walk toward the faculty offices before turning to face the sprawling campus of Brightfall University. Students streamed past me, many chatting in the distinctive local dialect. Groups had already formed, friends reuniting after summer break, their laughter and animated conversations highlighting my solitude.

I took a deep breath, squared my shoulders, and walked toward the orientation hall where international students were gathering. New life, new me. I could do this.

The main building was an impressive blend of traditional architecture with modern elements sweeping pagoda-style roofs over glass and steel structures. Inside, the orientation hall buzzed with voices speaking a dozen different languages. Tables lined the perimeter, staffed by student volunteers wearing bright blue shirts with "WELCOME" written in multiple languages.

I approached the check-in desk, where a woman with silver-framed glasses glanced up with a practiced smile. "Name, please?" she asked in English, recognizing me as a foreign student.

"Adora Grayskull," I replied, keeping my voice soft. "I'm part of the exchange program from America." She typed into her computer, then nodded. "Ah, yes. Athletics department interest, correct?"

"Um, sports science," I clarified.

"Perfect. You'll be meeting with Dr. Moon shortly for your academic advising," she handed me a folder with orientation materials. "But first, let me introduce you to your student guide." She looked past me and waved someone over.

"Glimmer! Your exchange student is here."

I turned to see a young woman hurrying toward us, her pink hair catching the light in a way that almost seemed to shimmer. She was shorter than me by several inches, with a curvy but athletic build, dressed in a stylish purple top and fitted jeans. The most striking thing about her was her smile, warm and genuine, lighting up her entire face.

"Hi! You must be Adora!" She said, extending her hand. "I'm Glimmer Moon. I'll be your student orientation guide this semester."

"Moon? Like Dr. Moon?" I asked, shaking her hand.

She rolled her eyes good-naturedly. "My mom. The department head of International Studies. No pressure, right?" She laughed, and I found myself smiling back despite my nerves.

"Don't worry," she continued, "I won't tell her if you skip class occasionally. Student guide-advisee confidentiality." She winked.

"Thanks," I said, relaxing slightly. "This is all a bit overwhelming."

"Oh, I totally get it," Glimmer said, gesturing for me to follow her away from the desk. "I spent a semester in France last year and nearly had a breakdown trying to figure out their university system. Come on, let's grab a seat and go through your welcome packet before you meet with my mom."

She led me to a quieter corner of the hall where small tables were set up for orientation consultations. As we sat, I noticed her studying me curiously.

"So, America, huh? What part?"

"West Coast," I answered, keeping it vague. "A bit north of Los Angeles."

"Cool! I've always wanted to visit California. Is it really like it looks in movies?" Her enthusiasm was infectious.

"Sometimes." I smiled. "Fewer car chases though."

Glimmer laughed, a bright sound that matched her name perfectly. "Well, Brightfall might seem boring in comparison, but I promise it has its charms." She began pulling items from my welcome packet. "So, here's your campus map, class schedule, meal plan info, and…" she lowered her voice conspiratorially, "My unofficial guide to which cafeteria foods to avoid at all costs."

I couldn't help but laugh. There was something so instantly likable about Glimmer, an openness that made me feel at ease.

"As your guide, I'm supposed to show you around campus, help you find your classes, and basically be your go-to person for any questions or problems," she explained. "We'll start with a campus tour after your meeting with my mom, I mean, Dr. Moon." She pulled out her phone. "But first, we should exchange numbers. Easier than trying to find each other in the crowd if we get separated."

We swapped contact information, and Glimmer immediately sent me a text with a sparkle emoji. "There! Now you officially know someone at Brightfall U."

A soft chime sounded from the speakers overhead, and Glimmer glanced at her watch. "That's the advisor call. My mom should be ready for you now." She stood, gathering my papers back into the folder. "Her office is just down the hall. I'll walk you there."

As we navigated through the crowd of international students, Glimmer pointed out various campus landmarks visible through the windows. "That's the main library. It's got the best study rooms. And over there is the student center where most of the clubs meet. Oh, and that building with the curved roof is the athletic center. Do you play any sports?"

The question was innocent, but I felt my muscles tense. "Not really," I lied, adjusting my hoodie sleeves to make sure my tattoos were completely covered. "I just find the science behind athletics interesting."

Glimmer nodded. "Well, if you're into fitness at all, the gym there is amazing. My friend Bow teaches archery lessons on weekends, and there's everything from swimming to rock climbing."

"Sounds nice." I said noncommittally. I'd have to check it out eventually to maintain my training. We stopped outside a door with a nameplate reading "Dr. Angella Moon, Department Chair, International Studies." Glimmer knocked and then opened it without waiting for a response.

"Mom, I mean, Dr. Moon. I've brought Adora Grayskull for her advisement session." She announced, ushering me inside. Dr. Moon looked up from her desk with a smile that mirrored her daughter's. She was elegant and poised, with streaks of silver in her dark hair that somehow made her look distinguished rather than older.

"Thank you, Glimmer." She said, rising to greet me. "Ms. Grayskull, welcome to Brightfall University. Please, have a seat."

"I'll wait outside." Glimmer told me with an encouraging smile. "When you're done, we'll start the campus tour."

As the door closed behind her, Dr. Moon gestured to the chair across from her desk. "So, Adora. I understand you're interested in our sports science program..."

For the next twenty minutes, Dr. Moon walked me through my class schedule, explaining the university's expectations and resources available to international students. She was thorough and kind, pausing occasionally to make sure I understood everything.

"Your academic records from America are quite impressive." She noted, looking over my file. "Though there seems to be a gap in your education history last year?"

My heart skipped. That would be when I was competing heavily and had switched to online classes. "I had some health issues." I said quietly, which wasn't entirely untrue. "But I'm fully recovered now."

She nodded sympathetically. "Well, we're glad to have you here. Brightfall University prides itself on providing a supportive environment for all students, especially those far from home." She closed my file. "And it seems my daughter has already taken you under her wing, which is fortunate. Glimmer has an extraordinary talent for making people feel welcome."

"She's been very kind." I agreed.

"Just one more thing," Dr. Moon said as I stood to leave. "Your file mentions you might have some familiarity with our culture? Your family lived in the region when you were younger?"

I tensed slightly but kept my expression neutral. "Yes, but I was quite young. I don't remember much, and I never really picked up the language."

She smiled. "Well, perhaps being here will refresh some memories. Many students find reconnecting with childhood places quite meaningful."

I nodded noncommittally and thanked her for her time. As I stepped back into the hallway, Glimmer bounced up from a bench where she'd been waiting.

"All set?" She asked brightly. "How was it? My mom can be pretty intense sometimes."

"It was fine." I assured her. "She seems nice."

"She is, just don't get on her bad side!" Glimmer laughed. "Ready for the grand tour? We should start with the places you'll need first. Your classrooms, the dining hall, library..." She paused, looking at me thoughtfully. "Actually, are you hungry? The orientation lunch won't be for another hour, but I know a great place just off campus."

My stomach growled in response, reminding me I hadn't eaten since the airplane meal hours ago. "Food would be great." I admitted.

"Perfect! And while we eat, you can tell me more about yourself. I want to know everything about my new American friend!" She grinned, linking her arm through mine with an easy familiarity that caught me off guard.

As we headed toward the exit, I felt a small pang of guilt about all the things I couldn't tell her. But for now, I was just grateful to

have made what seemed to be my first real friend at Brightfall University.

What I didn't realize was that our lunch destination would lead to my first encounter with a very different kind of student. One with mismatched eyes and a reputation that preceded her.

Chapter 2: Calculated Hostility

Glimmer led me away from campus and down a winding street lined with cherry blossom trees. After a few minutes of walking, we reached a small restaurant tucked between a bookstore and a tech repair shop. The sign above the door read "Whispering Woods Café" in both English and the local language.

"This place has the best bibimbap in town." Glimmer explained as she pushed open the door. "Plus, it's where most students hang out between classes."

Inside, the café was a cozy blend of traditional and modern aesthetics. Wooden tables and floor cushions alongside contemporary artwork and charging stations at every table. The smell of spices and grilled meat made my stomach growl embarrassingly loud.

"Someone's hungry." Glimmer laughed. She waved toward the back corner. "Oh perfect! My friends are here."

I followed her gaze to see a small group at a corner table. A young man with dark skin and an athletic build stood up when he spotted Glimmer, his face lighting up with a warm smile. Next to him, a woman with long purple hair tied in two thick ponytails was gesturing animatedly, completely absorbed in whatever she was explaining while typing on a tablet with her free hand.

"Hey guys!" Glimmer called as we approached. "I want you to meet someone."

The man immediately extended his hand. "You must be Glimmer's exchange student! I'm Bow." His handshake was firm and friendly, his smile genuine.

"Adora." I replied, returning his smile.

"AND THIS MUST BE THE AMERICAN SPECIMEN!" The purple-haired woman suddenly looked up, her voice several decibels

louder than necessary. She abandoned her tablet and bounded up, invading my personal space as she examined me with intense curiosity. "FASCINATING! You're much taller than the average female student here. Approximately 5'10" I'd estimate? Blonde hair, naturally so based on your eyebrows. And those eyes!" She leaned uncomfortably close. "Such a piercing blue! The coloration is quite striking against your skin tone."

"Entrapta." Bow said gently, pulling her back. "Remember what we talked about? Personal space?"

"Oh! Right!" She stepped back exactly two feet. "Sorry about that. I get excited about new data points. I mean, people. New people." She thrust out her hand robotically. "I am Entrapta. Robotics and engineering double major."

I shook her hand, slightly bewildered but amused. "Nice to meet you Entrapta."

"Your facial symmetry is remarkable!" She continued, seemingly unable to help herself. "And your smile creates the optimal ratio of teeth to lip visibility that most humans find attractive. According to my social interaction algorithms, you would be classified as extremely pretty."

Bow and Glimmer burst into laughter as my cheeks warmed.

"Entrapta! You can't just analyze people to their faces." Glimmer said between giggles.

"Why not? It's efficient." Entrapta replied, genuinely confused. "And accurate! The subject… I mean, Adora has a 94.8% likelihood of being in the top attractiveness percentile based on cross-cultural beauty standards."

"Okay, enough embarrassing Adora on her first day." Bow intervened, gesturing to the empty cushions at the table. "Let's sit and eat. I already ordered the lunch special for everyone."

As we settled around the table, I found myself wedged between Glimmer and Entrapta, who kept stealing glances at me while pretending to work on her tablet.

"So, Bow teaches archery on weekends." Glimmer explained, picking up our earlier conversation. "And he's on the university track team."

"Co-captain." Bow corrected with a grin. "Though I'm still trying to convince Glimmer to join something athletic."

"Hard pass." Glimmer replied. "I get all the exercise I need running between my mom's ridiculously high expectations and my actual interests."

"What about you, Adora?" Bow asked. "Are you into any sports or activities?"

Before I could answer with my prepared lie, Entrapta interjected, "Based on her musculature, which is evident despite the attempt to conceal it with oversized clothing, she engages in regular, intense physical training." She looked up from her tablet. "The shoulder-to-waist ratio suggests swimming or possibly a combat sport."

I nearly choked on the water I'd been drinking. "I, uh, just work out sometimes." I managed, tugging self-consciously at my hoodie sleeves. "Nothing serious."

Entrapta looked skeptical but was distracted when a server arrived with steaming bowls of bibimbap. The colorful arrangement of vegetables, meat, and egg over rice momentarily saved me from further scrutiny.

"Tiny food!" Entrapta exclaimed, already reaching for her chopsticks.

"Entrapta's in love with the miniature ecosystem of bibimbap." Bow explained, mixing the contents of his bowl. "Everything has its place but works together."

"Just like friendship!" Entrapta added, her mouth already full. "Different ingredients creating optimal flavor through proper combination."

I couldn't help but smile. There was something endearing about her unfiltered enthusiasm.

"So Adora," Bow said as we ate, "what made you choose Brightfall University?"

It was the question I'd prepared for, yet it still made me tense slightly. "The sports science program has a great reputation." I said, sticking to my cover story. "And I wanted to experience something completely different from California."

"You definitely came to the right place!" Glimmer said. "Brightfall is like nowhere else. You've got all the modern conveniences but with traditions that go back centuries."

"Like the Harvest Moon Festival next month." Bow added. "The whole town turns into this amazing celebration with lanterns and food stalls and traditional performances. We should all go together!"

"I GO PRIMARILY FOR THE TECHNOLOGICAL DISPLAYS." Entrapta announced. "Last year they had miniature drones performing synchronized light shows!" Her eyes widened suddenly and she grabbed my arm. "You have very firm biceps…" She blurted out, then quickly let go. "Sorry! That was inappropriate. But also factual."

Glimmer snorted into her water while Bow tried to hide his smile.

"It's okay." I said, feeling strangely comfortable despite the awkwardness. There was something refreshing about Entrapta's honesty, even if it was a bit too perceptive for my comfort.

"Entrapta has a talent for noticing things about people." Bow explained diplomatically. "Sometimes before they want those things noticed."

"I'm working on it." Entrapta sighed. "Social interaction is much more complex than robotics. Robots follow logical rules. Humans are..." She waved her chopsticks expressively "Messy."

"Speaking of messy…" Glimmer said, lowering her voice conspiratorially, "Guess who just walked in."

We all turned toward the entrance, where a group of five students had entered. At their center was a young woman who seemed to command attention without trying. Tall and lithe with long brown hair cascading in waves down her back. Even from across the room, I could see her unusual eyes, one blue, one amber as they scanned the café with a bored expression.

"Catra." Bow whispered, turning back quickly. "And her whole crew."

"Who's Catra?" I asked, still watching the newcomer. There was something magnetic about her presence, the way she moved with languid confidence.

"Only the most popular girl at Brightfall University." Glimmer explained. "She's brilliant, beautiful and knows it. Her family basically owns half the tech companies in town, so she acts like she owns the university too."

"And people let her," Bow added, "because crossing Catra means crossing her friends, which means social suicide."

"THE POWER DYNAMICS OF HER SOCIAL HIERARCHY ARE FASCINATING!" Entrapta whispered loudly. "She maintains dominance through a combination of wealth, beauty standards, conformity and strategic alliances."

As if sensing our discussion, Catra's mismatched eyes suddenly locked with mine from across the room. For a moment, neither of us looked away, her gaze cool and assessing, mine steady despite the unexpected flutter in my stomach.

"Oh no." Glimmer muttered. "She's coming over."

Indeed, Catra had detached herself from her group and was sauntering toward our table, her eyes still fixed on me with a curiosity that felt almost predatory.

"New blood." Bow whispered. "She always checks out the transfer students."

I straightened my shoulders slightly, an old reflex from facing down opponents in the ring. Whatever test Catra was about to administer, I was determined to pass it.

What I didn't know then was how thoroughly that encounter would complicate my carefully planned new life.

The sound of Catra's approaching footsteps seemed to change the atmosphere of our table instantly. Bow subtly straightened his posture, Glimmer's smile tightened and even Entrapta stopped typing, her eyes darting between her tablet and the approaching figure.

"Well, if it isn't the Brightfall reject squad." Catra drawled as she reached our table, her voice a smooth contralto with a hint of rasp. Up close, her mismatched eyes were even more striking, the blue one cold as ice, the amber one gleaming with mischief. "Starting the charity work early this year Sparkles? Taking in strays before orientation's even over?"

Glimmer's cheeks flushed pink but she kept her voice level. "Her name is Adora. She's an exchange student I'm showing around."

Catra's friends had drifted over to flank her, a tall, muscular girl with short white hair, a willowy blonde examining her manicure with exaggerated boredom and two others I couldn't quite see behind them.

"How noble of you." Catra smirked, then shifted her attention to Bow. "Arrow Boy. Still following Sparkles around like a lovesick puppy, I see."

Bow's smile didn't waver, though his eyes hardened slightly. "Always nice to see you too Catra."

"AND YOUR SOCIAL AGGRESSION METRICS ARE STILL PEAKING IN GROUP SETTINGS!" Entrapta announced, as if making a scientific observation. "FASCINATING CONSISTENCY!"

Catra's eyes narrowed at Entrapta. "Still can't control your volume Lab Rat? Maybe you should build yourself a mute button." Her gaze finally shifted to me, and something in her expression changed, a flicker of genuine interest replacing the practiced disdain.

"So," she said, leaning one hand on our table as she addressed me directly, "you're new." It wasn't a question.

I met her gaze steadily. "Yes."

"Exchange student?"

"From America." I confirmed, keeping my voice neutral.

Catra studied me for a moment, her head tilting slightly in a gesture that was almost feline. A calculating look entered her eyes, like she was formulating a plan on the spot. Without warning, she switched from English to the local language, her words flowing with native fluency.

"*Another American who thinks they can just show up and be treated like royalty.* " She said, her tone mockingly sweet. "*At least this one's pretty. Probably dumb as a rock though, like all these exchange students.* " She glanced back at her friends. "*Bet she can't even handle the basic coursework.*"

The muscular girl with white hair laughed. "*Give her a week before she's crying for home.*"

"*Or begging one of us to do her assignments.* " Added the blonde.

I kept my expression carefully blank, as if I couldn't understand a word they were saying, but internally I was taking mental notes. So this was the real Catra, someone who switched languages specifically to exclude others, to talk about them right to their faces. The casual cruelty of it was almost impressive.

Catra continued in the local tongue, now addressing her comments to Glimmer while still looking at me. "*Your mother must be scraping the bottom of the barrel if this is who they're accepting now. Though I suppose with her looks, she'll at least make a nice decoration around campus.* " I saw Glimmer shift uncomfortably.

Catra leaned closer to me, switching back to English. "So, Adora from America, how are you finding our little university? Everything you hoped for?"

Before I could answer, she turned back to her friends and resumed in the local language, "*Look at her, so clueless. This might actually be fun. Fresh meat.* " She laughed, a sound that might have been charming if it wasn't so clearly at my expense.

I'd had enough. "Excuse me Entrapta." I said quietly, "Could you let me out please?"

Entrapta scrambled to her feet, and I stood up slowly, unfolding to my full height. At nearly 5'11", I towered over Catra by at least four inches, forcing her to tilt her head back to maintain eye contact. I saw a flicker of surprise cross her face as she realized just how tall I was.

"I don't know what you just said." I lied smoothly in English, my voice calm but firm, "But there's really no point in being rude on my first day here. I think it's time for you to leave."

A hush fell over both groups. Catra's eyes widened slightly, clearly not used to being challenged, especially by someone new.

"Well well." She recovered quickly, a slow smile spreading across her face. "Looks like America sent us someone with a backbone

for once." She took a deliberate step back, looking me up and down with renewed interest. "See you around, Adora."

The way she said my name, drawing out the middle syllable with a hint of a purr sent an unexpected shiver down my spine.

Catra turned and sauntered back to her group, her friends closing ranks around her as they moved to a table at the far side of the café. I could feel her eyes on my back as I sat down again.

"Holy crap." Glimmer whispered, staring at me with newfound admiration. "Nobody stands up to Catra like that. Nobody."

"THAT WAS AMAZING!" Entrapta exclaimed at full volume. "DID YOU SEE HER FACIAL EXPRESSION? COMPLETE RECALIBRATION OF EXPECTATIONS!"

"Shh!" Bow urged, though he was grinning broadly. "But seriously Adora, that was impressive. Most people either fall all over themselves trying to please Catra or shrink into nothing when she targets them."

I shrugged, trying to downplay the moment. "I just don't see the point of letting someone bully me on my first day here. What's her deal anyway? Why is everyone so afraid of her?"

Glimmer leaned in, lowering her voice. "Her family basically funds half the university's research programs. Her mother is some tech mogul who developed military-grade security systems. Plus, Catra herself is actually brilliant. Top of her class despite barely seeming to try."

"And she has dirt on everyone." Bow added. "Somehow, she always knows exactly which buttons to push."

"The social dynamics are complex." Entrapta contributed, for once keeping her voice at a reasonable level. "Catra maintains power through a combination of wealth, intelligence, strategic information gathering and carefully cultivated fear."

I glanced over at Catra's table, where she was holding court with her friends, laughing at something. As if sensing my attention, she looked up, those mismatched eyes finding mine instantly across the café. Instead of looking away, she raised an eyebrow and lifted her glass in a mocking toast.

I turned back to my new friends. "Well, she doesn't scare me." I said truthfully. After facing down opponents twice my size in the ring, after the brutality of my last match, a spoiled rich girl with a mean streak hardly registered as a threat.

"Maybe you should." Glimmer said quietly. "Catra doesn't like being challenged. She might leave you alone now, or..."

"Or she might make you her new special project." Bow finished.

"Either way," Glimmer added, brightening, "you've got us now. Safety in numbers, right?"

I smiled, genuinely touched by their instant inclusion. "Right."

As we finished our lunch and prepared to continue the campus tour, I couldn't help but think about Catra's words in the local language. The casual way she'd dismissed me as pretty but dumb, as someone who'd be begging for help with coursework. Little did she know I'd graduated top of my class even while maintaining a professional boxing career.

I'd have to be careful around her. She was clearly observant and calculating. But a small, competitive part of me, the part that had driven She-Ra to championship titles, couldn't help but look forward to proving her wrong.

What I didn't realize then was that my reaction to Catra had set something in motion that would be difficult to stop. And for someone trying to maintain a low profile, that was a dangerous first step.

The rest of the day passed in a whirlwind of campus tours, introductory lectures and information sessions. Glimmer proved to

be an excellent guide, showing me shortcuts between buildings and pointing out which professors were strict about attendance. Bow joined us for the afternoon, offering his own insights about student life, while Entrapta occasionally appeared and disappeared like a purple-haired phantom, always engrossed in some technological project but eager to share random facts about Brightfall's infrastructure.

By late afternoon, I was mentally exhausted but oddly content. For the first time in years, I'd spent a day being seen as just Adora and not She-Ra the boxing prodigy, not the athlete with the carefully managed public image. Despite the encounter with Catra or maybe partly because of it, I felt like I'd found my footing.

"You sure you don't want a ride home?" Glimmer asked as we stood outside the main administration building. The sun was beginning to set, casting long shadows across the campus grounds. "My apartment's not far from the bus station. I could drop you off."

"Thanks, but I'm good." I assured her. "The bus will take me straight to my neighborhood, and I could use the downtime to process everything."

"Fair enough." She nodded, then surprised me with a quick hug. "See you tomorrow for your first real day of classes! Text me if you need anything, okay?"

I nodded. Bow gave me a friendly wave as they headed off toward the student parking lot, already deep in conversation about some campus event they were organizing.

Making my way to the bus stop, I couldn't help but feel a small thrill of accomplishment. Day one of my new life and I'd already made friends, stood up to the campus queen bee, and successfully maintained my cover. Not bad.

The campus bus stop was crowded with students heading home after orientation activities. I checked the route map, confirming

that bus number 42 would take me to the stop about a ten-minute walk from my house. As the large blue and white vehicle pulled up, students began forming a line to board.

I was one of the last to get on, scanning for an empty seat as the bus filled quickly. There were only two spots left, one next to an elderly man who appeared to be sleeping, and another beside a girl with her face turned toward the window, brown hair cascading over her shoulders.

I opted for the latter, sliding into the seat just as the bus lurched forward. Only after I'd settled my backpack between my feet did I glance at my seat partner and felt my stomach drop.

Catra.

She turned from the window, those mismatched eyes widening slightly in recognition before a slow, almost predatory smile spread across her face.

"Well well," she drawled, "if it isn't America's newest export."

I considered pretending I hadn't heard her, but something about the challenge in her eyes made me respond. "Small world." I said neutrally.

"Small bus." She corrected, shifting to angle herself toward me. "What are the chances? You live out this way or are you following me?"

I nodded. "Not a chance I would follow you. And yes I live about ten minutes from the Moonstone Heights stop."

"Interesting." She said, in a tone that suggested she found it more than merely interesting. "That's a nice area. Pricey."

I shrugged, not taking the bait to discuss finances. "My parents are faculty."

"Ah." She nodded, as if that explained everything. "The perks of academia."

An awkward silence fell between us as the bus rumbled through Brightfall's streets. I pulled out my phone, hoping she'd take the hint but Catra seemed determined to continue our interaction.

"So, Adora from America." She began, emphasizing my name in that same drawn-out way from earlier, "What made you choose Brightfall? We're hardly on the typical exchange student circuit."

"The sports science program." I replied, sticking to my cover story. "It has a good reputation."

Catra made a dismissive noise. "Please. There are dozens of better programs you could have chosen. Try again."

I looked at her, surprised by her directness. "Excuse me?"

"I'm giving you a chance to tell me something real." She said, lowering her voice slightly. "Not the rehearsed answer you've been feeding everyone else today."

"I'm not sure what you want me to say. It's a good program in an interesting location. Why does there need to be more to it than that?"

Catra studied me, her eyes narrowing slightly. "Because nobody comes to Brightfall without a reason. It's too remote, too different, too... particular." She switched suddenly to the local language. "*Everyone here is running from something or looking for something. Which are you?*"

I maintained my blank expression, though internally I was impressed by her perception. "Sorry, I don't understand when you do that." I said, gesturing vaguely at her shift in language.

"Hm." she hummed, clearly not convinced. "You're a mystery, Adora. And I don't like mysteries. I prefer to expose them."

The directness of her statement caught me off guard. "There's nothing to expose." I insisted. "I'm probably the least mysterious person you'll meet."

"Oh, I doubt that." Catra leaned closer, her voice dropping to almost a whisper. "See, I watched you today. The way you move, the way you hold yourself. You're... contained. Careful. Like someone who's hiding something."

My heart rate picked up, but I kept my expression neutral. "Or maybe I'm just navigating a new environment in a foreign country. Not everything has a hidden agenda."

She laughed at that, a genuine sound that transformed her face, making her look younger and somehow more approachable. "Everything has a hidden agenda in Brightfall. You'll learn."

The bus slowed as it approached a stop, and Catra gathered her bag, preparing to stand.

"That was boring." She said, rising gracefully. Before stepping into the aisle, she paused, looking down at me with those unsettling mismatched eyes. "See you around Adora."

As she moved toward the exit, she called back over her shoulder, "Oh, and for what it's worth? Not many people stand up to me the way you did today. I haven't decided if that makes you brave or just stupid."

With that, she stepped off the bus, leaving me staring after her. Through the window, I watched her walk toward a modern apartment complex, her confident stride unmistakable even from a distance.

Two stops later, I exited the bus myself, my mind replaying our conversation as I walked the remaining distance home. Catra was observant. Dangerously so. Her comment about the way I moved hit too close to home. Boxers develop a particular way of carrying themselves, a balance and economy of movement that becomes second nature. I'd need to be more careful around her.

The sun had fully set by the time I reached our house. Inside, I found a note from my parents saying they'd gone to a faculty dinner and left food in the refrigerator. The empty house was a relief after a day of constant social interaction and vigilance.

After heating up dinner, I retreated to my room and finally changed out of my concealing clothes. Standing before the mirror in just shorts and a sports bra, I examined the defined muscles of my arms and shoulders, the tattoos that covered surgical scars and told stories of fights won and lost.

This was the real me, the fighter who never backed down, who had risen to the top through sheer determination and skill.

But it was also the me that Brightfall couldn't see. Not if I wanted to be a 23 year old experiencing her college life for the first time.

I pulled on a tank top and settled on my bed with my laptop, intending to review my class materials for tomorrow. Instead, I found myself searching Catra's name. The results were illuminating. President of the student business association, winner of multiple academic competitions, daughter of prominent tech CEO Shadow Weaver.

In one photo from a university gala, she stood in an elegant burgundy dress, looking simultaneously bored and commanding, those distinctive eyes challenging the camera. I studied the picture longer than I should have, intrigued despite myself.

Catra was right about one thing, everyone at Brightfall did seem to have a reason for being there. Hers appeared to be birthright and brilliance. Mine was simply to learn and live. To experience something new without the weight of expectations.

Closing my laptop, I set an early alarm for a pre-dawn run. Tomorrow would be my first real day of classes. My first real test of whether Adora could successfully exist where She-Ra was nowhere to be found.

And somewhere in Brightfall, in an apartment not far from the bus stop where she'd exited, Catra was perhaps wondering about the new American student who had stood her ground without flinching.

Chapter 3: The Festival

The next few weeks settled into a routine that felt almost normal. My days filled with classes, study sessions with my new friends and carefully timed workouts when the athletic facilities were least crowded. I'd discovered an abandoned storage room in the sports building's basement that I'd converted into a makeshift training space, complete with a heavy bag I'd purchased and snuck in piece by piece.

By the third week of the semester, Glimmer, Bow and Entrapta had become fixtures in my life. We studied together in the library, shared meals at the Whispering Woods Café and spent weekends exploring Brightfall. It was the most genuine friendship I'd experienced in years.

There was just one persistent thorn in my otherwise pleasant new existence: Catra.

It turned out we shared three classes, Advanced Physiology, International Business Ethics, and Cultural Studies. In each one, she seemed to go out of her way to make her presence known to me specifically. At first, I thought I was imagining it but Glimmer confirmed my suspicions over lunch one day.

"She's definitely targeting you." She whispered, glancing across the cafeteria where Catra sat. "I've never seen her so focused on one person before."

"Statistically significant behavioral deviation" Entrapta agreed. "I've been tracking her interaction patterns. Normally she distributes her antagonism fairly evenly across the student population but you receive approximately 68.3% of her attention now."

"Lucky me." I muttered, stabbing at my salad.

It had started subtly enough. In Advanced Physiology, Catra had begun sitting directly behind me, occasionally "accidentally" kicking my chair or whispering sarcastic commentary about my answers when I spoke in class. In International Business Ethics, she'd challenge every point I made during discussions, twisting my words until I sounded naïve or uninformed.

But it was Cultural Studies that had become the real battleground. Professor Netossa had assigned us as partners for a semester-long project on cultural identity and displacement. A cruel irony given that I was actively hiding my cultural understanding of Brightfall. During our first project meeting in the library, Catra had spent the entire time scrolling through her phone, occasionally looking up to make cutting remarks about my research approach.

"You realize you're completely missing the local perspective, right?" She'd drawled, not even glancing at the outline I'd prepared. "This reads like a tourist brochure, not academic work."

I'd bitten my tongue. "That's why we're partners." I'd replied evenly. "You can provide the local insights."

She'd laughed at that. "So I do all the real work while you get half the credit? Typical exchange student approach."

That had been just the beginning. As days turned into weeks, Catra's targeted campaign against me grew more creative and persistent. She'd "accidentally" spill coffee on my notes before important exams. She'd ask me questions in the local language in front of others, making me play the confused foreigner while she smirked knowingly. Once, she'd even switched my presentation slides in Business Ethics, replacing my carefully researched content with random memes.

I refused to show how much she irritated me, which only seemed to fuel her determination to crack my composure.

By the time the Harvest Moon Festival approached in mid-October, Catra's vendetta had become common knowledge across campus.

Even professors had noticed. With Dr. Moon pulling me aside after International Studies to ask if I wanted to discuss "any social challenges" I might be experiencing.

"I'm fine." I'd assured her, not wanting to seem weak or incapable of handling myself. In truth, compared to the physical and mental challenges of professional boxing, Catra's mind games were annoying but manageable. What bothered me more was how much mental space she occupied in my thoughts, how often I found myself anticipating her next move or rehearsing responses to her potential provocations.

The Wednesday before the festival, things came to a head in Cultural Studies. Professor Netossa had asked each partnership to give a progress update on their projects. When our turn came, I stood and began presenting our outline on cultural displacement in international education.

"Our research focuses on how exchange students navigate cultural adaptation while maintaining their own cultural identity." I explained, aware of Catra's bored expression as she examined her nails beside me. "We're looking specifically at-"

"Actually!" Catra interrupted, suddenly animated, "I'd like to share a fascinating discovery from our research." She turned to face the class, completely cutting me off. "It seems our American partner here isn't quite what she appears to be."

My blood ran cold. Had she somehow discovered my She-Ra identity? Had I slipped up somewhere?

Catra continued, her mismatched eyes gleaming with malice. "I've been doing some background research for our project and it turns out Adora's family actually lived in Brightfall years ago. Isn't that an interesting omission from someone studying cultural displacement?"

The class murmured with interest while I fought to keep my expression neutral. This wasn't about She-Ra, it was about my

childhood in Brightfall.

"I was very young." I said carefully. "I don't remember much from that time."

"Really?" Catra tilted her head in mock confusion. "Because your father was quite well-known at Brightfall General Hospital. Chief of Cardiology, wasn't he? And your mother was a research fellow at the university. Seems significant enough to mention when discussing your connection to our culture."

Professor Netossa looked between us with interest. "Is this true, Adora? You have previous ties to Brightfall?"

I maintained my composure. "My family did live here when I was a child, yes. But we left when I was thirteen and I've been in America since. My memories of Brightfall are limited, which is why I didn't think it relevant to mention."

"How convenient." Catra smirked. "Selective memory that just happens to position you as a complete outsider when it suits your narrative."

"That's enough Catra." Professor Netossa intervened, sensing the tension. "While interesting, Adora's childhood residence doesn't fundamentally change the parameters of your project. Please continue with your actual research findings."

Catra shrugged as if it didn't matter but the damage was done. She'd publicly called my authenticity into question, planted seeds of doubt about my honesty. As we returned to our seats after the presentation, she leaned close and whispered in the local language, "*I know there's more you're hiding, Adora. It's just a matter of time before I figure it out.*"

I pretended not to understand, but inside, my pulse was racing. Catra was digging into my past, and while she hadn't uncovered She-Ra yet, she was clearly determined to expose something about me.

After class, she brushed past me in the hallway, deliberately bumping my shoulder. "Better watch yourself princess." she said just loudly enough for me to hear.

I watched her saunter away, surrounded by her usual entourage, all of them glancing back at me with smirks and whispers. The tall muscular girl, Scorpia, I'd learned seemed less enthusiastic about the bullying than the others, occasionally shooting me apologetic looks when Catra wasn't watching.

That evening, as I vented to Glimmer, Bow and Entrapta at our weekly study session in the library, Bow finally asked the question they'd all been dancing around.

"Why do you think she's so fixated on you specifically? I mean, Catra's always been... difficult but this seems personal somehow."

I shook my head, genuinely baffled. "I wish I knew. From day one, she's had this... vendetta against me."

"MAYBE IT'S ATTRACTION!" Entrapta announced, earning us a stern look from the librarian. Lowering her voice to a stage whisper, she continued, "Many mammals exhibit antagonistic behavior toward potential mates! It's a form of testing genetic fitness!"

Glimmer snorted. "Or maybe she just can't stand that Adora didn't immediately bow down to her like most new students do."

"Whatever her problem is." I said firmly, "I'm not going to let her get to me. The Harvest Moon Festival is this weekend and I want to enjoy it without worrying about Catra's next move."

Bow grinned, clearly relieved to change the subject. "It's going to be amazing. There's food, music, traditional performances and the lantern release at midnight is basically magical."

"AND TINY FOOD!" Entrapta added excitedly. "SO MANY VARIETIES OF TINY FOOD!"

As they launched into a detailed description of festival traditions, I tried to put Catra out of my mind. But later that night, as I worked through my training routine, throwing combinations at the heavy bag with perhaps more force than necessary, I couldn't shake the memory of her words.

"*I know there's more you're hiding, Adora. It's just a matter of time before I figure it out.”*

The thought of Catra digging deeper into my past, potentially uncovering She-Ra, sent a chill through me that had nothing to do with the cool air. For the first time since arriving in Brightfall, I wondered if I'd made a terrible mistake in thinking I could be just Adora and not She-ra.

The following morning, sunlight streamed through my window as my phone buzzed with messages. Glimmer had already sent a dozen texts about festival plans, her excitement practically leaping from the screen.

"So, festival plans?" Glimmer asked, spreading a campus map marked with festival locations across our library table. "We should coordinate where to meet for the lantern release at midnight."

It was Thursday afternoon, just two days before the much-anticipated Harvest Moon Festival. According to Bow, the entire town transformed for the weekend-long celebration, with streets closed to traffic, food stalls lining the main thoroughfares and performances happening on stages throughout Brightfall.

"Bow and I usually start at the University Square." Glimmer continued, pointing to a spot on the map. "The dance performances there are amazing and then we work our way down to the harbor for the night market."

"I'll be at the technology showcase until approximately 8:42 PM." Entrapta announced, consulting a color-coded schedule on her tablet. "They're demonstrating miniature agricultural drones that can pollinate individual flowers with 98.6% accuracy!"

Bow grinned at Entrapta's enthusiasm before turning to me. "What about you, Adora? Any specific traditions you want to check out?"

I shrugged, a new reluctance feeling coming up about the whole event. The festival would be crowded. Plus, after weeks of Catra's targeted harassment, the thought of potentially running into her during what was supposed to be a fun celebration wasn't appealing.

"I'm not sure I'm going." I admitted. "I have a lot of work to catch up on, and-"

"UNACCEPTABLE!" Entrapta exclaimed, slamming her hands on the table dramatically. "The Harvest Moon Festival is a crucial cultural experience with significant data-gathering potential!" Her expression suddenly shifted from outrage to something more vulnerable. "Also, large crowds produce sensory overload that impairs my normal functionality, and having a companion increases my comfort metrics by 73.4%."

"What Entrapta's trying to say…" Bow translated gently, "Is that she'd like you to go with her."

"Yes! Be my festival date!" Entrapta grabbed my hands, her eyes wide and pleading. "We can observe the technological exhibitions together and you can prevent me from dismantling public property when I see inefficient engineering!"

Glimmer snickered. "That actually happened last year. The city's automatic street lamps were apparently offensively wasteful in their power consumption algorithms."

I looked at Entrapta's hopeful expression and felt my resistance crumbling. "Alright, I'll go. But I'm not staying out too late."

"EXCELLENT!" Entrapta immediately pulled out her tablet and began typing furiously. "I'm adding you to my festival optimization schedule. We'll achieve maximum experience efficiency!"

Bow and Glimmer exchanged knowing looks. "And while Entrapta's dragging you around the tech exhibits, we'll be enjoying actual fun activities," Glimmer teased.

"Speaking of which." Bow said, a slight blush coloring his cheeks, "Glimmer and I were thinking of checking out the moonlight boat rides at the harbor. They're supposed to be, um, really nice."

The way Glimmer suddenly became very interested in rearranging her pens told me there was more to this plan than a simple boat ride. I'd been watching these two dance around their obvious feelings for weeks now.

"Sounds romantic." I observed innocently, enjoying how they both stammered denials.

"It's traditional!" Glimmer insisted, her cheeks matching her pink hair.

"Cultural appreciation!" Bow added too quickly.

"YOUR ELEVATED HEART RATES SUGGEST OTHERWISE!" Entrapta commented without looking up from her tablet.

The conversation devolved into good-natured teasing after that but I couldn't shake my uneasiness about the festival. That evening, after dinner with my parents, I decided a run might help clear my head. The night air was crisp with early autumn, the streets quieter than usual as the town prepared for the weekend's festivities.

I chose a route that took me around the neighborhood perimeter and through a small wooded park. The physical exertion felt good after a day of sitting in classes and the library. I gradually relaxed into the familiar rhythm of my footfalls.

I was crossing through the park, lost in thought about tomorrow's physiology exam, when I rounded a bend in the path and nearly collided with another runner coming from the opposite direction.

"Watch it!" A familiar raspy voice snapped as we both pulled up short.

Catra stood before me in running gear, her hair pulled back in a ponytail, breathing hard from exertion. Recognition dawned in her mismatched eyes, quickly followed by her customary smirk.

"Well, if it isn't America's favorite exchange student." She drawled. "Shouldn't you be inside studying how to blend in better?"

I bit back a retort, determined not to let her provoke me. "Just getting some exercise. Excuse me." I tried to step around her, but she shifted to block my path.

"Always with the long sleeves. Even when running?" She observed, eyeing my attire with calculated curiosity. "Aren't you hot in that?"

I actually was. The light jacket I wore was uncomfortable for running but necessity outweighed comfort. "I get cold easily." I lied.

Catra laughed, the sound sharp in the quiet park. "Sure you do." She stepped closer, her eyes narrowing. "You're full of convenient little stories, aren't you?"

"I don't know what you're talking about." I said, maintaining my cover despite the frustration building inside me. "And I really don't understand why you've made it your mission to make my life difficult."

"Because you're annoying." She replied bluntly. "Everything about you is... off. The way you pretend to be this perfect, polite exchange student while clearly hiding something. The way everyone immediately loves you despite your obvious fakeness." Her voice took on a harder edge. "The way you waltz into my classes and act like you belong here."

"Last I checked, tuition payments were the only requirement for belonging at Brightfall University." I countered, my patience

wearing thin. "Not your personal approval."

"Cute." She sneered. "Real cute. You think you can just show up mid-semester and immediately fit in? Some of us have worked for years to get where we are."

Something in her tone caught my attention, a hint of genuine resentment beneath the practiced disdain. Was that what this was about? She saw me as some kind of threat to her position?

Before I could process this, Catra continued. "Let me guess, you'll be at the festival this weekend, soaking up our culture like the perfect tourist? Taking cute photos for your American friends?"

"Actually, I'm going with Entrapta." I said, not sure why I was bothering to engage. "She asked me to be her date."

Something flashed in Catra's eyes, surprise maybe, or something else I couldn't identify. "Entrapta? The weird tech girl? That's... fitting, I suppose. Two misfits together."

Her dismissive tone sparked a protective anger in me. Entrapta was brilliant and kind, even if she was socially awkward, she didn't deserve Catra's contempt.

"At least she's genuine." I shot back. "Unlike some people who build their entire personality around being mean to others."

Catra's eyes widened slightly, then narrowed again. "You don't know the first thing about me."

"I know enough." I said, stepping closer until we were only inches apart. I had several inches of height on her, forcing her to look up to maintain eye contact. "I know Dr. Moon announced yesterday that my midterm paper scored five points higher than yours. The first time you haven't had the top grade."

It was a low blow but after weeks of her targeted harassment, I couldn't resist the opportunity to throw her off balance. Dr. Moon had indeed announced the top scores, though not by name but

the way Catra had glared daggers at me afterward made it clear she knew exactly who had bested her.

Catra's face flushed with anger, her jaw tightening. "You got lucky." She hissed. "And if you think one paper means anything-"

"It means maybe you should spend less time obsessing over me and more time on your own work." I interrupted, surprising myself with the directness of my challenge. Weeks of restraint had finally reached their limit.

For a moment, Catra seemed genuinely speechless, her mismatched eyes wide with shock at my sudden confrontation. I used her momentary stillness to step around her and resume running, not looking back even when I heard her shout after me.

"This isn't over, Adora!"

I picked up my pace, putting distance between us, my heart pounding from more than just physical exertion. That confrontation had felt dangerously satisfying. Like landing a perfect punch in the ring. I'd spent weeks being the polite, somewhat naïve exchange student and in one impulsive moment. I'd shown a flash of the competitive fighter beneath.

As I ran through the darkening park, I couldn't shake the memory of Catra's expression when I'd challenged her, surprise yes, but also something that looked almost like... respect? Interest? Whatever it was, I had a feeling our dynamic had just shifted in ways I couldn't predict.

And with the festival looming tomorrow, where the entire town would be gathered in close quarters, celebrating long into the night. I wondered if I'd just made a serious tactical error in my carefully planned reinvention of myself. Too late now. The gauntlet had been thrown down and knowing Catra, she wouldn't back away from the challenge.

The Harvest Moon Festival transformed Brightfall completely. Streets I'd come to know over the past weeks were now

unrecognizable, strung with lanterns, lined with colorful stalls, and filled with the aromas of traditional foods and the sounds of music and laughter. The entire town seemed to pulse with energy beneath the full autumn moon.

I stood in front of my mirror, scrutinizing my appearance with uncharacteristic attention to detail. After Glimmer's insistent texts that festival night required ‘actual effort and not just your usual hoodies.’ I'd dug through my closet for something appropriate.

I'd settled on a crisp navy button-up shirt with subtle silver threading, formal enough for the occasion while still providing the long sleeves I needed. I paired it with tailored gray pants that were significantly more fitted than my usual baggy attire and leather shoes rather than my everyday sneakers. After some deliberation, I'd left my hair down instead of pulling it back into my usual ponytail, the blonde waves falling just past my shoulders.

I'd even applied light makeup, something I rarely bothered. The subtle enhancements made my blue eyes seem more vivid against my skin.

The overall effect was... different. Without the intentionally oversized clothes hiding my physique, the outline of my athletic build was clearly visible, the breadth of my shoulders, the narrowness of my waist, the definition in my arms even beneath the fabric. I looked more like myself, like She-Ra than I had in weeks.

Was it too much? Would it draw unwanted attention? I considered changing back into something safer, more concealing but a text from Entrapta interrupted my overthinking.

PUNCTUALITY ALERT! MEETING TIME IN 17 MINUTES. CURRENT LOCATION TRACKING INDICATES YOU HAVE NOT LEFT YOUR RESIDENCE.

I smiled at her characteristic directness and decided to stick with my current outfit. One night wouldn't unravel everything.

"Wow, you look... different." Mom observed as I came downstairs. "In a good way!" She added quickly. "It's nice to see you dressing like yourself again."

Dad glanced up from where he was reading festival brochures at the kitchen table. "You look lovely sweetheart. Planning to stay out late?"

"Not too late." I said automatically, though I wasn't sure I believed it. "Just meeting friends to see the main events."

"Well, the lantern release is at midnight, and that's the highlight." He said with a knowing smile. "When we lived here before you used to beg to stay up for it, remember?"

I did, memories of sitting on his shoulders as a child, watching thousands of paper lanterns float into the night sky like earthbound stars seeking to rejoin the heavens. "Maybe I'll stay for that." I conceded.

The walk to University Square, our designated meeting point, gave me my first real taste of the festival atmosphere. Families strolled together, children ran with sparklers trailing light through the evening air, and elderly couples walked arm in arm, pointing out how celebrations had changed or stayed the same over the decades.

I spotted my friends gathered near the central fountain, which had been decorated with floating candles and flower petals for the occasion. Bow saw me first, his eyes widening comically as he elbowed Glimmer and pointed in my direction.

"Adora?" Glimmer's jaw actually dropped. "Is that YOU?"

I tugged self-consciously at my sleeves. "Too much?"

"TOO MUCH? YOU'RE STATISTICALLY IN THE TOP 1.7% OF HUMAN AESTHETIC PRESENTATION TONIGHT!" Entrapta practically shouted, her scientific assessment somehow more flattering than conventional compliments. She herself had made an effort for the occasion, her purple hair elaborately braided and adorned with tiny glowing lights that twinkled when she moved.

"Seriously, you look amazing!" Bow agreed. He was dressed in a traditional Brightfall formal jacket, open at the chest in a way that somehow managed to be both respectful of tradition and slightly daring. Next to him, Glimmer sparkled in a lavender dress with iridescent accents that caught the festival lights.

"We just didn't know you were hiding all... that... under your usual clothes." Glimmer gestured vaguely at my entire body, making me laugh despite my nerves.

"I clean up okay I guess." I shrugged, trying to downplay their reactions.

"UNDERSTATEMENT DETECTED!" Entrapta announced, looping her arm through mine with surprising confidence. "As your official festival date, I calculate a 94.3% probability that I will need to deter unwanted attention from others attempting to claim your company."

Her serious expression made us all laugh, breaking the moment of awkwardness. As we made our way into the heart of the festival, I gradually relaxed. The night was about enjoyment.

The festival exceeded all expectations. We watched traditional dance performances in the University Square, sampled foods from dozens of stalls along the main boulevard and cheered for Entrapta when she won a robotics competition at the technology showcase. Bow convinced us to try a traditional folk game involving ribbons and poles that left us all breathless with laughter and tangled together in a colorful mess.

"This is what I've needed." I realized as we wandered through the night market near the harbor later that evening. Tonight, surrounded by friends and the collective joy of the festival, I felt lighter.

Glimmer and Bow had disappeared earlier for their ‘culturally significant’ boat ride, returning with suspiciously bright eyes and interlaced fingers that suggested they'd finally acknowledged what everyone else had seen for weeks.

"EMPIRICAL EVIDENCE SUGGESTS SUCCESSFUL ROMANTIC ADVANCEMENT!" Entrapta observed when they rejoined us, making them both blush furiously.

As midnight approached, the crowds began moving toward Harbor Park for the lantern release. The four of us found a good spot on a grassy hill overlooking the water, where thousands of unlit paper lanterns waited to be released.

"This is my favorite part." Bow said softly, looking out over the gathering crowd. "Everyone together, sending their hopes into the sky."

"The combined thermal effect of thousands of simultaneously lit lanterns creates fascinating air current patterns." Entrapta added, though her usual scientific detachment was softened by genuine wonder.

Volunteers moved through the crowd, distributing lanterns and small candles to light them. When we each held one, Glimmer explained the tradition.

"You're supposed to whisper your deepest wish or hope to the lantern before releasing it." She said. "The higher it flies, the more likely your wish will come true."

"That's not scientifically accurate." Entrapta began, then caught herself. "But it's a lovely metaphor for collective aspiration!"

As midnight neared, a hush fell over the gathered crowd. Somewhere, a gong sounded, deep and resonant. At this signal, thousands of tiny flames sparked to life as people lit their lanterns. The effect was breathtaking, darkness gradually replaced by a warm, golden glow that illuminated faces from below.

I lit my lantern, watching the paper slowly inflate with warm air. What should I wish for? Professional comeback? Healing? Success in my new life? After a moment's reflection, I whispered something simpler, more honest: "Freedom to just be myself."

A second gong sounded and as one, the crowd released their lanterns. The sight was indescribable, thousands of glowing lights rising into the night sky, illuminating the darkness like a galaxy being born. I watched mine ascend, carried higher and higher until it was indistinguishable among the multitude.

"It's beautiful." I whispered, unexpectedly moved.

"Yeah." Glimmer agreed, her head on Bow's shoulder. "Worth staying up for, right?"

I nodded, realizing I'd completely forgotten my intention to leave early. The night had passed in a blur of new experiences and genuine joy. Something I hadn't felt in far too long.

"We should celebrate!" Bow suggested as the crowd began to disperse, the lanterns now distant specks of light over the ocean. "The Silver Moon is open late for the festival. Best cocktails in Brightfall."

"I don't know..." I hesitated, aware that alcohol might not mix well.

"SOCIAL BONDING OPPORTUNITY!" Entrapta declared. "Plus, they have those tiny umbrellas in the drinks. TINY UMBRELLAS ADORA!"

Her enthusiasm was contagious and the night had gone so perfectly that I found myself agreeing. "One drink." I conceded.

"Then I really should head home."

The Silver Moon was packed with festivalgoers, the atmosphere electric with post-lantern euphoria. Somehow Bow managed to secure us a corner table, and soon we were sampling the bar's famous moonlight cocktails. Each glowing faintly blue from some ingredient I couldn't identify.

"To new friends!" Glimmer proposed, raising her glass. "And to Adora who finally learned there's life beyond hoodies!"

We clinked glasses, laughing and I felt a surge of affection for these people who had so quickly become important to me. The pleasant buzz from the cocktail loosened something in me, making it easier to laugh, to share stories, to be present in a way I rarely allowed myself.

One drink turned into two and our table grew louder and more animated. Bow recounted embarrassing stories from his and Glimmer's childhood, Entrapta demonstrated her ability to tie cherry stems into knots using her mouth and I found myself relaxing into the moment.

I was mid-laugh at something Glimmer said when the atmosphere at our table suddenly shifted. My friends' eyes focused on something behind me, their expressions falling. Before I could turn to look, a familiar raspy voice cut through the ambient noise of the bar.

"Well well. Look who finally came out of hiding."

I turned to find Catra standing behind me, her appearance momentarily stealing my ability to form a coherent response. She wore a deep burgundy suit that hugged her slender frame perfectly, the jacket cropped to reveal a glimpse of midriff, the matching pants slim-fitting and ending just above ankle boots with a slight heel. Her hair fell in waves around her face, and subtle makeup emphasized those striking mismatched eyes.

Chapter 4: Shots all around

"Didn't know they let children into bars." Glimmer shot at Catra, her cheeks flushed either from the cocktails or irritation, possibly both.

Catra smirked, ignoring Glimmer to focus on me. "Well, well. America finally learned how to dress." Her gaze traveled deliberately from my face down to my outfit and back up again, the assessment so thorough it felt almost physical. "Though I'm surprised you're able to stay vertical after what, three drinks? Do they even have alcohol over there or is it all just green juice and protein shakes?"

"Why don't you go bother someone else?" Bow suggested, his usual friendliness strained. "There's plenty of bar space elsewhere."

"INTERPERSONAL HOSTILITY DETECTED!" Entrapta announced, looking between our groups. "FASCINATING TERRITORIAL DISPLAY BEHAVIOR!"

Catra opened her mouth for what would undoubtedly be another cutting remark when a booming voice cut through the tension.

"EVERYONE TOGETHER!" A large man in festival staff attire was standing on a chair near the bar, waving enthusiastically. "Silver Moon tradition! At one A.M., all barriers come down! We celebrate as one Brightfall family!"

Cheers erupted throughout the bar as staff began pushing tables together, creating long communal seating areas. Before any of us could protest, our table was being merged with the one beside us, which happened to be where Catra's group had been heading.

"You've got to be kidding me." Glimmer muttered as bar staff cheerfully encouraged us all to squeeze together.

Through some cosmic joke of seating arrangements, I found myself directly next to Catra, our shoulders almost touching in the newly crowded space. She looked as pleased about this development as I felt.

"Don't worry, princess." She murmured, just loud enough for me to hear. "I don't bite. Unless you ask nicely."

I felt heat rise to my cheeks, unsure if it was from irritation or something else I didn't want to examine. "I'm surprised you're participating in something so communal." I replied. "Doesn't playing nice with others ruin your reputation?"

"Festival tradition." she shrugged, reaching for her drink. "I even respect some things about Brightfall."

A server appeared, setting down trays of shot glasses filled with a clear liquid that glowed faintly purple under the bar lights.

"Moonshine shots!" The enthusiastic staff member announced. "Festival special! One for everyone!"

I eyed the glowing liquid suspiciously. "What exactly is in this?"

"Afraid you can't handle it America?" Catra challenged, her mismatched eyes gleaming with mischief. She picked up a shot glass and held it aloft. "Or do they not teach you how to hold your liquor across the Pacific?"

Something about her smug expression triggered the competitive streak I normally kept carefully contained. Without breaking eye contact, I picked up my own glass. "I can handle anything you can."

A slow smile spread across her face. "Is that a challenge?"

"If you need it spelled out sure." I replied, the cocktails I'd already consumed loosening my usual caution.

Around us, conversation had resumed, our friends awkwardly attempting civility while throwing concerned glances our way. But Catra and I remained locked in our own private standoff.

"First one to back down loses," she proposed, voice low enough that only I could hear. "and I never lose."

"There's a first time for everything." I countered, raising my glass slightly.

Without further ceremony, we both downed our shots. The liquid burned pleasantly, leaving a sweet aftertaste that reminded me of honey and something floral.

"Another." Catra called to a passing server, not breaking eye contact with me.

"Catra…" Scorpia's concerned voice came from across the table. "Maybe we should slow down? Remember last festival when you-"

"Another." Catra repeated firmly, silencing her friend with a look.

Two more glowing shots appeared before us. Without hesitation, we drank these as well.

"Not bad for an exchange student." Catra conceded, her voice taking on the slightest hint of warmth. "Most foreigners can't handle traditional moonshine."

"I'm full of surprises." I replied, feeling the alcohol's pleasant heat spreading through my body.

"So I'm discovering." She murmured, studying me with unexpected intensity.

The next hour passed in a competitive blur. Each shot was followed by another challenge, another exchange of barbs that somehow began to feel less hostile and more... playful? Around us, our respective friend groups had grudgingly begun to intermingle. Entrapta deep in conversation with Scorpia about

exoskeleton engineering, Bow diplomatically mediating between Glimmer and Perfuma about some campus policy dispute.

But Catra and I remained in our own bubble of escalating challenges and surprisingly personal questions.

"Why do you always wear long sleeves?" She asked after our fifth or was it sixth? shot. "Even when you run. Even tonight."

The alcohol made me bolder but not reckless. "I get cold easily."

"Liar." She said, but there was no malice in her tone, only curiosity. "What are you hiding?"

"Why do you care?" I countered, genuinely curious.

She considered this for a moment, her gaze unexpectedly thoughtful. "You're different. You don't... react to me like others do."

"You mean I don't cower when you're mean?"

"That," she acknowledged with a slight nod, "and you don't try to use me for my connections either. Everyone wants something from me."

"Maybe I just want you to leave me alone." I suggested, though the words lacked conviction even to my own ears.

Catra laughed, the sound surprisingly genuine. "No you don't. You'd be bored without me to fight with."

Before I could argue, another round of shots arrived, these glowing blue instead of purple.

"The midnight special." the server explained. "Strongest in the house. Not for the faint of heart."

Catra raised an eyebrow in silent challenge. I knew I should stop, the alcohol was already making it harder to maintain my careful

barriers and my tongue felt dangerously loose. But backing down from Catra felt impossible.

We clinked glasses and drank. The blue liquid was substantially stronger than the previous shots, burning all the way down and leaving me slightly light-headed.

"Tell me something true Adora," Catra said suddenly, her voice softer than I'd ever heard it. "One real thing about yourself."

The request caught me off guard. Perhaps it was the alcohol lowering my defenses, or the strange intimacy that had developed between us over the course of our drinking competition, but something inside me snapped. All the weeks of her targeted harassment, her digging into my past, her constant needling. It all bubbled to the surface at once.

"You want something true?" I said, my voice low but intense. "Fine. I don't like you Catra. I think you're a bitch who gets off on making other people miserable because you can't stand the idea that not everyone worships the ground you walk on."

Her eyes widened, those mismatched irises reflecting shock at my bluntness.

I wasn't finished. "You think you're so clever, trying to figure me out, digging into my past. But guess what? You'll never know more about me than I choose to let you see. The only people who get to know the real me are my actual friends. People who care about me, not people obsessed with proving I don't belong here." I leaned closer, the alcohol making me reckless. "So you can just fuck off with your questions and your theories."

For a moment, Catra looked genuinely stunned, as if no one had ever spoken to her that way before. Then her expression hardened, her jaw clenching visibly.

"At least I'm honest about being a bitch." She fired back, eyes flashing. "Not hiding behind some fake, perfect exchange student

persona. You think I can't tell when someone's lying about who they are? It's written all over you Adora."

She signaled for another round, practically snatching the glasses from the server. "Here's to honesty." She said with bitter sarcasm, pushing a shot toward me.

I shouldn't have taken it. I'd already had far more than I'd planned, and my filter was dangerously compromised. But backing down from Catra still felt impossible.

We drank in tense silence, the momentary connection we'd been building shattered by my outburst. Around us, I vaguely registered that our table had thinned considerably. Glimmer and Bow had already left, Bow giving me a concerned look and making me promise to text when I got home safely. Entrapta was deep in conversation with Scorpia at the far end of the table, apparently oblivious to the tension between Catra and me. The rest of Catra's crew had dispersed to other parts of the bar or headed home.

"Why do you even care who I really am?" I asked after another uncomfortable silence.

Catra studied her empty glass, avoiding my eyes. "I don't." She insisted, though something in her tone suggested otherwise. "I just hate fakes. And you're the fakest person I've ever met."

"You don't know anything about me." I said, feeling suddenly tired.

"Whose fault is that?" She shot back. Another round appeared, these shots a dangerous-looking red. I didn't remember ordering them but Catra must have signaled the server again.

"To secrets." She said mockingly, raising her glass.

Against my better judgment, I drank again. The red liquid was even stronger than the blue, and I felt the room tilt slightly as I set the glass down.

"I'm not hiding anything important." I lied, the words feeling thick on my tongue. "You're just making things up because you can't stand not being the center of attention."

"And you're deflecting because you can't handle being called out on your bullshit," Catra retorted, her words beginning to slur slightly. "What's under those sleeves, Adora? What are you so afraid of people seeing?"

"None of your business." I snapped.

"Are you arms like super ugly?" She pressed, leaning forward unsteadily. "Or is it just that you've got muscles that don't let anyone see?"

Her accuracy, even while drunk, was unsettling. I changed the subject. "Why don't you have any real friends, Catra? Even the people who follow you around look afraid of you."

That hit a nerve. Her expression flickered, vulnerability showing for just a moment before her mask of disdain returned. "I have plenty of friends."

"You have followers. It's not the same thing."

"At least I'm not pretending to be something I'm not." She said, but the bite had gone out of her voice, replaced with something that sounded almost like weariness.

I'm not sure how much time passed as we continued our verbal sparring, punctuated by increasingly unwise rounds of shots. The bar had begun to empty, festival-goers finally succumbing to exhaustion after the long day of celebration. Even Entrapta and Scorpia had left at some point, Entrapta giving me a concerned look and offering to stay, which I'd waved off with false confidence in my sobriety.

Eventually, the bartender approached our table. "Last call, ladies. We're closing in fifteen minutes."

I blinked in surprise, looking around the now mostly empty bar. When had everyone left? I checked my phone, 3:27 AM. I had missed calls from Glimmer and texts from Bow asking if I was okay.

Across from me, Catra looked as surprised as I felt by the time. "Shit." She muttered, attempting to stand and swaying dangerously. She grabbed the edge of the table to steady herself. "Didn't realize it was so late."

I stood up with only slightly more grace, the room spinning briefly before settling. "We should go."

"Brilliant deduction genius." She slurred, taking a step and nearly stumbling. She caught herself against a chair, looking frustrated by her own unsteadiness.

Despite my anger at her, despite everything she'd said and done over the past weeks, I couldn't just leave her there. We lived in the same direction, and she was clearly in no state to get home safely alone.

"Come on." I sighed, moving to her side. "I'll help you get home."

"I don't need your help." She protested, even as she leaned heavily against me.

"Sure you don't." I replied, my own words not entirely clear. "But we're going the same way, and I'm not leaving you here to pass out in the gutter."

Outside, the festival had long since wound down. The streets were quiet, lanterns still hanging but no longer lit, abandoned food stalls awaiting morning cleanup. The air had cooled considerably and I felt Catra shiver beside me.

"Where do you live?" I asked, supporting more of her weight than I think she realized.

"Crescent Heights Apartments." She mumbled. "By the bus stop."

I nodded, remembering where she'd gotten off the bus that day. It was on my way home, about a fifteen-minute walk in our current state.

After a few stumbling steps, it became clear that our side-by-side arrangement wasn't working. Catra could barely stay upright, and I wasn't much more stable trying to support her while maintaining my own balance.

"This isn't working." I said, stopping under a streetlight. "Here, get on my back."

"What? No way!" She protested.

"It's this or I call you a cab." I said firmly. "And I don't think either of us wants to wait around for that."

She looked like she wanted to argue more but was too exhausted and drunk to formulate a good objection. With a defeated sigh, she moved behind me as I crouched slightly.

"If you tell anyone about this, I'll end you." She muttered as she climbed awkwardly onto my back.

Despite my own intoxication, carrying Catra wasn't difficult. Years of boxing training had given me substantial upper body strength, and she was surprisingly light. I hooked my arms under her legs and straightened, adjusting to balance her weight.

"You're stronger than you look." She observed, her voice close to my ear, her breath warm against my neck.

"Thanks." I said dryly, starting to walk. The piggyback position was actually easier to maintain than trying to support her from the side and I found my balance improving as we made our way through the quiet streets.

For several minutes, we moved in silence. Catra was unusually subdued, her earlier antagonism seemingly exhausted along with her physical energy.

"Why are you helping me?" She asked finally, her voice quiet and lacking its usual edge. "After everything I've said and done?"

I considered the question as we passed under another streetlight, its glow casting long shadows ahead of us. "Because it's the right thing to do." I said eventually. "And because maybe I'm not as fake as you think I am."

She was quiet for a long moment. "I don't actually think you're fake." She admitted, so softly I almost didn't hear her. "I think you're hiding something, but... that's not the same thing."

The unexpected honesty caught me off guard. "Everyone hides parts of themselves, Catra. Even you."

She didn't respond immediately, and for a moment I wondered if she'd fallen asleep. Then I felt her adjust her position slightly, her arms tightening around my shoulders.

"I'm not always a bitch, you know." She said finally. "I just... it's easier that way. People expect it from me."

"Why does that matter? What people expect?"

She laughed softly, the sound unexpectedly genuine. "Says the girl who's been pretending to be someone else since she arrived."

I couldn't argue with that. We lapsed back into silence as I continued walking, the weight of her against my back strangely comforting in the quiet night.

As we approached her apartment building, I felt a strange reluctance to reach our destination. Something about this moment, the honesty that only seemed possible in the liminal space between night and morning, between sobriety and drunkenness felt important.

"This is me." She said as we reached the modern glass entrance of Crescent Heights. "You can put me down now."

I crouched to let her slide off my back, steadying her as her feet touched the ground. She swayed slightly but remained upright, looking at me with an unreadable expression.

"Thanks." she said, the word sounding unfamiliar from her lips. "For not leaving me there."

"You're welcome." I replied, unsure what else to say.

We stood there awkwardly for a moment, the alcohol still buzzing in my system making everything feel slightly surreal.

"Can you get up to your apartment okay?" I asked, suddenly concerned about her navigating stairs or an elevator in her state.

"I'm not that drunk." She insisted, though she still leaned slightly against the building's entrance for support.

"Right…" I said skeptically. "Well... goodnight."

I turned to leave, but her voice stopped me.

"Hey." I looked back to find her watching me with an intensity that seemed at odds with her intoxicated state.

"Tomorrow," she said, "when we're sober… you won't say anything will you?"

The question took me by surprise. "Why would I?"

A small, enigmatic smile played at the corners of her mouth. "I don't know. I can’t figure you out. That's what makes you so... interesting."

As she turned toward her building, she suddenly lost her balance, stumbling forward. I moved quickly, catching her before she could fall.

"Whoa, careful." I said, my arm around her waist steadying her.

"Maybe I'm a little drunker than I thought." She admitted, the confession clearly difficult for her.

I sighed, knowing I couldn't just leave her like this. "Come on, I'll help you inside."

She didn't protest this time as I supported her weight, guiding her through the entrance and into the elegant lobby. The night doorman barely glanced up from his book, apparently accustomed to festival revelers returning at odd hours.

"Which floor?" I asked as we approached the elevator.

"Seventh." She mumbled, fumbling in her pocket for a key card.

The elevator ride was silent, Catra leaning heavily against the wall while I tried to ignore how the small space seemed to amplify her presence. When we reached her floor, she directed me to apartment 714 at the end of a carpeted hallway.

"Key?" I prompted when we reached her door.

She handed it over with surprising trust, her usual defensive barriers seemingly dissolved by exhaustion and alcohol. I unlocked the door and helped her inside, my eyes adjusting to the darkness as I searched for a light switch.

The soft glow revealed a stylish apartment that somehow both did and didn't match what I'd expected, modern furniture with clean lines but also unexpected touches like a collection of vintage vinyl records and several thriving houseplants. It was tidy but lived-in, with textbooks stacked on a coffee table and a throw blanket carelessly tossed across a sleek sofa.

"Couch or Bedroom?" I asked, still supporting much of her weight.

She gestured vaguely towards the main living area. I guided her there, setting her down on the couch.

"Here you go." I said, helping her sit on the edge. "You should drink some water before you sleep."

Catra slumps on the couch and tells me where the water is.

I try to hand Catra the glass as she pushes herself up, swaying as she reaches for it. Her hand catches the rim of the cup and it tips. I yelped as i felt the cold splash across my chest, soaking my shirt.

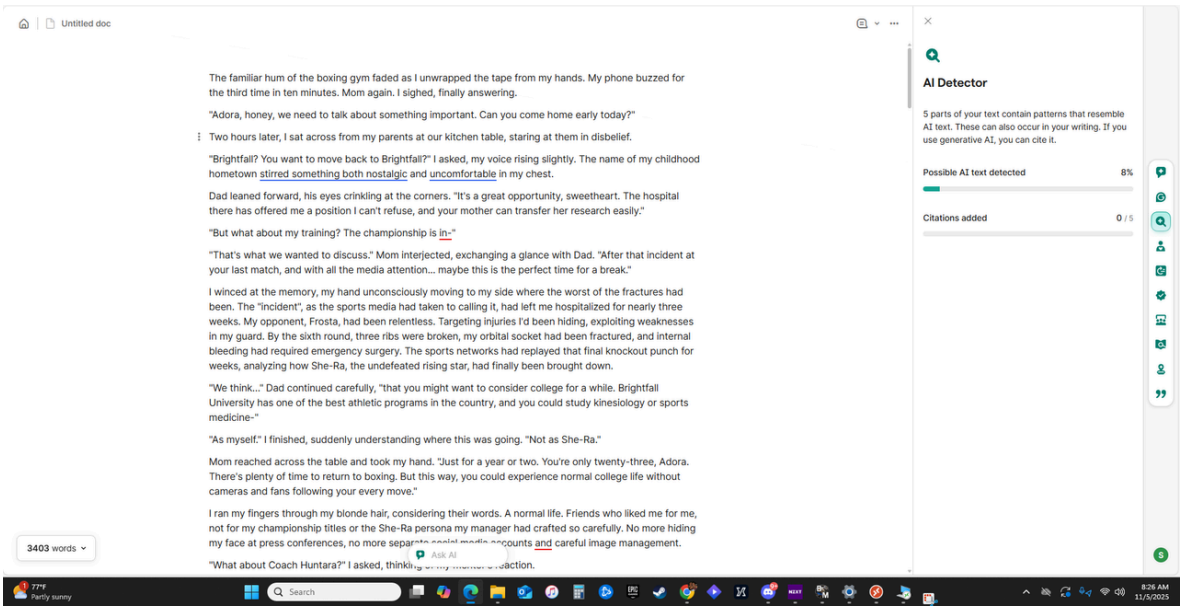
"I- Shit! I didn't mean to-" Catra started to say as she stumbled over one of the pillows and before either of us can react she slams into me and we both go down, hitting the floor. All I could feel was Catras body on top of mine and her breath in the crook of my neck. I had to contain the fluttered and other unfamiliar feelings developing in my stomach as i felt her warmth. I grab her shoulders and push her up. "Hey you okay?"

For a suspended second we simply stare at each other. I saw Catra's eyes dilate and go hazy. I was about to speak up when her fingers find my collar and yank me toward her. She kisses me, fierce and hungry. And the world narrows to that press of lips and the shock of her actions.

Chapter 5: ** For all thos saying this is AI**

Chapter Summary

For the comments saying AI generated this. Here is this posted in an IA Finder and the results. Yes a few sentences are but 98% is not.



Chapter 6: A Line Crossed (And Erased)

For a heartbeat, I'm too stunned to respond. Then something inside me ignites. A heat that rushes through my veins and short-circuits all rational thought. My hands move from her shoulders to her back, pulling her closer instead of pushing her away. I kiss her back with equal fervor.

The kiss deepens, becoming something neither of us seems prepared for. Her fingers tangle in my hair, while her other hand slides between us, pressing against my stomach where my wet shirt clings to my skin. I feel her pause momentarily as her palm traces the defined lines of muscle there. A discovery that seems to surprise her. Her touch lingers, fingers exploring what I've kept hidden beneath loose clothing all these weeks.

Then, as if we both suddenly realize what we're doing, we push apart simultaneously, breaking contact with such force that we end up several feet apart, both breathing hard. "What the hell?" Catra gasps, her eyes wide with shock.

We stare at each other across her living room floor, the moment stretched taut between us like a wire about to snap. The only sound is our ragged breathing and the distant ticking of a clock, marking seconds that feel like hours. Catra looks as bewildered as I feel, her carefully constructed persona shattered completely. In its place is something raw and unguarded. Her mismatched eyes wide, lips slightly swollen from our kiss, hair disheveled where my fingers had tangled in it.

"No." she whispers, the word more plea than statement. "This didn't happen." Her voice is unsteady, almost trembling, as if she's trying to convince herself more than me.

"Right." I agree quickly, though something molten and primal is swirling in my chest, threatening to consume every rational thought. My body still hums with the echo of her touch, betraying my words. "We drank too much. This was a mistake."

"A big mistake." she emphasizes, but her eyes drop to my lips as she says it, lingering there with an intensity that contradicts everything coming out of her mouth. Her fingers flex at her sides, as if remembering the feel of my skin beneath them.

"Huge." I nod, fighting the inexplicable gravitational pull urging me to cross the distance between us again. My heart pounds so loudly I'm certain she can hear it across the room.

We fall into charged silence, the air between us thick enough to cut with a knife. Every nerve ending in my body remains painfully aware of her presence, as if the atoms in the room have rearranged themselves around this new reality where we've crossed a line that can never be uncrossed.

"I should go..." I say eventually, pushing myself to my feet with as much dignity as I can muster. My shirt is still damp from the spilled water, clinging uncomfortably to my skin in a way that makes me acutely self-conscious. I cross my arms over my chest, a protective gesture I can't help.

Catra's gaze follows the movement, lingering on my arms for a moment too long before she looks away, her cheeks flushing slightly. "Yeah..." she agrees, getting up as well, though with less steadiness than me. "Probably for the best."

I move toward the door, at the threshold I pause, looking back at her. "Um..." I say, not sure what I'm trying to say.

She meets my eyes, and for a moment, her expression is completely unguarded. Confused, vulnerable and maybe even a little afraid. "Just go." She says softly. "Please."

I nod once and slip out the door, closing it quietly behind me. The hallway feels too bright, too real after the dreamlike quality of what just happened in her apartment. I lean against the wall for a moment, waiting for the world to stop spinning. Whether from the alcohol or the kiss, I'm not sure which.

The walk home is a blur, my mind replaying the moment over and over, analyzing every detail. The way she looked at me just before she pulled me toward her. The softness of her lips despite the fierce pressure of the kiss. The small sound she made when I pulled her closer.

By the time I reach my house, the sky is beginning to lighten with the first hints of dawn. I let myself in quietly, hoping not to wake my parents. In my room, I peel off my damp clothes and pull on a tank top and shorts.

I collapse onto my bed, staring at the ceiling. Sleep feels impossible with my thoughts racing and my body still humming with the memory of her touch. Yet exhaustion pulls at me, dragging me toward unconsciousness despite my churning mind.

My last thought before sleep claims me is a troubling realization: For all the fights, for all the antagonism, for all the ways Catra has tried to make my life difficult since I arrived at Brightfall, that kiss was still a mistake. One I can't afford to repeat if I want to maintain the peace of being a normal student.

"So she just... passed out? And you took her home and left? She didn't like try to murder you for helping her... did she?" Glimmer's skepticism is palpable as she stirs her coffee, eyeing me over the rim of her mug.

It's Monday morning, two days after the festival, and I'm sitting in the campus cafe with my friends before our first class. My hangover has mostly subsided, replaced by a strange nervous energy that has me constantly scanning the room, hoping not to see a familiar pair of mismatched eyes.

"That's it." I confirm, keeping my voice casual. "I wasn't going to leave her there barely able to walk, even if she is the worst person on campus."

"Your pulse INCREASES by 12.3% every time you mention her." Entrapta announces, peering at me over her tablet where she's apparently been monitoring... what? My vital signs? "FASCINATING PHYSIOLOGICAL RESPONSE."

"It's called annoyance Entrapta." I say dryly. "She's been making my life miserable for weeks. Having to carry her drunk self home wasn't exactly the highlight of my festival experience."

"Well, I think it was nice of you." Bow says, ever the peacemaker. "Even if Catra's been nothing but mean to you, making sure she got home safe was the right thing to do."

"Right thing to do maybe BUT, It was your fault it got there. The amount of alcohol in you-"

"So!" I interrupt Entrapta before she can continue her analysis. "Midterms are coming up. Should we organize a study session?"

The change of subject works, thankfully. Glimmer immediately launches into scheduling options, pulling out her color-coded planner while Bow suggests potential locations. I nod along, contributing occasionally while my mind wanders back to Catra's apartment, to that moment of weakness.

I'm still angry with myself for letting it happen. The alcohol is only a partial excuse. I should have had better control. The last thing I need is any kind of complication with Catra, of all people. She's been nothing but a thorn in my side since day one, and one drunken kiss doesn't change that.

"Adora? Did you hear me?" Glimmer's voice pulls me back to the present.

"Sorry, what?"

"I said, does Wednesday evening work for our first study session? My place at seven?"

"Oh, yeah. Sounds perfect!" I nod, gathering my things as we prepare to head to our respective morning classes.

Outside the cafe, Bow gives me a concerned look. "You sure you're okay? You seem... distracted."

"I'm fine." I assure him with what I hope is a convincing smile. "Just thinking about all the midterm prep I need to do."

He doesn't look entirely convinced but doesn't push the issue. "Well, if you need to talk about anything, we're here. You know that right?"

The sincerity in his voice makes my chest tight with gratitude. These people have become real friends, perhaps the first genuine friendships I've had in years and I'm determined not to let anything complicate that.

"I know. Thanks Bow."

We part ways, heading to different buildings. My first two classes pass in a haze of anxiety and anticipation. I take notes mechanically, barely registering the content of the lectures, my stomach twisting tighter as the clock inches toward my Cultural Studies class.

I decide on a strategy: I'll be professional but distant. Nothing happened. We'll focus on our project, maintain cold civility, and never speak of that night again. It's the only way forward.

When my second class ends, I find Glimmer, Bow and Entrapta waiting outside the building to walk with me to Cultural Studies. Our only shared class this semester.

"So I was thinking for the midterm review," Glimmer says as we make our way across campus, "we should focus on the comparative analysis methodology Professor Netossa keeps emphasizing. I'm pretty sure that's going to be a major portion of the exam."

"And the localized versus globalized cultural framework." Bow adds. "She mentioned that in every lecture so far."

"THE STATISTICAL RECURRENCE OF SPECIFIC TERMINOLOGIES SUGGESTS A 92.7% PROBABILITY OF THEIR INCLUSION ON THE EXAMINATION," Entrapta confirms, not looking up from whatever data she's analyzing on her tablet.

We reach the Humanities building and pause outside our classroom door, continuing the conversation about study plans. I'm mid-sentence explaining a concept I think will be important when I sense a shift in the atmosphere. A sudden tension in my friends' postures, Glimmer's eyes widening slightly as she looks past my shoulder.

I don't need to turn to know who's approaching. I can feel her presence like an oncoming storm.

"Move." Comes the familiar raspy command from behind me.

I turn slowly, steeling myself. Catra stands a few feet away, looking every bit her usual self, hair artfully tousled, clothes stylish yet edgy, expression set in its customary blend of boredom and disdain.

"The hallway is public space Catra." Glimmer starts but I touch her arm lightly, shaking my head. The last thing I want is a scene.

Our group parts silently, creating a path to the door. Catra walks through without making eye contact with any of us, though I notice a momentary hesitation in her stride as she passes close to me, so brief it might have been my imagination.

"Someone woke up on the wrong side of the bed..." Bow mutters as she disappears into the classroom.

"Some things never change." Glimmer agrees with an eye roll. "Anyway, we should head in. See you both after class?"

I nod, suddenly finding it difficult to form words. Bow and Glimmer enter the classroom, but Entrapta lingers, studying me with unnerving intensity.

"Your cortisol level appear elevated." She observes quietly.

"It's nothing." I insist, irritation creeping into my voice. "Just dreading another thrilling session of her undermining everything I say about our project."

Entrapta tilts her head, clearly unconvinced, but mercifully doesn't pursue the topic further. "I'll collect additional observational data during class." She says instead, which isn't particularly reassuring.

Taking a deep breath, I follow her into the classroom. The only available seats are near the front, not far from where Catra sits alone at a two-person desk, the same desk where we've been working on our cultural identity project for weeks.

I hesitate for just a moment before making my decision. Being professional means maintaining routine, even uncomfortable ones. I say goodbye to Bow, Glimmer, and Entrapta, who take seats on the opposite side of the room, then walk deliberately toward Catra.

She doesn't look up as I slide into the chair beside her, though I notice her posture stiffen slightly. I pull out my notebook and pen, arranging them on the desk with more care than necessary, keeping as much distance between us as the small desk allows.

"I did some research for our project over the weekend." I say, my voice cool and detached. "Found some interesting articles on cultural displacement in educational settings."

For a long moment, I think she might ignore me entirely. Then, without looking at me, she replies, "I started the outline for the next section. It's in my notes."

Her voice betrays nothing. No awkwardness, no acknowledgment of our last encounter. In fact, she's acting remarkably... normal.

Not the cold hostility I'd expected, just her usual mild disinterest when it comes to our project.

"Great." I say, a bit thrown off by her casual demeanor. "We should schedule a time to work on it together. The midterm presentation is coming up."

She finally turns to look at me then, those mismatched eyes meeting mine for the first time since that night. But instead of the charged recognition I expected, I see only vague confusion, as if she's trying to piece together a puzzle with missing pieces.

"About the other night..." she begins, her voice lower so others can't hear. "Things are... fuzzy after we left the bar. You got me home, right?"

It takes me a moment to process what she's saying. She doesn't remember. Or at least, not clearly. The kiss that's been a source of frustration and self-recrimination for me is lost in an alcohol-induced haze for her.

"Yep." I confirm, relief washing over me. "You were pretty out of it. I helped you to your apartment and then left."

She studies my face for a moment, as if searching for something. "Did I... say anything weird? Do anything?"

"You passed out pretty much as soon as we got to your place." I say, the lie coming easily. "I just made sure you were okay and then went home."

Something flickers across her face and she nods. "Right." she says. "Well... thanks, I guess. For not leaving me in a ditch somewhere."

"Don't mention it." I reply coolly. "Library tomorrow at four for project work?"

"Yeah, fine." She agrees, turning to face the front as Professor Netossa enters the room.

As the lecture begins, I find myself unexpectedly relieved. Catra doesn't remember our kiss, which means I don't have to deal with any awkward aftermath. We can go back to our established dynamic. Mutual dislike and grudging cooperation on our project. It's simpler this way. Cleaner.

And if there's a small, nagging voice in the back of my mind questioning why I feel a twinge of something else beneath the relief, I silence it firmly. I came to Brightfall for a fresh start, not to get entangled with someone as complicated and difficult as Catra.

By the time class ends, I've managed to focus enough to take decent notes, my relief at the simplified situation making it easier to concentrate. As students begin packing up, Catra stands.

"Tomorrow. Four o'clock. Don't be late." she says, then walks away without waiting for a response. It's exactly like our normal interactions, as if that night never happened at all.

Which, as far as I'm concerned, is for the best. Glimmer appears at my side, eyeing me curiously. "What was that about? She seemed almost... civil."

"Project meeting." I say, gathering my things. "Looks like I'll be spending quality time with Catra in the library tomorrow."

"Want us to come as backup?" she offers, only half-joking.

I shake my head, no longer feeling the same dread about being alone with Catra now that I know she doesn't remember our moment of weakness. "I'll be fine. We're just working on our presentation. I'm pretty sure she values her grades just as much as I do. So, I got a feeling there isn't anything to worry about."

"If you say so." Glimmer shrugs, clearly unconvinced. "Just text us if she tries anything, I don't know, push you down a flight of stairs or something."

I laugh, genuinely this time, and we head out of the classroom. For the first time since the festival, I feel like I can breathe normally again. Catra's convenient memory loss has given me exactly what I needed. A clean slate, a return to the status quo, and the chance to pretend that moment of weakness never happened.

Chapter 7: The Call Back to the Ring

The two weeks leading up to midterms transformed Brightfall University into a pressure cooker of stress and caffeine. Even the normally tranquil library resembled a refugee camp for the academically desperate. Students sprawled across every surface, surrounded by towers of textbooks and empty energy drink cans, their faces illuminated by laptop screens at all hours.

I'd expected the workload to be challenging, but nothing prepared me for the particular brand of anxiety that came with maintaining peace with Catra while also trying to excel in my classes. My project with Catra had evolved into a strange détente since the festival night. We were polite but distant during our library sessions, focusing exclusively on the work with minimal personal interaction.

The evening before our Cultural Studies presentation found us in our usual corner of the library, surrounded by books, notes and the remnants of takeout from the Whispering Woods Café.

"We should run through it one more time." I said, suppressing a yawn. It was past midnight, and we'd been rehearsing for hours.

Catra leaned back in her chair, stretching her arms above her head. Even exhausted, with her hair pulled into a messy bun and wearing what appeared to be the same clothes as yesterday, she somehow managed to look effortlessly beautiful. It was annoying.

"If I have to talk about 'cultural displacement as a catalyst for identity reformation' one more time, I might actually scream." She muttered, but straightened her notes anyway.

We'd settled on a presentation that examined how exchange students navigated their dual cultural identities, using interviews we'd conducted with international students at Brightfall. The irony of me presenting on this topic wasn't lost on either of us, though Catra still didn't know the full extent of my deception.

"Just once more." I insisted. "We need to nail the transition between your section on cultural adaptation strategies and my analysis of institutional support systems."

She rolled her eyes but complied and we launched into our well-rehearsed presentation for what felt like the hundredth time. Despite our personal differences, we worked surprisingly well together academically. Catra was brilliant, sharp, insightful, with a talent for distilling complex ideas into compelling narratives. I brought methodical research skills and a structured approach that complemented her creative thinking.

"...which brings us to the question of how educational institutions can better support these students through their cultural transition." Catra finished her section smoothly, nodding at me to continue.

As I picked up the thread, I noticed her watching me with an intensity that had become familiar during our preparation sessions. Analytical, assessing, as if I were a puzzle she was determined to solve. I'd caught her looking at me that way often since the festival, especially when she thought I wouldn't notice.

When we finished the run-through, she closed her laptop with a decisive snap. "Good enough. If we don't get an A on this, the whole grading system is rigged."

I gathered my notes, allowing myself a small smile. "For once, we agree on something."

"Mark the calendar." She said dryly. "A historic moment in the Adora-Catra cold war. The only time this will happen."

I looked up, surprised by her almost friendly tone. She held my gaze for a moment, something unreadable flickering in those mismatched eyes before she glanced away and began packing her bag.

"Get some sleep." she said, standing to leave. "I need you sharp tomorrow, not zombified from pulling an all-nighter."

"Is that concern I detect?" I couldn't resist asking.

"Self-preservation." she countered, slinging her bag over her shoulder. "Your grade is my grade, remember? I'm not about to lower my grades for someone like you."

With that, she walked away, leaving me alone in the quiet corner of the library. I sighed, gathering the rest of my things. Whatever fragile truce we'd established while working on this project, I had a feeling it wouldn't survive past tomorrow's presentation.

The next morning, the atmosphere in Professor Netossa's classroom crackled with pre-presentation anxiety. Students reviewed notes frantically, practiced under their breath, or stared into space with the glazed look of the severely sleep-deprived.

Glimmer and Bow, who'd presented the previous class, wished me luck as I took my seat beside Catra. She looked immaculate in a burgundy blazer and black pants, her hair falling in perfect waves around her face. A stark contrast to the exhausted student I'd left in the library just hours ago.

"Ready?" I asked, setting down my notecards.

She glanced at me, a hint of approval in her expression as she took in my own carefully selected outfit. Navy button-down and gray slacks, similar to what I'd worn to the festival but more formal.

"Born ready." She replied with her characteristic confidence.

Professor Netossa called the class to order and the presentations began. I barely registered the other students' talks, too focused on reviewing our own material one last time. When our names

were finally called, Catra and I moved to the front of the room with practiced synchronicity.

For fifteen minutes, we presented our research flawlessly. Slides advancing on cue, transitions smooth, our points building on each other's as if we'd been academic partners for years instead of reluctant collaborators for weeks. When we opened the floor for questions, we fielded them with complementary approaches. Catra handling the theoretical inquiries with eloquence while I addressed the methodology with precision.

As we returned to our seats amid enthusiastic applause, I caught Glimmer giving me a thumbs up from across the room. Even Entrapta looked impressed, though she was still typing furiously on her tablet, probably recording data on our presentation dynamics for some personal research project.

"Well done, Ms. Grayskull, Ms. Weaver." Professor Netossa said, making a note in her grade book. "An excellent integration of theoretical frameworks with original research."

When class ended, students poured into the hallway in a collective exhale of relief. Midterms were officially over for many of us, with a week-long fall break ahead before the second half of the semester began.

"At least your looks come with brains." Catra remarked as we gathered our things. "I half expected you to freeze up there."

Coming from her, it was practically a glowing compliment. "You weren't too bad yourself." I replied.

A ghost of a smile touched her lips. "Thank god that's over." She said, shouldering her bag. "I need about forty-eight hours of uninterrupted sleep."

"Big plans for the break?" I asked, surprising myself with the attempt at casual conversation.

"My mother's dragging me to some tech conference in the capital." She said with a grimace. "Five days of pretending to care about innovation paradigms and disruption strategies."

"Sounds thrilling."

"Doesn't it?" She paused, studying me for a moment. "What about you? Flying back to America to soak up some California sun?"

I shook my head. "Staying here. My parents are too busy with faculty obligations."

She nodded, and for a moment it seemed like she might say something else. Instead, she just said, "Well now that everything is over. See you never." and walked away, disappearing into the crowd of celebrating students.

Outside the Humanities building, I found Glimmer, Bow, and Entrapta waiting for me.

"YOU DEMONSTRATED REMARKABLY EFFECTIVE COLLABORATIVE COMMUNICATION PATTERNS WITH YOUR NEMESIS!" Entrapta announced by way of congratulations.

"She means you guys crushed it." Bow translated with a grin. "Seriously, that was impressive."

"Thanks." I said, feeling the tension of the past weeks finally beginning to ease. "I'm just glad it's over."

"We're heading to the Whispering Woods to celebrate the end of midterms." Glimmer said. "You in?"

"Definitely." I nodded. "Just let me drop off my presentation materials at home first."

We made plans to meet in an hour, and I headed home, enjoying the crisp autumn air and the weightless feeling of academic obligations temporarily fulfilled. The house was quiet when I

arrived, my parents both at the university for faculty meetings that would run late into the evening.

I had just changed into more comfortable clothes, jeans and a loose sweater when the doorbell rang. Assuming it was a package delivery, I opened the door without checking first.

"Surprise champ!"

I froze, staring in disbelief at the woman standing on my doorstep. Tall and powerfully built, with close-cropped white hair and the weathered face of someone who'd spent decades in boxing gyms, Coach Huntara grinned at me, arms spread wide.

"Coach?" I managed, my voice barely above a whisper. "What are you- how did you-"

"What, no hug for your old coach?" She interrupted, pulling me into a bone-crushing embrace before I could process what was happening.

I returned the hug automatically, my mind racing. Coach Huntara was here. In Brightfall. At my door. Where anyone could see her, anyone who might recognize the famous trainer of She-Ra, three-time women's boxing champion.

"Get inside." I said urgently, pulling her into the house and shutting the door quickly. "What are you doing here? Is something wrong?"

"Wrong? Hell no!" She laughed, dropping a duffel bag on the floor and looking around the living room with interest. "Nice place you got here."

"Coach." I said, trying to keep the panic from my voice, "You can't just show up here."

Her eyebrows rose in surprise. "Your parents didn't tell you I was coming? I called them last week."

"They didn't mention anything," I said, making a mental note to have a serious conversation with my parents about the importance of warning me before dropping bombshells.

"Well, surprise!" She said again, clapping her hands together. "And girl, do I have news for you."

I sank onto the couch, a sense of dread building. "What kind of news?"

"The best kind!" Coach's eyes lit up with excitement. "The International Boxing Federation is hosting a special exhibition championship in Meridian City next weekend."

"Meridian City?" I repeated, the name registering slowly. "That's less than an hour from here."

"Exactly!" Coach exclaimed. "When I heard about it, I knew it was a sign. The timing is perfect. It's been almost been over a year and a half since the Frosta fight, you've had time to heal, to clear your head..." She leaned forward, her expression turning serious. "It's time for She-Ra to make her comeback, Adora."

I stared at her, speechless. A year before i got here, I'd been lying in a hospital bed, broken physically and mentally after the most brutal match of my career. Now Coach was talking about stepping back into the ring as if I'd just taken a short vacation.

"I'm not ready." I said automatically. "I haven't been training properly, I'm in college, I'm-"

"Bullshit." Coach cut me off, but gently. "Your dad told me you've been keeping up with your conditioning. Said you've got some secret training space set up in the university basement. And you've got brains, so your academics won't suffer much."

Mental note number two: have a very serious conversation with my father about confidentiality.

"That's just basic maintenance." I protested. "Not competition prep."

Coach Huntara waved her hand dismissively. "It's an exhibition match, not a title defense. Two rounds, controlled environment, carefully selected opponent." She fixed me with the penetrating stare that had intimidated me since I was fourteen. "I wouldn't be here if I didn't think you were ready."

I stood up, pacing across the living room as my mind raced. Return to the ring? Here, so close to Brightfall, where I'd been building a life as just Adora?

"I can't." I said, shaking my head. "I'm in the middle of the semester, I have classes, friends who most likely will notice my absence. As much as i would love to throw fists in the ring and feel that rush I can't. Much less I have things to do here."

"It's fall break next week, isn't it?" Coach interrupted. "Perfect timing. We train for a few days, you fight a couple nights, and you're back in time for classes Monday morning." She spread her hands. "No one here needs to know. We maintain all the usual security protocols. Separate entrance, mask during press appearances, the works."

I stopped pacing, a strange mix of fear and excitement stirring in my chest. The truth was, I missed it. The discipline of training camp, the focused preparation, the pure physicality of the sport I'd dedicated most of my life to. My secret training sessions in the basement had kept me in shape, but they were pale imitations of the real thing.

"Who would I be fighting?" I asked, already hating myself for considering it.

Coach's face broke into a triumphant grin, knowing she had me. "Peek-a-blue. Promising up and comer, good technical skills but not at your level. Perfect opponent for a comeback bout."

I sat back down, my head spinning. "I'd need to tell my parents."

"Already done." She said cheerfully. "They're on board, though your mom made me promise it's just this one event until the semester ends."

Of course she had. I could almost hear her voice: "Academic commitments come first, Adora."

"I don't know." I said, still hesitant. "It's risky. If someone from Brightfall recognizes me-"

"With the mask and the security measures? Not a chance." She assured me. "Besides, how many college kids follow women's boxing closely enough to connect some exchange student to She-Ra?"

She had a point. The chances were slim. And it was just a couple of matches, a controlled environment to test the waters, to see if I was truly ready to return to professional competition.

"When would we leave?" I asked, knowing I was already caving.

"Friday." Coach said, unable to contain her excitement. "Training camp's all set up in Meridian City. Your gear's been shipped ahead."

My phone buzzed in my pocket, a text from Glimmer asking if I was still meeting them at the Whispering Woods. I'd completely forgotten about our celebration plans.

"I need to think about it." I said, standing up again.

Coach nodded, uncharacteristically patient. "Take the night to think it over. But Adora," her voice turned serious, "this is a perfect opportunity. Low risk, controlled environment. Let loose feel the power you have in your bones again." She stood, placing a heavy hand on my shoulder. "She-Ra has unfinished business. You know it, I know it and the boxing world knows it."

After Coach left to check into her hotel, promising to return tomorrow for my answer, I sat alone in the living room, my mind

in turmoil. I should have immediately refused. The whole point of coming to Brightfall was to escape the pressure of being She-Ra, to heal both physically and mentally, to experience normal life.

But there was truth in Coach's words. She-Ra did have unfinished business. My last memory in the ring couldn't be that brutal defeat, the hospital stay, the whispers that my career was over. I needed closure, one way or another.

My phone buzzed again with another text from Glimmer. I needed to make a decision.

I texted back that I was on my way to meet them, then opened my closet and moved aside the carefully hung clothes to reveal a small lockbox at the back. Inside was the one piece of my She-Ra identity I'd brought to Brightfall. A simple mask that covered the upper half of my face, designed to conceal my identity during public appearances.

I held it in my hands, feeling its familiar weight. One chance to step back into that world under controlled circumstances, to test whether I was truly ready to return or if that chapter of my life was indeed over.

Decision made, I tucked the mask back into its hiding place and headed out to meet my friends, the contradiction of my dual lives weighing heavier than ever. For the first time since arriving in Brightfall, I wasn't sure which version of myself I wanted to be.

Chapter 8: The Intervention

"You're in?" Coach Huntara's voice was a mix of excitement and satisfaction when I called her the next morning.

"I'm in." I confirmed, still not entirely sure I wasn't making a huge mistake. "But just for this exhibition. No promises beyond that."

"One step at a time, kid." She agreed, sounding like she was trying to contain her enthusiasm. "I'll handle all the logistics. You just focus on getting your head in the game. We leave Friday afternoon, that gives you three days to wrap up anything at school before we head to Meridian City for training camp."

After hanging up, I sat on my bed, staring at the mask I'd retrieved from its hiding place. She-Ra would return to the ring. The thought sent equal parts dread and adrenaline through my system.

Three days. Seventy-two hours to maintain to be a regular college student while mentally preparing to step back into the identity I'd kept carefully hidden for months.

I tucked the mask away and dressed for class. My parents had already left for work, sparing me an immediate conversation about Coach Huntara's visit, though I knew that discussion would come soon enough. For now, I was grateful for the reprieve.

The campus seemed different somehow as I approached the main quad. Groups of students huddled together, phones out, voices raised in excitement. I caught fragments of conversations as I passed.

"...can't believe she's actually fighting here..." "...tickets are going to be impossible to get..." "...first appearance since the hospital..."

A chill ran down my spine. They couldn't possibly be talking about-

"Adora!" Glimmer's voice cut through my rising panic. She was waving frantically from the steps of the Humanities building, Bow and Entrapta beside her.

I forced a smile and jogged over to them, trying to look normal despite the dread pooling in my stomach.

"Did you hear?" Glimmer practically bounced with excitement, grabbing my arm. "She-Ra is fighting in Meridian City next weekend!"

My carefully practiced neutral expression almost slipped. "She-Ra?" I repeated, feigning confusion.

"Only the most dominant female boxer of the last decade!" Bow explained, his eyes wide with enthusiasm. "She's been out of competition for like a year after a really brutal match where she got seriously injured. Nobody knew if she'd ever fight again."

"AND NOW SHE'S APPEARING MERELY 57.3 KILOMETERS FROM BRIGHTFALL!" Entrapta added at full volume, typing furiously on her tablet. "THE STATISTICAL IMPROBABILITY OF THIS COINCIDENCE IS REMARKABLE!"

I swallowed hard, trying to process what was happening. "I... didn't realize boxing was so popular here."

Glimmer laughed. "Are you kidding? Brightfall is crazy about She-Ra! The university even sponsors her training center back in America. There's a whole sports science exchange program built around it."

This was news to me. Had my parents known about this connection when they suggested Brightfall University? Was that why Coach Huntara had been so confident about the exhibition match's security protocols?

"Plus," Bow added with a grin, "she's incredible to watch. The way she moves in the ring is like... art in motion. And nobody knows

her real identity. She always wears this mask for public appearances."

"The mystery adds to her appeal!" Glimmer explained, clearly noting my bewildered expression. "There are whole online forums dedicated to theories about who she really is."

"I HAVE ANALYZED ALL AVAILABLE FOOTAGE AND NARROWED POTENTIAL IDENTITIES TO 342 POSSIBILITIES!" Entrapta announced proudly.

I felt slightly faint. "Sounds... intense."

"We're definitely going!" Glimmer declared. "My mom can probably get faculty tickets through the sports science department. You have to come with us, Adora!"

"Oh, I-" I began, scrambling for an excuse.

"What's got Sparkles so worked up this morning?" A familiar raspy voice interrupted.

Catra approached our group, looking unusually animated despite her attempt at casual disinterest. Her hair was pulled back in a loose ponytail and she wore a fitted leather jacket over a simple t-shirt and jeans, a far cry from her usual carefully curated outfits.

"She-Ra's fighting in Meridian City next weekend." Bow explained. "We're planning to go."

To my absolute shock, Catra's face lit up with genuine excitement. "Seriously? She-Ra? Here?" For a moment, her cool facade completely disappeared, replaced by something I'd never seen before, authentic enthusiasm.

"Since when do you care about boxing?" Glimmer asked, clearly as surprised as I was.

Catra's expression shifted, attempting to regain her trademark indifference but not quite succeeding. "What? I just happen to

appreciate watching attractive, strong women who can absolutely fuck someone up." She shrugged, a hint of color rising to her cheeks. "It's... entertaining."

I stared at her, utterly blindsided by this revelation. Catra was a She-Ra fan? The universe clearly had a twisted sense of humor.

"We're getting tickets." Glimmer said. "You should come with us."

For a second, it looked like Catra might actually agree, before her usual disdain reasserted itself. "With you? Please." But then she added, "Though I am definitely getting tickets. Wouldn't miss it."

My mind raced for a plausible reason I couldn't attend. "I... actually can't make it." I said, trying to sound genuinely disappointed. "My parents just told me we're visiting some relatives in... in the capital that weekend. Family obligation, can't get out of it."

"The capital? That's hours away in the opposite direction!" Glimmer protested. "Can't you come back early? This is She-Ra!"

"I know, I'm really sorry." I said, injecting as much regret into my voice as possible. "But it's my dad's birthday and his sister is throwing this whole thing... it's complicated."

"FAMILIAL OBLIGATIONS DO TYPICALLY SUPERSEDE RECREATIONAL ACTIVITIES IN SOCIAL HIERARCHIES," Entrapta observed, inadvertently coming to my rescue.

Catra was watching me with that calculating look I'd come to dread. The one that suggested she was filing away information for future reference. "That's too bad." she said, though her tone implied she wasn't entirely buying my story. "Guess you'll miss seeing a legend in action."

"I'll catch the replay." I said weakly.

"It won't be the same." Bow sighed. "The energy in the arena when she fights... it's electric."

"Well, I'd better head to class." I said, desperate to escape this surreal conversation. "See you guys later?"

As I walked away, I heard Catra say to the others. "So how are we getting tickets? Because I have connections that might help."

The rest of the day passed in a blur. In each class, conversation inevitably turned to the upcoming fight. She-Ra's return was apparently the biggest news to hit Brightfall in years. I sat through lectures barely absorbing a word, my mind constantly circling back to the image of my friends sitting in the audience while I stood in the ring.

By the time I got home, my nerves were frayed to breaking point. I needed to burn off this restless energy, to think through the implications of what I'd committed to.

I changed quickly into running clothes, leggings, a sports bra, and a loose hoodie pulling a ball cap low over my eyes. The late afternoon sun was beginning to wane, casting long shadows across the neighborhood as I set out at a steady pace.

I ran without a clear destination, pushing myself harder than usual, welcoming the burn in my lungs and the familiar ache in my muscles. This was what I needed, the simplicity of physical exertion, body and breath in sync, mind clearing with each pounding footfall.

I'd circled through a nearby park and was cutting through a less familiar neighborhood when the sounds of an altercation caught my attention. Raised voices came from an alley between two buildings, sharp with tension. I slowed, instinct telling me to keep moving, to avoid other people's problems.

But something about the voices made me pause. One of them, female, angry, and strangely familiar cut through the deeper male tones. I edged closer, peering around the corner of the building.

Three men stood in a loose semicircle, their backs to me. Facing them, backed against a wall, was Catra. Her posture was

defensive but defiant, chin raised, eyes flashing with anger. One of the men reached toward her, saying something in the local language that I couldn't quite catch.

Catra slapped his hand away. "*I said I'm not interested!*" She snapped in the local tongue. "*Get it through your thick skull.* "

"*Playing hard to get?* " One of the others replied, his tone making my skin crawl. "*We're just being friendly. Come have a drink with us.* "

"*I'd rather drink bleach.*" Catra shot back. "*Now move.* "

I hesitated, watching. Catra could handle herself, she'd made that abundantly clear. This wasn't my problem. I should keep running, let her deal with her own situation.

I was already turning away when I heard the sharp sound of skin striking skin, followed by Catra's furious gasp. I whipped back around to see her holding her cheek, eyes wide with shock, as one of the men loomed over her.

"*Bitch. Learn some manners.* " He growled.

Something in me snapped. Before I could think through the consequences, I was striding into the alley, pushing between the men to stand in front of Catra. My hood was up, cap pulled low, face partially shadowed.

"*Back off!*" I said in flawless local dialect, my voice low and dangerous.

The men exchanged surprised glances, not immediately sure what to make of me, a hooded stranger materializing out of nowhere.

"*Mind your own business.* " The one who'd slapped Catra said, recovering quickly. "*This is between us and her.* "

"*Not anymore.*" I replied, shifting my weight subtly into a fighting stance.

Behind me, I felt Catra move, trying to see my face.

I ignored her, keeping my attention on the three men. The largest of them took a step toward me, attempting to use his size as intimidation.

"*Get out of the way, or you'll get the same as your friend here.*" He threatened.

I smiled, though they couldn't see it beneath the shadow of my cap. "*I'd like to see you try.* "

He moved faster than I expected, swinging a meaty fist toward my head. But after years in the ring, his telegraphed punch might as well have been in slow motion. I ducked easily, pivoting on my left foot as his momentum carried him forward, and drove my right fist into his solar plexus.

He doubled over with a pained wheeze and I followed with a precise strike to the side of his jaw, not full force, just enough to send him staggering back into his friends.

The other two gaped for a split second before launching themselves at me together. I sidestepped the first, using his own momentum to send him sprawling, while blocking a wild punch from the second. My counterpunch caught him in the ribs, followed by a swift jab to his nose that wasn't hard enough to break it but definitely made him reconsider his choices.

It was over in seconds. They never stood a chance. As they stumbled back, cursing and holding various injured parts, I maintained my stance, ready if they decided to try again.

"*Leave.*" I said, the single word carrying enough menace to make them reconsider any thoughts of retaliation.

They backed away, muttering threats but clearly unwilling to follow through. I watched them go, adrenaline still coursing through my veins.

"Are you okay?" I asked, turning toward Catra but keeping my head angled down, voice deliberately lowered.

She was staring at me, those mismatched eyes wide with shock and something that might have been admiration. "How did you- who are-"

Before I could respond, a movement behind me caught my peripheral vision. One of the men, apparently not as deterred as his friends, had circled back and was charging at my back. I started to pivot but he was too close, his momentum slamming into me.

The impact sent me crashing forward, directly into Catra. We went down in a tangle of limbs, my cap flying off and my hood slipping back as I instinctively twisted to take the brunt of the fall. We hit the ground hard, me on top of her, our faces inches apart.

For a heartbeat, we froze, her eyes locked on mine as recognition dawned.

"Adora?!" She gasped.

There was no time to explain. The man who'd tackled me was already pulling back for a punch. I rolled off Catra, springing to my feet in one fluid motion and met his attack with a practiced counter that left him groaning on the ground.

Breathing hard, I turned back to Catra, who was still sitting where she'd fallen, staring at me as if she'd never seen me before. I crouched in front of her, my cover blown.

"Are you okay?" I asked again, softer this time.

Her lips parted to respond, but for once, Catra seemed completely at a loss for words.

Chapter 9: Exposed Secrets

"Are you okay?" I asked again, softer this time.

Her lips parted to respond but for once, Catra seemed completely at a loss for words.

I sighed, glancing back to make sure the men weren't returning. "Focus, Catra. Are you alright? Did they hurt you?"

She blinked, then touched her cheek where the man had slapped her. Slowly, she nodded.

The shock in her eyes began to recede, replaced by something sharper, more calculating. She narrowed her eyes, studying me with a new intensity.

"You speak the language." She stated flatly, accusation clear in her tone. "Fluently."

I stood up, offering her a hand that she ignored as she pushed herself to her feet. "I- uh... I've picked up some things since I've been here." I tried, knowing how weak the excuse sounded.

"Bullshit." She shot back. "That wasn't you picking up some things. You were completely fluent. Perfect accent, idioms, everything." Her mismatched eyes bore into mine. "You've been lying this whole time."

I sighed again, looking around at our surroundings. The alley wasn't exactly the place for this conversation. "Yes I know the language." I admitted, deciding there was no point denying what she'd clearly witnessed. "Can we not do this here?"

"How? Why would you pretend-" she began, then stopped abruptly, staring at me with renewed intensity. "And where the hell did you learn to fight like that? Those weren't just lucky punches. That was..." she gestured vaguely, seemingly unable to find the right words.

I rubbed my temples, feeling a headache forming. "Catra, please. Can you be quiet for just a moment? I need to think."

Her expression shifted suddenly, eyes widening. "You're bleeding."

"What?" I reached up to touch my temple, wincing as my fingers came away red. I must have hit my head during the fall.

"Let me see." Catra said, stepping closer, her hostility momentarily forgotten.

"It's fine." I insisted, backing away. "Just a scratch."

"It's not fine, you idiot." She said, grabbing my arm with surprising strength. "You could have a concussion."

"I don't have a concussion." I protested. "I've had enough of those to know what they feel like."

Her eyebrows shot up at that slip but instead of pursuing it, she pulled me toward the street. "There's a convenience store on the corner. We need to clean that cut."

I could have resisted, could have easily broken her grip but the fight had drained out of me. The convenience store was brightly lit and empty except for a bored cashier who barely looked up as we entered. Catra directed me to a small seating area near the window while she went to find first aid supplies.

Left alone, I tried to formulate a plausible explanation for both my language skills and my fighting ability. I could say I'd taken martial arts as a kid, that was common enough. And maybe I could claim my parents had taught me the language at home, even though we'd moved away when I was young?

But Catra was smart. She'd already caught me in one lie. She'd be scrutinizing everything I said for inconsistencies.

I was still strategizing when Catra returned with an armful of supplies: antiseptic wipes, bandages, and a small ice pack.

Without a word, she pulled her chair close to mine and began cleaning the cut on my temple.

Her touch was surprisingly gentle as she dabbed at the blood, her face set in concentration. I watched her, puzzled by this unexpected side of someone I'd only known as confrontational and cutting.

"Thank you." I said quietly. "For helping me."

She snorted. "I think we've established that you're the one who helped me." She pressed a bandage to my temple, smoothing it with careful fingers. "Though I could have handled it myself."

"I know." I said honestly. "I've seen how you handle yourself. But when he hit you..."

Something flickered in her expression, surprise or confusion. "Yeah, well... thanks." The words seemed to cost her effort.

We fell into silence as she finished tending to my wound. When she was done, she sat back in her chair, studying me with that piercing gaze that always made me feel like I was being dissected.

"Stand up." She said suddenly.

"What?"

"Stand. Up." She enunciated each word deliberately.

Confused but wary of her intense stare, I complied, rising to my feet in the small seating area.

What happened next was so fast I barely had time to react. Catra lunged forward, hands grasping the hem of my hoodie and yanked it up to my chest, exposing my stomach and sports bra.

"What the fuck!" I yelped, immediately grabbing for the fabric but she'd already seen what she was looking for, the defined muscles of my abdomen, the results of years of professional training.

"I knew it." She breathed, her eyes wide.

We struggled for a moment, my hands trying to pull the hoodie down, hers trying to keep it raised.

"Let go!" I hissed, acutely aware that we were in a public place, even if it's an empty one.

"I just want to confirm something!" She insisted, not releasing her grip.

"Confirm what? That you're insane?" I shot back, finally managing to wrench the fabric from her hands and pull it down, my face burning with embarrassment and anger.

She stepped back, but her eyes held a gleam of triumph. "No normal college student has abs like that." She said. "Or fights like you just did."

I crossed my arms protectively over my midsection, glaring at her. "So I work out. That's not a crime."

"Riiigghhhtttt..." she drawled, clearly not buying it. "And the language skills?"

"You don't know what you're talking about." I said, but the defense sounded weak even to my own ears.

Catra held my gaze for a long moment, then suddenly turned and walked back toward the store shelves. I stood there, wondering if I should just leave but a perverse curiosity kept me rooted to the spot. What was her game? What did she think she knew?

A minute later, she returned with two cans of soft drinks, handing one to me before sitting back down.

"Sit." She said, popping open her can. "Let's have a chat, Adora."

The way she said my name sent a chill down my spine, like she was saying it for the first time, tasting it, testing its authenticity. I

sat slowly, keeping my eyes on her.

"So..." she began, taking a sip of her drink. "Who exactly are you?"

I took a deep breath, centering myself. This wasn't my first high-pressure situation. Catra was intimidating in her own way, but I could handle this.

"I grew up doing martial arts." I said, meeting her eyes steadily. "Started when I was six, my dad thought it would help with discipline and confidence. Turns out I had a natural talent for it." I shrugged, aiming for casual.

Catra raised an eyebrow but didn't interrupt.

"I was born here in Brightfall, grew up speaking the language at home and at school. My family lived here for the first part of my life." I took a sip of my drink, using the moment to gauge her reaction. Her expression remained skeptical but attentive.

"When I came back for college, I just... never mentioned that I was fluent. Nobody asked so i never used it. Plus it was amusing knowing what was said around me so freely."

A flicker of recognition crossed Catra's face at that, she probably is remembering the times she spoke in the language about me specifically.

"As for the fitness thing..." I continued, gesturing vaguely at my torso, "I never stopped training. It became part of who I am. Just the discipline, the routine. Running, strength training, bag work." Another careful shrug. "It makes me feel... centered. Like I have control over something in my life, you know?"

That part, at least, was completely true. Boxing had always been my anchor, the one constant I could rely on when everything else felt chaotic.

"When I came back to Brightfall for college, I wanted a fresh start." I looked down at my drink, finding it easier to tell this partial truth without meeting her eyes. "I just wanted to be normal. I wanted the new kid who could fit in."

The silence stretched between us as Catra considered my explanation. I'd woven truth with fiction.

"So that's why you always wear those baggy clothes." Catra said finally. "You're hiding... this." She gestured toward my body.

I nodded. "People treat you differently when they can see you're athletic. Make assumptions about your intelligence, your interests. It was just easier to cover up."

"And the night of the festival?" She asked suddenly. "When you helped me home?"

My heartbeat quickened. "What about it?"

Catra's eyes narrowed slightly, calculating. "I've been having... fragments of memory come back to me." Her fingers tapped against the can in her hands. "Nothing clear, just... impressions."

I kept my face carefully neutral. "Like what?"

"Like feeling your stomach under my hand." She said bluntly, holding her hand up and looking at it. "When you were helping me. I thought I'd imagined it." Her gaze became penetrating. "But I didn't, did I? That's what I felt just now, exactly what I remembered."

A flush crept up my neck. "My shirt was wet." I said, recalling the spilled water. "It probably clung to me."

"Hmm." Her eyes didn't leave mine. "I feel like there was something else too. Something more that happened." She leaned forward slightly. "What exactly went down that night, Adora?"

"I-I don't know what you mean." I stammered, feeling the heat in my face intensify. "Nothing. Nothing happened."

A slow smile spread across Catra's face, clearly pleased by my discomfort. "You're a terrible liar. Your whole face is red." She set down her drink and crossed her arms. "Spill it."

I swallowed hard, knowing I was cornered. "Fine. You want to know what happened? I got you home, helped you inside and got you some water. You spilled it all over me, we both fell, and then... well... then you kissed me."

It was Catra's turn to look shocked. Her eyes widened, color flooding her cheeks. "I did what?"

"You kissed me." I repeated, a small part of me enjoying her reaction after all her smugness. "Right there on your living room floor."

"That's... Hold on..." She shook her head, clearly flustered. "That can't be. I wouldn't-"

"Oh, but you did." I said, unable to suppress a smile. "And now you're red."

"I am not!" She protested, touching her cheek as if she could physically push away the color.

"You absolutely are." I leaned back, feeling the tables turn. "Who's the terrible liar now?"

Catra recovered quickly, her usual composure sliding back into place. "Well, I was clearly very drunk. It didn't mean anything."

"Of course not." I agreed easily.

"And it's not like you stopped me." She countered, trying to regain the upper hand.

I couldn't help but smile, seeing my opportunity. "It happened too fast. Plus, you've got a surprisingly strong grip. Even with all my training, I couldn't unlatch you from me." I leaned forward slightly, enjoying her discomfort. "You were quite... determined. Grabbed my collar and everything."

Catra's blush deepened, and she looked away. "That's ridiculous. I wouldn't-"

"You absolutely would," I interrupted, mimicking her earlier tone. "And did. Very enthusiastically, I might add."

We stared at each other for a long moment, the air between us charged with something I couldn't quite define.

"So." I said finally. "Are we even now? Secret for secret?"

She considered this. "I guess that's fair. Though mine was an accident, while yours was deliberate deception."

I rolled my eyes. "Fine. You still get your favor to be determined later. Happy?"

A slow smile spread across her face again, but different this time, less smug, more genuine. "Ecstatic."

"It's getting late." I said finally. "I should head home."

Catra nodded, gathering the first aid wrappers and our empty cans. "Yeah, me too."

We walked out together, lingering awkwardly on the sidewalk. The dynamic between us had shifted in ways I couldn't quite define, leaving us in uncharted territory.

"So..." I started, not sure how to end this strange encounter.

"So..." she echoed, looking at me with an expression I couldn't read. "See you around."

"Yep, see you."

I watched her walk away, her silhouette gradually disappearing down the street. Only when she was completely out of sight did I let out the breath I'd been holding.

I'd averted disaster, at least for now. Catra knew about my language skills and my martial arts background, but not about She-Ra. And somehow, in the midst of all these revelations, we'd ended up in a strange new place. Not friends exactly, but something more complicated than enemies.

As I made my way home, I couldn't shake the memory of her face when I told her about the kiss. The shock, the embarrassment, the fleeting vulnerability. It was a side of Catra I'd never seen before and somehow, it made her seem more human.

But with the exhibition match approaching, I had more pressing concerns than whatever was evolving between me and Catra. In less than a week, I'd be stepping back into the ring as She-Ra. And now, with Catra already suspicious about parts of my identity, the stakes were higher than ever.

Chapter 10: The Gala

Friday arrived with a flurry of activity. Campus was buzzing with She-Ra fever. Students wearing homemade t-shirts with her logo, the sports science department hosting a special panel on women in combat sports, and almost everyone discussing their plans to attend the exhibition match.

"I still can't believe you're missing this." Glimmer lamented as we sat at our usual table in the cafeteria for lunch. "My mom pulled strings and got us incredible seats. Third row!"

"I tried to get out of the family thing." I lied, picking at my salad. "My dad was pretty upset that I even asked."

"ACCORDING TO MY ANALYSIS OF SOCIAL MEDIA ACTIVITY, TICKET PRICES HAVE INCREASED BY 382% ON RESALE PLATFORMS!" Entrapta announced, not looking up from her tablet. "FASCINATING MARKET RESPONSE TO LIMITED SUPPLY!"

"Even Catra's going." Bow added. "I saw her this morning getting into some fancy car with her mother. Apparently they're attending the pre-fight gala tonight."

My fork froze halfway to my mouth. "Pre-fight gala?"

"Yeah, it's this fancy dinner for sponsors and VIPs." Bow explained. "Catra's mom is some tech mogul whose company sponsors the event. Scorpia was telling me about it yesterday."

Great. Just great. Not only would Catra be at the fight, but she'd be at the gala where She-Ra would make her first public appearance. I'd have to be extra careful to avoid her.

"Well, take lots of pictures for me." I said, forcing enthusiasm into my voice. "I want to hear all about it when I get back."

"We will!" Glimmer promised. "I'm going to try to get She-Ra's autograph after the match."

"Good luck with that." I said, knowing just how strict the security protocols would be. "I hear she's pretty elusive."

As my friends chattered excitedly about their weekend plans, I checked the time. Coach Huntara would be picking me up in an hour, and I still needed to finish packing.

"I should get going." I said, standing up. "My parents want to hit the road by three to beat traffic."

We said our goodbyes, with promises to text and update each other throughout the break. As I walked away, I felt a pang of guilt for all the deception but pushed it aside. This was necessary, not just for my privacy but for my peace of mind. I needed this fight, needed to know if I could still be She-Ra after everything that happened.

Coach Huntara was waiting in an unmarked SUV with tinted windows when I arrived home. I tossed my duffel bag in the back and climbed in, immediately feeling the shift in my mindset as we pulled away from Brightfall.

"You ready for this?" She asked, glancing at me as we merged onto the highway.

"Yes." I replied.

The training facility in Meridian City was state of the art, a converted warehouse with every piece of equipment a boxer could dream of. For three days, I immersed myself completely in preparation. Morning runs, bag work, sparring sessions, strength training, and endless tactical discussions with Coach Huntara.

It felt like coming home. The familiar rhythm of a training camp, the focus, the discipline. All of it centered me in a way nothing at Brightfall could. Here, I didn't have to hide my strength or my skills. I could be She-Ra without reservation.

By Friday evening, the night before the fight, I was in peak condition. My body remembered what to do, muscle memory

taking over where conscious thought left off. Even Coach seemed impressed by how quickly I'd regained my form.

By Sunday evening, the night before the fight, I was in peak condition. My body remembered what to do, muscle memory taking over where conscious thought left off. Even Coach seemed impressed by how quickly I'd regained my form.

"There's a pre-fight gala at the Meridian Grand tonight." Coach Huntara said as we finished our final training session. "All the fighters on the card will be there for a formal meet and greet with sponsors and VIPs."

"Will there be press?" I asked, toweling off sweat from my forehead.

"Minimal. Just the official event photographer. You'll wear the mask, of course."

I nodded. The mask was integral to the She-Ra persona. It had started as a marketing gimmick, a way to create mystique, but had become essential for maintaining the separation between my boxing career and my private life.

An hour later, I was dressed in fitted black pants and a sleeveless burgundy top that showcased my toned arms and the intricate tattoos that covered my biceps and shoulders. My hair was pulled back in the tight braid that had become She-Ra's signature style. With the mask in place, the transformation was complete.

The person in the mirror was She-Ra, confident, powerful and untouchable. "Let's roll." Coach said, giving me an appraising look. "You look ready to fight right now."

The Meridian Grand was the city's most exclusive hotel, its ballroom transformed for the evening into an elegant reception space. Fighter profiles and promotional images decorated the walls, and stations had been set up around the perimeter where each boxer would meet fans and sponsors.

We entered through a private entrance, a security team smoothly escorting us to my designated area. Several heads turned as we passed, whispers following in our wake. I kept my posture straight, my gait measured and confident.

"You're at station three." The event coordinator said, directing us to a sleek podium with my name and image prominently displayed. "Water and anything else you need will be provided. The event runs for two hours."

The ballroom was already filling with sponsors, media representatives, and select VIP ticket holders, all dressed in formal attire. Coach Huntara stood nearby, scanning the crowd with the practiced vigilance of someone used to protecting her fighter from overeager fans or intrusive questions.

I was greeting a young aspiring boxer when I caught sight of a familiar figure across the room. My breath caught in my throat.

Catra.

She stood with an elegant older woman who shared her sharp features and several business-looking types in expensive suits. Catra herself wore a fitted black dress, her hair loose around her shoulders, looking more sophisticated than I'd ever seen her.

"Something wrong?" Coach asked, noticing my sudden tension.

"No." I said quickly, returning my attention to the young boxer in front of me. "Just thought I recognized someone."

Coach glanced in the direction I'd been looking, then back at me. "Anyone I should be concerned about?"

"No, it's fine."

She raised an eyebrow but didn't push further. I continued greeting fans and sponsors, signing programs and posing for photos, though I found myself hyperaware of Catra's presence in the room.

I was just finishing a conversation with a potential sponsor when I noticed a ripple of excitement move through the crowd. Looking up, I saw a striking young woman making her entrance. White-blue hair cropped short, athletic build evident even in her tailored suit, a confident set to her jaw that I recognized all too well.

Frosta.

My body tensed involuntarily, phantom pain flaring across my ribs where they had been broken in our match. The last time I'd seen her was across the ring, her glove connecting with my face in the knockout blow that had nearly ended my career.

Unlike most of the other fighters who entered quietly, Frosta moved through the room like she owned it, stopping to pose for photos and accepting admiration with practiced ease. The championship belt she'd won by defeating me, my championship belt was prominently displayed at her station.

"Easy." Coach murmured, noticing my reaction. "She's just here for the exhibition too. Different card, different night."

I nodded, forcing myself to relax. "I know. It's fine."

It took Frosta less than ten minutes to notice my presence. When her eyes found me across the ballroom, she did a slight double-take, then a smug smile spread across her face. Rather than a discreet nod of professional courtesy, she raised her glass in my direction, the gesture clearly meant to draw attention to our history.

Several heads turned toward me, and I could hear the whispers starting. "She-Ra's back..." "Frosta nearly ended her... wonder if there'll be a rematch..."

"Don't let her get to you." Coach warned. "That's exactly what she wants."

I kept my expression neutral, acknowledging her toast with the barest inclination of my head before returning my attention to the

sponsor I'd been speaking with. But I could feel Frosta's eyes on me, watching, assessing.

For the next hour, I greeted a steady stream of fans and sponsors, slipping easily into the public persona, focused but gracious. The structured format of the event provided a welcome buffer, allowing me to maintain control of each interaction.

I was answering a young reporter's questions when I sensed a presence approaching from the side. The reporter's eyes widened, and the questions stopped mid-sentence. I didn't need to turn to know who had arrived.

"She-Ra," Frosta's voice carried just enough volume to ensure those nearby could hear. "The mysterious masked fighter returns from the shadows. How... inspiring."

I turned slowly, maintaining my composure. "Frosta."

She smiled, all perfect teeth and cold eyes. "I must say, I'm surprised to see you back so soon. Those ribs of yours must have healed faster than the doctors predicted." She tilted her head, studying me with calculated interest. "Or are you just that eager for another lesson?"

Several onlookers had stopped to watch our exchange, the tension palpable. This was exactly the kind of drama the promotion loved—the fallen champion confronting her conqueror.

"The only lesson from our last fight was that anyone can have a bad night." I replied evenly. "Even me."

Frosta laughed, the sound sharp and dismissive. "A bad night? Is that what you tell yourself?" She leaned closer, lowering her voice. "I broke you, She-Ra. Physically and mentally. Everyone saw it."

I held her gaze steadily, refusing to be baited. "And yet, here I am."

Something flickered across her face then a brief moment of genuine surprise, maybe even respect, quickly masked by her usual arrogance.

"Yes." She acknowledged, her tone shifting slightly. "Here you are. Back in the ring sooner than anyone expected." She paused, then added more quietly, "Good. The division needs you."

The admission caught me off guard. Was that actual sincerity from Frosta?

Before I could respond, she'd already reverted to her public persona. "Just don't expect any special treatment when we inevitably face each other again." She said, voice raised for the benefit of onlookers. "I don't care what mask you wear or what excuses you make. The result will be the same."

She extended her hand, a gesture that appeared sporting on the surface but felt like another power play. "For what it's worth. You better win your rounds."

I took her hand, matching her firm grip. "We'll see, won't we?"

As Frosta turned to leave, tossing her final verbal jab over her shoulder. "Don't worry, I'll be watching your fight. Taking notes for next time." I caught sight of Catra watching our interaction with intense interest from across the room, those mismatched eyes darting between us, clearly sensing the tension.

The encounter with Frosta had left me more rattled than I wanted to admit. Coach Huntara appeared at my side, a steadying presence. "She's in your head. Don't let her stay there."

I nodded, taking a deep breath. "I'm good."

As I resumed greeting fans, I noticed Catra had detached herself from her group and was making her way toward my station, moving with the confident grace I'd always associated with her, though there was something different about her demeanor, a hint of genuine excitement breaking through her usual cool facade.

I straightened, my heartbeat quickening for entirely different reasons. As she approached, I felt a mischievous urge rising within me. How often did I get to see Catra, confident, cutting, always in control and now Catra as a starstruck fan? The opportunity to turn the tables, to fluster her for once, was too tempting to resist.

"Ms. She-Ra." Catra said as she reached my station, her voice carrying that familiar raspy quality but with a politeness I'd rarely heard her use. "It's an honor to meet you."

"The honor is mine." I replied. I leaned forward, giving her my full attention in a way that was deliberately intense. "I always make time for my biggest fans."

I watched with hidden delight as a faint blush crept up Catra's neck at being called a fan.

She glanced briefly toward where Frosta was holding court with reporters, then back at me, her expression hardening. "I saw your exchange with Frosta." She said, a hint of disdain in her voice. "She's even more obnoxious in person than on camera."

The directness of the comment surprised me, though it was quintessential Catra. I found myself appreciating her straightforwardness after Frosta's mind games.

"She earned her moment." I said diplomatically, though I allowed a hint of steel to enter my voice.

"She got lucky." she said with surprising conviction. "Anyone who's watched your careers knows you're the better fighter. You were undefeated for a reason."

Her unwavering belief in my abilities caught me off guard. It was one thing to know Catra was a fan, another entirely to hear her defend me so passionately.

"That's... very kind of you to say." I managed, genuinely touched.

"It's not kindness, it's fact." She insisted, a flash of the stubborn Catra I knew showing through. "Your technique, your power, your ring IQ. They're all superior. The rematch will be a different story."

I couldn't help but smile at her fierce advocacy. "With supporters like you, how can I lose?"

The compliment landed exactly as I'd hoped, Catra's confident demeanor faltered momentarily, that faint blush returning to her cheeks.

"Would you mind signing this?" She asked, regaining her composure and holding out a photograph that she must have brought specifically for this purpose. It wasn't one of the standard promotional shots but a more artistic image from a sports magazine profile. A black and white photo capturing me mid-punch, muscles defined, determination evident even with half my face obscured by the mask.

"For you? I'd be happy to." I said, letting a bit more warmth into my voice than I had with the other fans. I accepted the photo and the pen she offered. "Catra, is it?"

She paused, those mismatched eyes suddenly sharp with confusion. "How did you know my name? I didn't mention it."

My heart skipped a beat. I laughed lightly, covering my momentary panic. "The woman you were with called it across the room earlier when you were speaking with the event organizer. It's a distinctive name. Hard to forget."

Catra's eyes narrowed slightly but then she seemed to accept the explanation. "Right. I guess it is pretty unique."

"It suits you." I said, recovering my composure and turning my attention to the photograph. My hand moved across the photo as I wrote: "To Catra. Your fire is unforgettable. Keep burning bright. With admiration, She-Ra." And beside my signature, I drew a small heart, flourishing it with more care than necessary.

"Thank you," she said, accepting the photo back with careful hands, her eyes scanning what I'd written. Her brows furrowed slightly at the personalized message. "My... fire?"

I smiled, leaning slightly closer. "Just something I sense about you. You're not someone who backs down easily, are you, Catra?"

Her eyes widened in surprise. "No, I'm not." she admitted, sounding almost breathless.

"I thought so." I said with a knowing nod.

Before she could respond, I made a spontaneous decision. "Would you like a photo together? Since you've been following my career so closely?"

The look of shock and excitement that crossed her face was priceless. So different from the carefully controlled expressions she maintained at school.

"I- yes, that would be amazing!" She managed, fumbling for her phone.

"Allow me." Coach Huntara said, stepping forward to take Catra's phone. "I'll make sure it's a good one."

I moved from behind my station to stand beside Catra, who seemed suddenly unsure what to do with herself. Taking advantage of her momentary uncertainty, I placed my arm confidently around her waist, drawing her against my side.

"Relax." I murmured close to her ear, feeling her stiffen at the contact.

Catra took a deep breath and managed to compose herself, though I could feel the heat radiating from her body as Coach Huntara framed the shot.

"Perfect." Coach said after taking several photos. "You two look great together."

Catra stepped away as soon as the photos were taken, checking her phone with what seemed like a mix of disbelief and delight. "Thank you." She said, looking back up at me. "This is... wow."

"My pleasure." I replied with a genuine smile, enjoying this flustered version of Catra more than I probably should have. "It's always nice to meet someone who appreciates the art of fighting."

"I'll be cheering for you tomorrow." she said, still seeming slightly dazed by the encounter. "Front row. You'll hear me."

"I'll listen for your voice." I told her, the words coming out more sincere than I'd intended.

A call from her group finally broke the moment. Catra glanced back, nodding to indicate she'd heard.

"I should go." She said reluctantly. "Thank you again. For everything."

I watched as she walked back to her group, phone clutched in one hand, autograph in the other, her usual graceful stride slightly less steady than normal. When she rejoined her mother, I saw the older woman lean in curiously, examining the photo and autograph while Catra spoke animatedly, gesturing back toward me.

Across the room, I noticed Frosta watching the interaction, a calculating look in her eyes as they moved from me to Catra and back again. When she caught me looking, she smirked and raised her glass once more, as if to say, "Enjoy your fans while you can."

"Friend of yours?" Coach asked once the next fan approached my station, a knowing look in her eyes.

"Something like that." I answered vaguely, turning my attention to the new arrival.

As the event began winding down, I caught Catra looking at me once more from across the room. Our eyes met, and this time,

instead of looking away, I held her gaze for a moment and gave her a small, private nod of acknowledgment.

The flush that rose to her cheeks was visible even from a distance.

As we prepared to leave, I passed near Frosta's station. She was surrounded by admirers, basking in her championship status, but she paused mid-sentence when she saw me.

"She-Ra." She called out, loud enough to draw attention. "Good luck tomorrow. It's always tough coming back after a knockout like that."

The barb was deliberate, designed to remind everyone present of my defeat. I paused, aware of the eyes on us, the tension in the room.

"Thanks." I replied evenly. "It's good to be back."

For a brief moment, her carefully maintained arrogance slipped, and something more genuine showed through. "I mean it." She said, her voice lower so only I could hear.

I nodded once, understanding the complex sentiment behind her words. The genuine respect of one fighter for another, mixed with the competitive drive that defined us both.

For the first time since agreeing to this exhibition match, I felt a thrill of something other than anxiety about my dual identities colliding. There was something exhilarating about being so close to exposure yet still safely hidden behind the mask.

Chapter 11: Return to the Ring

The locker room hummed with pre-fight energy, the snap of hand wraps being secured, the distinctive smell of liniment oil. I sat on a wooden bench, eyes closed, headphones delivering the same playlist I'd used before every professional fight since I was eighteen.

My body had slipped effortlessly back into the routine, muscle memory guiding me through the familiar preparation ritual. Coach Huntara moved around me with practiced efficiency, checking my wraps, testing the gloves, ensuring everything was perfect.

"Five minutes!" The timekeeper announced from the doorway, then disappeared.

I opened my eyes and removed my headphones. The sounds of the arena filtered in. The distant roar of the crowd, the thump of entrance music for the undercard fights, the general buzz of thousands of people gathered to witness controlled violence as sport.

"How are we feeling?" Coach asked, crouching in front of me, her eyes searching mine for any hint of doubt.

"Good." I said and meant it. "I've studied the footage. Peek-A-Blue is quick, but she telegraphs her right hook. Drops her left shoulder slightly before she throws it."

Coach nodded, pleased with my tactical focus. "She likes to counter-punch. Don't get suckered into chasing her. Make her come to you."

"I know. Patient pressure. Create angles. Work the body early to slow her down in the later rounds."

A comfortable silence fell between us as Coach applied petroleum jelly to my face. The familiar sensation was oddly calming.

"You ready for the mask?" She asked, holding up the black half-mask that would complete my transformation into She-Ra.

I nodded, rising to my feet. Coach held up the black half-mask that would complete my transformation into She-Ra. Unlike traditional boxing headgear, this custom-designed piece was made of a specialized polymer composite—thin enough to not impede my vision or breathing, yet durable enough to withstand impacts. We'd spent months working with equipment designers to create something that would protect my identity without compromising my safety or performance in the ring.

"The federation still giving you grief about this?" I asked as Coach helped secure it with medical-grade adhesive around the edges.

"They tried," she replied with a hint of pride. "But after our legal team reminded them there's no rule against it, and our publicity team showed them how much the fans love the mysterious masked champion angle, they backed off. The mask stays."

The mask fitted perfectly against my skin, comfortable yet secure enough to withstand the action to come. I checked myself in the mirror—no trace of Adora the exchange student remained. Only She-Ra, the fighter, stood reflected there.

"Time!" The timekeeper called, reappearing at the door.

Coach Huntara placed her hands on my shoulders, her expression serious. "Remember, this isn't about Frosta or the championship or any of that. Tonight is just about you getting back in there. Finding yourself again."

I nodded, rolling my shoulders to release the last bit of tension. "One round at a time."

"That's my girl."

We moved into the corridor, the sound of the crowd growing louder with each step toward the arena. My entrance music, a driving instrumental piece that had become synonymous with She-Ra's appearances began to play, and the roar intensified.

The corridor seemed to stretch endlessly, the lights at the end growing brighter. I focused on my breathing, on the rhythm of my footsteps, on the weight of the gloves on my hands.

And then we were at the entrance, the full arena spread before us. A sea of faces, camera flashes like stars, banners with my name and image held aloft by fans I'd never met but who had followed my journey from championship to hospital bed and now, hopefully, to redemption.

For one terrible moment, I froze. The enormity of it all crashed down. The expectations, the scrutiny, the memory of my last fight ending with me unconscious on the canvas, the possibility of that happening again tonight.

"Hey!" Coach's voice cut through the noise, her hand firm on my arm. "Eyes on me." I turned to her, grateful for the anchor. "One round at a time." She reminded me. "Nothing else exists." I nodded, centering myself.

With that mantra repeating in my head, I stepped out into the light, raising a gloved hand to acknowledge the thunderous reception. The walk to the ring was a blur of noise and movement, my focus narrowing to the boxing ring at the center of the arena. My true home, the place where all pretense fell away.

The referee called us to the center for instructions, and I got my first close look at Peek-A-Blue—slim but muscular, with quick, darting eyes that assessed me coolly. We touched gloves briefly, a gesture of respect that did nothing to diminish the coming combat.

Back in my corner, Coach gave final instructions, her voice the only clear sound in the cacophony around us.

"First round, feel her out. Don't force anything. Find your rhythm."

The bell rang, clear and commanding, and just like that, I was back in the fight game.

We circled each other cautiously, each throwing probing jabs, testing distance and timing. I felt the familiar calm settle over me. The heightened awareness that came with knowing every move could have consequences, every decision mattered.

Peek-A-Blue was fast, just as I'd expected, her footwork nimble as she darted in and out of range. I kept my guard high, weathering her initial flurry of punches, most of which glanced off my gloves and arms.

Midway through the round, she overextended on a right cross and I countered with a sharp left hook to the body. I heard her exhale sharply, the first sign that my punches were having an effect.

The round ended with us still measuring each other, neither having established clear dominance. In my corner, Coach was pleased.

"Perfect start. She's quick but predictable. Now show her your power."

The second round began at a higher tempo. Peek-A-Blue, perhaps sensing she couldn't outbox me from a distance, began pressing forward more aggressively. I met her advance with a stiff jab that snapped her head back, followed by a right cross that partially landed.

She responded with a flurry of her own, some punches finding their way through my guard to land on my jaw and ribs. The impact was jarring but familiar, the language of the ring, a conversation conducted in controlled violence.

I caught her with a counter uppercut as she came in, and for the first time in the fight, I saw uncertainty flash across her face. She retreated, more cautious now, respect evident in her more measured approach.

By the third round, we had settled into a rhythm of attack and counter, each of us landing significant blows. The crowd responded to every exchange, the energy in the arena electric. This wasn't just a comeback exhibition anymore, it was a genuine contest between two skilled fighters.

Midway through the round, Peek-A-Blue connected with a right hook that I hadn't seen coming. The exact punch Coach had warned me about. My head snapped to the side, vision blurring momentarily.

In that instant, I was back in my last fight against Frosta, feeling that final punch that had sent me to the canvas and then the hospital. The memory was so vivid I could almost hear the count, see Frosta's triumphant face above me, feel the cold floor against my back.

But this wasn't then. This was now.

I shook off the flashback, refocusing on the present threat. Peek-A-Blue, sensing an opportunity, pressed forward with renewed aggression. I weathered her assault, blocking and slipping punches until I found an opening.

When it came, I didn't hesitate. A feint with my left drew her guard high, and I drove a right hand to her midsection, following with a left hook that landed flush on her jaw. She staggered backward, clearly hurt.

I followed up methodically, not wild or reckless, but with the controlled aggression that had made me champion. A jab to keep her on the defensive, another right to the body, an uppercut that lifted her chin toward the arena lights.

The bell saved her from further damage and she returned to her corner on unsteady legs.

"That's it." Coach said in my corner, her voice calm but pleased. "You've got her now. Stay disciplined. Don't rush."

The fourth round saw Peek-A-Blue recover somewhat, using her footwork to avoid extended exchanges. She'd felt my power and didn't want to experience it again.

I cut off the ring methodically, trapping her against the ropes with measured pressure. When she tried to clinch to slow the action, I worked free and punished her with short hooks to the body.

By the fifth round, fatigue was becoming a factor for both of us. My timing was slightly off, some punches missing their mark. Peek-A-Blue found success with counter jabs as I pressed forward, marking up my face.

For a brief moment, doubt crept in. Had I pushed too hard too early? Was my conditioning not what it once was after the long layoff?

Then I remembered Coach's words: One round at a time. Nothing else exists.

I reset, finding my breathing pattern, adjusting my footwork to conserve energy. Peek-A-Blue, perhaps sensing my momentary vulnerability, came forward with a combination. I slipped the first punch, blocked the second, and countered with a perfectly timed right cross that landed flush.

She stumbled backward, stunned. I followed with precision, cutting off her escape routes, landing a three-punch combination that had her sagging against the ropes.

The referee stepped in, giving her a standing eight count. Her eyes were clear enough to continue, but both of us knew the momentum had shifted decisively.

The final round was a demonstration of everything that had once made me champion. I controlled the distance, picked my shots, and showed flashes of the power that had defined my career. Peek-A-Blue fought valiantly but defensively, more concerned with surviving to the final bell than mounting any real offense.

When that bell finally sounded, the arena erupted. I raised my gloves in acknowledgment, my body tired but intact, my mind clear and present in a way it hadn't been for a year.

The decision was a formality unanimous for She-Ra. As the referee raised my hand, I scanned the crowd, taking in the moment. My comeback wasn't just about winning a fight, it was about reclaiming a part of myself I'd feared was lost forever.

In the locker room afterward, away from the cameras and the crowds, Coach Huntara sat beside me as I slowly unwrapped my hands.

"How do you feel?" she asked, her usual gruffness softened by genuine concern.

I considered the question, taking stock of my body. The familiar aches, the swelling beginning around my left eye, the burn in my muscles from six rounds of intense effort. But beyond the physical, I assessed something deeper.

"Like myself again." I answered honestly.

Coach nodded, understanding perfectly. "The question is, which self is that? She-Ra or Adora?"

I didn't have an answer, not yet. But for the first time since my defeat at Frosta's hands, both parts of me felt aligned rather than at war.

"Both, maybe." I said finally. Coach smiled, patting my shoulder as she stood. "That's progress. Now get showered. There's a press conference and then you need to rest. Tomorrow's opponent saw you fight tonight. She'll be prepared."

"Octavia." I nodded, already mentally shifting focus to the next challenge. "Southpaw, likes to work the body."

"Good. Keep that mindset." Coach approved.

As she left me to clean up, I caught sight of myself in the mirror. Mask removed, face slightly marked from the fight, but eyes clear and focused. She-Ra had returned to the ring tonight and proven she still belonged there.

But the comeback wasn't complete yet. Tomorrow would bring another test.

I carefully cleaned my face, assessing the damage. Nothing too visible. A slight swelling under my left eye that would fade by morning, no cuts that would raise questions when I returned. I'd need to be even more careful tomorrow. Octavia was known for targeting the face with her sharp jab.

Tonight's victory was just the first step in a longer journey. One that would eventually require me to reconcile the two worlds I was living in.

Chapter 12: Knockout

Sunday evening arrived with a different energy. The excitement of my return to the ring had been replaced by expectation. Now that I'd proven I could still fight, the question was whether I could dominate as I once had.

I sat in the same locker room, going through the same preparation rituals, but something felt different. Perhaps it was the soreness from yesterday's bout. Subtle reminders in my shoulders and ribs that I wasn't fully recovered yet.

"How's the eye?" Coach Huntara asked, examining the slight swelling under my left eye from Peek-A-Blue's right hook.

"Fine." I said. "Won't affect anything."

She nodded, but I could see the concern she was trying to hide. "Octavia hits harder than Peek-A-Blue. She'll target that side if she spots weakness."

"I'm expecting it." I said, stretching my neck and shoulders. "I've studied her fights."

"And she's studied yours, including last night's. No element of surprise today."

The timekeeper's five-minute warning came and I began my final mental preparation. Octavia was a southpaw with heavy hands and a reputation for breaking opponents down with body shots. She'd been waiting for a shot at me even before my injury. Now she'd see my comeback as her opportunity to make a name for herself.

As Coach applied the petroleum jelly to my face and secured my mask, I visualized the fight ahead. Establish my jab early. Circle away from her power hand. Don't trade in the pocket. Simple, effective strategies that had carried me to championship level.

"Remember, she's a slow starter." Coach said as we headed toward the arena. "First two rounds are yours if you push the pace."

I nodded, focused on the task ahead. The arena seemed even more packed than the previous night, the energy more intense. As my entrance music played and I made my way to the ring, I deliberately kept my eyes forward, not scanning the crowd. I couldn't afford distractions.

Octavia already waiting in the ring. Stocky and powerful, with cropped hair and heavily muscled shoulders. Her eyes tracked me coldly as I climbed through the ropes, assessing, calculating. This wasn't just another opponent, this was someone who had specifically prepared for me.

The referee's instructions were the same as always, but there was a different tension in the center of the ring. When we touched gloves, Octavia's gaze was unflinching, her confidence evident. She believed she could beat me and that made her dangerous.

Back in my corner, Coach gave final instructions. "First round is about establishing distance. Don't let her get inside where she wants to work. Stick and move."

The bell rang and I moved to the center of the ring, circling right to stay away from Octavia's powerful left hand. I established my jab early, keeping her at distance, scoring points without taking risks.

But Octavia was patient, cutting off the ring effectively, gradually reducing my space to maneuver. Late in the round, she trapped me against the ropes and landed a heavy left to my body that forced the air from my lungs. I clinched to recover but the message had been sent. This wouldn't be like last night's relatively comfortable victory.

"She's stronger than she looks." I admitted in the corner between rounds.

"But slower." Coach reminded me. "Use your footwork. Make her miss."

The second round began better as I found my rhythm, landing clean combinations and moving out of range before Octavia could counter. But midway through the round, she timed my movement perfectly and caught me with an overhand left that crashed against my temple.

I staggered, momentarily disoriented, and she pounced. A barrage of punches drove me to the ropes, many landing cleanly. I covered up, weathering the storm, but when I finally escaped, I felt a warm trickle above my right eye. Blood.

The cut wasn't serious, but it was a psychological advantage for Octavia. She pressed forward with renewed confidence, targeting my injury with precise jabs that reopened the cut each time Coach's work in the corner closed it.

By the fourth round, I was being outboxed. Octavia had found her timing, anticipating my movements, countering my attacks with crushing body shots that were steadily sapping my energy and resolve.

"You need this round." Coach said bluntly during the break. "Show me something."

I nodded, digging deep for the champion's mindset that had once come so naturally. The bell rang, and I came out aggressively, taking the fight to Octavia with a ferocity that seemed to surprise her. For a minute, I had the upper hand, landing crisp combinations that snapped her head back and brought the crowd to life.

Then she adjusted, slipping under a right hook I'd thrown with too much commitment, and countered with a devastating left uppercut that caught me flush on the chin.

The world tilted sideways, arena lights swirling above me as I crashed to the canvas. The referee's count seemed to come from

far away: "One! Two! Three!"

Panic seized me, not just from the punch, but from the terrible familiarity of the moment. "Four! Five! Six!"

I tried to move, to get my legs under me, but my body felt disconnected from my commands. The roar of the crowd became a distant buzz, and darkness edged my vision. "Seven! Eight!"

In that moment, teetering between consciousness and defeat, I heard a voice cutting through the noise. High-pitched, enthusiastic, unmistakable: "STATISTICAL ANALYSIS INDICATES YOU CAN STILL WIN THIS FIGHT!" Hold on... is that... Entrapta?

I blinked, clearing my vision enough to scan the crowd. There, in the third row, I saw her purple hair bobbing excitedly as she shouted calculations at the ring. Beside her stood Bow, hands cupped around his mouth as he called out: "Come on, She-Ra! You've got this!"

And Glimmer, jumping up and down, her voice carrying clearly: "Get up! Don't let her win!"

My friends. Here, watching She-Ra fight, having no idea they were cheering for Adora.

"Nine!"

As I struggled to get to my feet, another voice cut through the din... Raspy, fierce, almost desperate in its intensity: "GET UP, DAMN IT! YOU'RE BETTER THAN HER!"

Catra. I found her in the front row, pressed against the barrier, her face flushed with emotion, those mismatched eyes locked on me with an intensity that took my breath away. She wasn't just watching the fight, she was living it, feeling every punch, invested in my victory in a way I'd never seen her invested in anything.

Something ignited in my chest, not just the competitive fire that had driven me throughout my career, but something new.

Something tied to the look, to the faith my friends were showing in a fighter they didn't know was me.

I surged to my feet just before the referee reached ten, steadying myself on shaky legs. The crowd erupted, none louder than the small group in the third row.

"Are you good to continue?" The referee asked, searching my eyes for signs of concussion.

"I'm good." I confirmed, my voice steadier than my legs.

The fight resumed, and Octavia came at me with predatory focus, sensing a finish. But something had changed. The panic that had nearly paralyzed me was gone, replaced by a clarity I hadn't felt since before my injury.

I slipped her first punch, then her second, finding my defensive rhythm. When she overextended on a left hook, I countered with a straight right that stopped her momentum. The surprised look in her eyes told me she'd thought the fight was already won.

For the remainder of the round, I boxed defensively, regaining my composure, finding my distance. In my corner, Coach worked on the cut above my eye, her expression revealing nothing of her thoughts.

"Last two rounds." She said simply. "Show them who you are."

As the fifth round began, I was aware of my friends in the crowd in a way I hadn't been before, not as a distraction but as a source of strength. Each time Octavia drove me to the ropes, I caught glimpses of them: Bow wincing with each punch I took, Glimmer shouting encouragement, Entrapta analyzing the fight in real-time, Catra living and dying with every exchange, her usual cool facade completely abandoned.

Midway through the round, something clicked. A combination I'd practiced thousands of times in training suddenly flowed perfectly

in the ring. Jab, slip, right cross, left hook to the body. Octavia backed up.

I pressed my advantage, not wildly but with calculated aggression, each punch setting up the next. By the end of the round, the momentum had shifted. As I returned to my corner, I caught Catra's eye for the briefest moment. The fierce pride in her expression sent a jolt through me that had nothing to do with the fight.

"One more round." Coach said, her voice low and intense. "She's tiring. Don't let her off the hook."

The final bell rang, and I met Octavia in the center of the ring with renewed determination. She came out aggressively, knowing she needed a strong finish to win on the scorecards. But her punches had lost some of their snap, her movements slowed by fatigue and the body shots I'd invested in earlier.

I weathered her initial barrage, then began my counterattack. A one-two combination backed her up. A left hook to the body made her lower her guard momentarily. And then I saw the opening, the same one I'd visualized in training.

The right hand landed perfectly, catching Octavia as she was setting her feet for her own punch. Her eyes went blank for an instant, legs wobbling beneath her. I followed with a left hook that sent her mouthguard flying and crumpled her to the canvas.

The referee didn't even bother with a count. The fight was over.

As the official raised my hand in victory, the arena exploded with sound. Through my swollen eyes, I searched the crowd until I found them. Entrapta jumping up and down, Bow and Glimmer hugging each other.

The post-fight protocol passed in a blur. The ringside doctor examining my cut, declaring it superficial. Coach wrapping an ice pack around my ribs, officials confirming my next appearance. But throughout it all, I remained acutely aware of the small group in

the third row, and particularly the figure in the front with the mismatched eyes.

As I headed back down the corridor toward the locker room, I made an impulsive decision. Grabbing one of the promotional She-Ra shirts from a merchandise table and a sharpy where i quickly signed the shirt. The crowd was beginning to disperse, but I could still see my friends making their way toward the exit.

With a swift movement that security probably wouldn't have approved if they'd noticed, I called out to glimmer and tossed the rolled-up shirt directly to Glimmer, who caught it with a look of shocked and delight on her face. Before she or the others could react further, I disappeared down the corridor, a strange mix of emotions swirling through me.

In the locker room, Coach eyed me curiously as she helped unwrap my hands. "That was some comeback. What changed when you were down?"

I thought about the voices that had cut through my panic, the faces in the crowd that had anchored me when I was drifting. "I found something worth fighting for." I said simply.

She nodded, accepting the answer without pressing for details. As I showered and changed, carefully removing the mask that had protected my identity, I thought about the complicated web I was weaving. My friends had cheered for She-Ra tonight without knowing they were supporting Adora. Catra had shown more passion watching me fight than she'd ever revealed in the months I've known her.

And I had fought harder, pushed through pain and fear because they were watching. Because somehow, their belief in She-Ra had connected with the part of me that was still learning to believe in Adora.

The ride back to our hotel was quiet, both Coach and I lost in our own thoughts. As I drifted toward sleep that night, exhausted

from the fight but strangely at peace, one image kept returning: Catra's face as I landed the knockout punch, her expression a complex mix of triumph, relief, and something I wasn't ready to name but couldn't seem to forget.

Tomorrow would bring its own challenges. Tonight, I would simply rest in the knowledge that both parts of me had been tested and both had proven stronger than I'd believed possible.

Chapter 13: Couple days rest

Monday morning arrived with piercing sunlight through the hotel curtains. I groaned, every muscle protesting as I rolled out of bed. The familiar post-fight soreness had settled in. A deep ache that spoke of effort and impact, victory earned through pain.

The bathroom mirror delivered the brutal truth. My right eye had swollen overnight, a dark purple bruise spreading across my cheekbone. The cut above my eyebrow had been neatly stitched by the ringside doctor, but the area around it was puffy and tender. My bottom lip was split on one side, and various smaller bruises decorated my jawline and neck.

She-Ra had won, but Adora would pay the price. I crouched down, resting my forehead against the cool edge of the sink and let out a heavy sigh. There was no way I could show up at Brightfall looking like this. Even the most elaborate explanation wouldn't account for what was clearly fighting damage.

Coach Huntara knocked on my door as I was gingerly testing the extent of the bruising on my ribs.

"Breakfast in twenty!" She called through the door. "Meeting with the promotion after."

"Got it." I replied, wincing as I straightened up. Over breakfast in a private dining room, I broke the news to Coach. "There is no way I can go back to campus today." I said, picking at my protein-heavy meal. "Most likely not tomorrow either." She examined my face critically, then nodded. "Smart move. That eye needs at least 48 hours to look less conspicuous. You've got classes?"

"Nothing I can't catch up on." I assured her. "I'll email my professors, say I picked up a virus during the family visit."

"Your parents should be back from their conference by now. I'll have the driver take you straight home after the meeting."

The meeting with the promotion officials went better than expected. My dramatic comeback, especially the knockout victory after being knocked down, had generated significant buzz. They wanted to discuss future fights, including the rematch with Frosta that fans were already clamoring for.

"Let's take it one step at a time." Coach intervened, seeing my hesitation. "She-Ra just returned to the ring. We need to be strategic about the next moves." The officials agreed, though I could see the hunger in their eyes. A She-Ra versus Frosta rematch would be a goldmine and they knew it.

By early afternoon, I was in the back of a private car heading toward Brightfall. The driver, a discreet professional hired by the promotion, maintained a respectful silence as I dozed fitfully in the back seat.

Home was a relief, the scent of my mother's favorite candles. My parents were waiting when I arrived, their expressions a mix of pride and concern as they took in my battered appearance.

"Oh, Adora!" Mom said, gently touching the unbruised side of my face. "Was it worth it?"

I thought about the feeling when the referee raised my hand, the roar of the crowd, the sense of reclaiming something I'd feared was lost forever. "Yes." I said simply. "It was." Dad hugged me carefully, mindful of my ribs. "You fought beautifully. That comeback in the second fight was vintage She-Ra."

"You watched?" I asked, surprised. They'd always supported my boxing career but rarely attended fights, finding it difficult to watch their daughter in combat.

"Livestreamed both nights!" He confirmed. "Wouldn't have missed your return for anything."

Mom's support was more practical. She'd already prepared my room with ice packs, anti-inflammatory medication, and arnica cream for the bruising. But her most valuable contribution came

after dinner, when she placed a shopping bag on the table in front of me.

"For when you go back to campus." She explained.

Inside, I found an assortment of face masks. "These should cover most of the lower facial bruising and the split lip," she said. "And this!" She pulled out a high-end concealer and foundation set, "Is theatrical grade. It won't sweat off during the day and it's designed to cover significant discoloration."

I looked up at her, touched by the thoughtfulness. "When did you get all this?"

"This morning, while you were on your way back. I had a feeling you might need a disguise." She gave me a knowing look. "I raised a boxer remember? I know what the aftermath looks like."

For the rest of the day, I rested, alternating ice and heat on my various injuries, catching up on texts from friends, and practicing with the makeup Mom had bought. It took several attempts but by evening, I'd figured out how to reduce the appearance of the black eye to something that could pass for ordinary tiredness, and the facial mask covered the worst of the lip and jaw bruising.

The eyebrow stitches were more challenging. No amount of makeup would completely disguise them. In the end, I decided to lean into a partial truth: I'd tell people I'd fallen while hiking over the break. The timing worked, and most of the injury could be attributed to a plausible accident.

"You should respond to Glimmer." Mom suggested as I modeled my third outfit option. "Let her know when you'll be back. She's texted you at multiple times today." I checked my phone and winced at the string of increasingly concerned messages. I'd been so focused that I'd neglected to respond.

Sorry for the radio silence! I texted back. *Family trip ran long, caught some bug on the way back. Feeling better now, see you tomorrow!*

Her reply was immediate: *OMG YOU MISSED THE MOST AMAZING FIGHTS! She-Ra was INCREDIBLE! I GOT A SHIRT!!!!*

I smiled despite my split lip. *Can't wait to hear all about it. Save the details for tomorrow?*

Fine but prepare for a full recap. We saw Catra there and you should have SEEN her during the knockout. Never thought I'd say this but it was almost cute how invested she was. I believe we witness her true soul. She acted our age for once and not so stuck up. I wish you could've seen it. I think you would've got a kick out of it.

My heart did an unexpected flip at the mention of Catra's name.

Sounds like I missed quite a show! I replied.

Beyond epic. Rest up and feel better. Can't wait to see you tomorrow!

One thing was certain: the line between my worlds had blurred in ways I hadn't anticipated. My friends had cheered for a fighter they didn't know was their friend. Catra had shown passion and vulnerability in supporting She-Ra that she'd never revealed to anyone.

And I had found strength in their presence that I hadn't known I still possessed.

As I prepared for bed, setting out the clothes and makeup I'd need for my return to campus, I caught sight of myself in the mirror. I was bruised and marked from battle, yet somehow more whole than I'd felt in months.

Whatever tomorrow brought, I would face it with the same determination that had carried me through those final rounds. One challenge at a time, just as in the ring.

Chapter 14: The new trainer

Tuesday morning arrived with a pounding headache and stiffness in every joint. The fights had taken their toll, and no amount of ice or anti-inflammatories could completely erase the evidence.

I spent nearly an hour on my disguise. Layer after layer of high coverage foundation to minimize the black eye, careful styling of my hair to partially obscure the stitched eyebrow, and a light blue medical mask that covered my split lip and most of the jaw bruising. The result wasn't perfect but it would have to do.

"You sure you're up for this?" Dad asked as I gathered my books, eyeing my careful movements with concern.

"I've missed enough class." I said, wincing slightly as I shouldered my backpack. "And the longer I'm gone, the more questions I'll have to answer."

The campus was bustling with post-break energy when I arrived, students exchanging stories about their weekends and comparing notes on upcoming assignments. I kept my head down, hoping to make it to my first class without drawing attention but Glimmer's excited voice cut through my plans.

"Adora!" She waved frantically. Bow and Entrapta beside her. "You're back!"

I braced myself for the inevitable interrogation as I joined them.

"What happened to your eye?" Bow asked immediately, concern evident in his voice. "And why the mask? Are you still sick?"

"Uh, Hiking accident." I explained, touching the edge of the stitches. "Slipped on some rocks during the family trip. As for the mask, yeah I think I still have something, so the mask is just a precaution."

"YOUR INJURY PATTERN SUGGESTS A SIGNIFICANT IMPACT TRAUMA." Entrapta observed, leaning uncomfortably close to examine my partially concealed black eye. "THE DISCOLORATION INDICATES-"

"It looks painful." Glimmer interrupted, shooting Entrapta a warning glance. "If you need anything just let me know! I always have a first aid in my bag. Other than that... You missed THE event of the year! She-Ra's comeback fights were INCREDIBLE!"

"So I heard." I said. "You mentioned something about a shirt?"

Glimmer's eyes lit up. "Yes! The craziest thing happened! After her second fight, She-Ra actually threw a shirt directly to me on her way out! Like, made eye contact and everything!"

"It was amazing," Bow added. "The whole weekend was. The first fight was impressive, but the second... Adora, she got knocked down in the fifth round, and everyone thought it was over. But then she got up and delivered this knockout that had the whole arena going crazy!"

"Sounds intense." I said. "I'm sorry I missed it. But I did end up seeing some of the highlights online."

"Highlights or not at least you saw some of it!" Glimmer said, lowering her voice conspiratorially. " We were talking and i think the best highlight of the weekend was..." Glimmer quickly looked around before continuing. " I think you would've been shocked to see Catra! She completely lost it during the fight. Screaming, jumping up and down. I've never seen her like that about anything."

Something warm fluttered in my chest. "Really? Catra? I knew she was going but didn't know you guys were together?"

Glimmer gave out a little laugh " No we weren't together but from what we could see... Her excitement and dedication had almost made me want to celebrate with her."

"AFFIRMATIVE," Entrapta nodded vigorously. "SHE EXHIBITED EXTREME EMOTIONAL INVESTMENT INCONSISTENT WITH HER TYPICAL BEHAVIORAL PATTERNS. FASCINATING CASE STUDY IN SITUATIONAL PERSONALITY VARIATION."

The warning bell for class cut our conversation. As we hurried inside, Glimmer linked her arm through mine, then quickly released it when I winced involuntarily.

"Sorry! Are you hurt there too?"

"Just some bruising." I said quickly. "I landed pretty hard when I fell."

Throughout the morning classes, I fielded similar questions about my mask and visible injuries. Most people accepted my hiking accident story without much scrutiny, though I noticed Professor Netossa watching me with particular interest during Cultural Studies.

"Ms. Grayskull, can you stay behind a moment." I told glimmer and the group i would catch up to them. "That must have been quite a fall." She started. "I hope you're recovering well."

"Yes, ma'am." I replied, uncomfortably aware of her evaluating gaze. "Just clumsy, I guess."

"Hmm," was all she said, but something in her expression made me wonder if she suspected there was more to the story.

By lunchtime, I was exhausted from the constant vigilance required to maintain my cover and manage my pain. The cafeteria's noise and bustle felt overwhelming.

"You sure you're okay?" Bow asked as I picked at my food, my appetite diminished by both pain and stress. "You seem... off."

"Just tired." I assured him.

"Perhaps you should visit the campus medical center." Entrapta suggested.

"I'm fine, really." I insisted, desperate to change the subject. "Tell me more about the fights. I heard Frosta was gonna be there?"

The question was risky. I knew very well that Frosta had been at the gala but not at the actual fights, but it successfully diverted them.

"No, thankfully." Glimmer said. "Can you imagine how awkward that would have been? She's the one who put She-Ra in the hospital last year."

"I heard it was brutal." I said carefully.

"Well, the medical records were never released, BUT sports analyst suggests three broken ribs, orbital fracture, and significant internal bleeding." Entrapta supplied helpfully.

I winced, the clinical description bringing back all too vivid memories. "Sounds rough."

As we were leaving the cafeteria, an announcement crackled over the campus-wide speaker system: "Attention all students and faculty. Please proceed to the main gymnasium at 2 PM for a special university announcement. Attendance is strongly encouraged. That's the main gymnasium at 2 PM. Thank you."

"What's that about?" I wondered aloud.

"No idea." Bow shrugged. "But if they're calling everyone together, it must be important."

At 2 PM, we joined the steady stream of students filing into the gymnasium. The space had been set up with rows of chairs facing a small stage where a podium displayed the Brightfall University logo. Faculty members were gathered to one side, including Dr. Moon and Professor Netossa.

"Let's grab seats near the front." Glimmer suggested, leading our group toward the rapidly filling rows.

As we settled into our chairs, I scanned the crowd unconsciously. My gaze stopped abruptly when it landed on a familiar figure several rows across.

She sat with her usual entourage, Scorpia to her right, the rest of her group filling the surrounding seats. Unlike her friends, who were chatting animatedly, Catra seemed lost in thought, her expression uncharacteristically soft, almost vulnerable.

Something fluttered in my stomach as I watched her. I'd felt it before, in fragments: when she'd visited She-Ra's station at the gala, when she'd cheered so fiercely during the fight, even during some of our more heated exchanges at school.

But this was different. Seeing her now, unaware of being observed, I was struck by a realization that caught me completely off guard: Catra was beautiful.

Not just in the conventional sense, though she certainly was, those striking mismatched eyes, the wild mane of brown hair that somehow always looked perfectly tousled, the elegant lines of her face. But beautiful in a deeper way that I hadn't allowed myself to acknowledge before.

The Catra I'd glimpsed during my fights, passionate, uninhibited, genuinely invested was a stark contrast to the carefully guarded person she presented at school.

I found myself studying her with new interest, the graceful way she tucked a strand of hair behind her ear, the slight furrow of concentration between her brows, the subtle curve of her lips as she half-smiled at something Scorpia said. Her fitted burgundy sweater and black jeans highlighted a figure that was both athletic and feminine in a way that made my cheeks warm beneath my mask.

Had she always been this captivating or was I seeing her differently now, after witnessing her completely unguarded during my fights? After hearing her voice cut through my moment of panic, anchoring me when I was lost?

"Earth to Adora." Glimmer's voice broke into my thoughts, her elbow gently nudging my side. "You're staring."

I quickly looked away from Catra. "Sorry, just zoned out for a second."

"At Catra?" Bow whispered, glancing in her direction with raised eyebrows.

"No, I was just... my mind wandered." I stammered but was saved from further explanation as Dr. Moon approached the podium, calling for attention.

"Good afternoon, students and colleagues!" She began, her voice carrying clearly through the gymnasium. "Thank you for coming together on such short notice. I'm excited to share some news that I believe will be of great interest to many of you."

She gestured to the side of the stage. "Brightfall University has always prided itself on offering our students access to the very best in every field. Today, I'm pleased to announce a special opportunity in our athletic department."

A murmur of interest spread through the crowd as Dr. Moon continued.

"For the next month, our fitness programs will feature a guest trainer of international renown! Someone who exemplifies the dedication, discipline and excellence that we strive to instill in all our students."

I should've looked but I didn't care to look when my preferential vision caught someone walking up to the stage.

"Please join me in welcoming world champion boxer and Brightfall University's special guest instructor! Frosta!"

The gymnasium erupted in applause and cheers as a familiar figure strode onto the stage. White and blue hair styled in its characteristic sharp cut, athletic build evident even in her business casual attire, that confident set to her jaw that I'd last seen across a gala ballroom.

The room seemed to tilt around me, blood rushing in my ears as panic set in. This couldn't be happening.

"As many of you know." Dr. Moon continued over the applause, "Frosta is the current world champion in women's boxing and has graciously agreed to offer specialized training sessions open to all students, regardless of experience level. This is a unique opportunity to learn from one of the greatest athletes of our generation."

Frosta stepped to the microphone, her signature confident smile in place. "Thank you for that warm welcome. I'm excited to share my knowledge and experience with Brightfall's students. Boxing isn't just about fighting, it's about discipline, strategy, and pushing past your limits. I look forward to working with anyone interested in discovering their own strength."

More applause followed. I sat frozen in my seat. "Adora? Are you okay?" Bow whispered, concern evident in his voice. "You've gone really pale."

"I'm Fine." I managed, though my voice sounded distant even to my own ears. "THIS IS AN UNPRECEDENTED OPPORTUNITY TO STUDY ELITE ATHLETIC TRAINING METHODOLOGIES AND PHYSICAL FORM!" Entrapta was saying, already typing frantically on her tablet. "WE SHOULD ALL REGISTER FOR SESSIONS!"

"Totally!" Glimmer agreed enthusiastically. "Even I'm interested, and you know how I feel about unnecessary exercise."

"Adora you would crush it!" Bow added. "With your martial arts background, you'd probably impress even a champion like Frosta."

The irony was so bitter I could taste it. "I don't think so." I said weakly. "Not really my thing."

As Dr. Moon outlined the details of Frosta's training schedule and how students could register, I tried to calm my racing heart. This was a disaster.

When the announcement concluded and students began filing out of the gymnasium, I remained seated, too overwhelmed to move. My friends waited patiently, attributing my shock to my "illness" and "injury" rather than the true cause.

"We don't have to sign up if you're not feeling well." Glimmer offered, misinterpreting my distress. "Though it would be pretty amazing..."

"You guys go ahead!" I said, forcing a smile they couldn't see behind my mask. "I might join later when I'm feeling better."

As we finally stood to leave, I glanced once more toward where Catra had been sitting, only to find her looking directly at me. Our eyes met across the thinning crowd, then her gaze shifted to the stage where Frosta was speaking with Dr. Moon, back to me, and a slight furrow appeared between her brows. Before I could interpret her expression, she was gone, disappearing into the crowd with her usual graceful efficiency.

I didn't realize until later, replaying the moment in my mind, that what I'd glimpsed in Catra's eyes might have been concern. As if she'd recognized my distress and, against all expectations, cared about it.

But that realization was overshadowed by the more immediate crisis: Frosta was here, at my school, threatening the careful separation I'd maintained between She-Ra and Adora. And I had absolutely no idea what to do about it.

Chapter 15: The slip up

"Actually, I think I'm going to head home," I said, adjusting my mask as we exited the gymnasium. "I'm feeling a bit worse than I thought."

Glimmer's face creased with concern. "Want me to walk with you? My next class isn't for an hour."

"No, it's fine!" I insisted, already backing away. "I just need some rest. I'll text you later, okay?"

Before they could protest further, I turned and walked quickly toward the main campus exit, feeling their worried gazes on my back. But once out of sight, I changed direction, heading not toward home but to the athletics building.

My mind raced with the implications of Frosta's arrival. For an entire month... I would have to navigate campus knowing she could appear around any corner. Every carefully constructed element of my new life felt suddenly precarious, as if balanced on the edge of a cliff with winds rising.

The basement storage room that I'd converted into my private training space was exactly as I'd left it, heavy bag hanging from reinforced chains, small collection of weights in the corner, workout mat spread across the dusty floor. I locked the door behind me, dropped my backpack, and unwound the hand wraps from my pocket.

I didn't bother with proper warm-up or technique. This wasn't training; this was release. The first punch landed with a satisfying thud, sending the heavy bag swinging. I followed with another, and another, each impact reverberating up my arms and into my already sore shoulders.

It felt good. With each punch, I channeled a different frustration: Frosta's smug smile on stage. The way she'd taunted me at the

gala. The memory of lying in a hospital bed, doctors discussing whether I'd ever fight again. The constant vigilance required to maintain my separate identities. The exhaustion of hiding who I really was.

I lost track of time as I pummeled the bag, my breathing growing ragged, sweat soaking through my clothes despite the basement's cool air. The mask made it harder to breathe, but I was beyond caring. My body protested, ribs aching, muscles burning from the weekend's fights but the physical pain was almost a relief compared to the emotional turmoil.

As my rhythm intensified, the room grew uncomfortably warm. Without breaking stride, I yanked off my sweatshirt, tossing it aside and continuing in just my tank top, relishing the cooler air against my skin.

That's when I heard it, a small, sharp intake of breath from behind me.

I whirled around, fists still raised, to find Catra standing just inside the door, her eyes wide with shock. For a suspended moment, we stared at each other in mutual disbelief.

I became acutely aware of what she was seeing: my arms fully exposed, revealing not just the defined muscles of a boxer but the intricate tattoos that covered my biceps and shoulders; my tank top damp with sweat, clinging to the athletic physique I'd carefully concealed for months; my face partially uncovered where the mask had slipped during my workout, revealing more of the bruising than I'd intended anyone to see.

"Catra" I gasped, scrambling for the discarded sweatshirt. "What are you—how did you—"

I moved too quickly, my foot catching on the edge of the mat. Already off-balance from the abrupt halt in my workout, I stumbled, pain shooting through my ribs as I fell awkwardly to one knee.

In an instant, Catra was beside me, not with the mockery or accusation I expected, but with a surprising gentleness. Her hand on my arm was steady, helping me regain my balance.

"Hey take it easy." She said, her voice softer than I'd ever heard it. "You're hurt."

She retrieved my sweatshirt and, instead of handing it to me, held it open. "Here."

Either too stunned to protest or just completely lost inb what to do next, I slipped my arms into the sleeves, wincing as the movement pulled at my sore ribs. Catra carefully helped adjust it over my shoulders, her actions so at odds with our usual antagonistic dynamic that I found myself speechless.

We ended up sitting on the mat facing each other, an arm's length apart, silence stretching between us. Her eyes never left mine, those mismatched irises filled with questions I wasn't sure I could answer.

The turmoil inside me was roaring. Had she seen the details of the tattoos? Or was it just quick enough that didn't see the She-ra design. What do I do in this situation? If it were Glimmer or even Bow I might just face the fact that they saw, but this is Catra. I can't get exposed because of her! I stare at her completely conflicted unsure of why she is just staring at me and won't say anything. If she's not gonna say anything, then I will.

"Why are you here? And what are you doing following me?" I finally asked. "Actually, how long have you been following me and standing there?" There was a little bit of anger starting to rise in me.

"Since you left the gym." She admitted without a hint of embarrassment. "I caught a glimps of you in the gym and I don't know. You just didn't look good. After I watched you ditch your friends, I felt like something was wrong so here I am." Catra

waved a hand at the air. "Turns out... I didn't need to worry at all. You seemed to just want to hit something."

The admission seemed to surprise her as much as it did me.

"Worried about me..?" I asked.

"Forget I said anything." She said, her usual defensive edge back her voice. "I knew something was off with you. I've known it since you arrived at Brightfall. The way you move, how you're always hiding your body under those baggy clothes, how you pretend not to understand the language..." She shook her head, a small smile playing at her lips. "I've been trying to figure you out for months."

"Well tell me Catra, just what have you figured out?" I said, adjusting my sleeve. " I wanna know what you think of me in that invasive thick brain of yours." I'm not sure why I was starting to get more angry.

Catra watched the movement, her expression growing a little uncomfortable. "Let me see behind your mask." She said quietly, reaching toward my face.

I caught her wrist, but instead of pulling away, she placed her other hand over mine. "Let me see Adora. I can't tell you what I think until I confirmed it." She repeated.

"Confirm what?" I challenged, not removing my grip from her wrist. "You always do whatever you want and now... well now, you are invading my private space where I let off some steam and can be by myself!"

Catra's eyes widened and she looked almost hurt? Regretting her following me? I'm not sure what is going through her head. "Why do you keep doing this?" I ask all my anger faded by exhaustion.

Catra stays quiet for a moment before sighing and then almost a whisper as she responds. "I don't know, since you came to this school, I have been intrigued by how unique you are. There is something about you that keeps pulling me towards you." She

looks away and starts to pull her hand back but my grip remains locked on her wrist. We stay quiet a moment longer when Catra speaks up. "I'm sorry, I know I invaded your space and I'll leave and won't say anything."

Part of me wanted to tell her to leave, get out and don't ever talk to me again but a part of me wanted someone to understand and take that weight of my shoulders, even if it is Catra.

"You can look... If you want." I finally decided.

Slowly, I released my grip. There was a pause before she moved. With a deliberate gentleness that seemed so incongruous with the Catra I thought I knew, she hooked her fingers around the edges of my mask and carefully pulled it away.

Her sharp intake of breath told me what she was seeing: the split lip, the dark bruising along my jaw, my swollen cheek.

But instead of recoiling, Catra leaned closer, her eyes studying every detail with an intensity that made my heart race, making me forget that in fact i should not be doing this and I should still be angry. She raised her hand, hesitating for just a moment before her fingertips gently touched my cheek, brushing away some of the foundation I'd so carefully applied.

"I knew you were hiding something..." She murmured, her touch impossibly soft as it traced the contours of my bruised face. "But this..." She shook her head in wonder. "Never in a million years would I have guessed you were She-Ra. It's... it's impossible."

I choked on my own breathing. "She-ra??" I coughed out panicking. How the hell did she immediately go to that??? "What on earth makes you think I am She-ra??" I asked more urgently and I start pulling away. Catra doesn't let me get far by gripping the back of my head. "Because I saw the tattoos dummy! The cuts and bruising on your face also gave it away! If you really are that dumb to really think I wouldnt notice then... well then you

are a much bigger idiot!" I just stare at her mouth agape and lost on how to respond.

Her gaze moved from my face to my hands, still partially wrapped, then back up. Understanding dawned in her eyes, mixed with something that looked almost like awe.

"It's really you." She breathed. "The three-time champion. The fighter I've been following for years..."

"The same annoying exchange student you've been tormenting for months." I added.

A flush spread across her cheeks. "It's not like I knew you could, if you wanted to, knock me out in one punch. If I'd known-"

"You'd have been nicer?" I finished for her.

She laughed softly, the sound surprisingly genuine. "No, I'd probably have asked for boxing lessons."

The answer was so unexpected, so quintessentially Catra, that I found myself laughing too, despite the pain it caused my ribs.

When our laughter faded, she looked at me with an expression I'd never seen on her face before, open, unguarded, almost tender. "Can you put the mask back on?" She asked quietly.

Confused, I complied, securing the mask over my nose and mouth, leaving only my eyes exposed.

Catra studied me for a long moment, her gaze so intense I could almost feel it like a physical touch. "Heh, how didn't I catch this earlier?" She said softly. "With or without the mask, She-Ra or Adora... your eyes are as beautiful as ever. The same blue I've seen in both."

The unexpected compliment sent warmth flooding through me, a sensation entirely different from the adrenaline of fighting or the

exertion of training. For a moment, we simply looked at each other, something unspoken passing between us.

"Thanks?" I said finally, unsure on how to respond.

Catra seemed to suddenly realize what she'd said, how she was behaving. Her eyes widened, and she looked away quickly, a deeper flush coloring her cheeks. "I—that's not—I mean, objectively speaking, of course. Just an observation. Not that I've been observing closely or anything."

Her flustered stammering was so at odds with her usual cool demeanor that I couldn't help but chuckle. "Of course." I agreed, deciding to spare her further embarrassment. "Just an observation, if it were anything else you wouldn't be Catra."

She cleared her throat, visibly trying to regain her composure. "So... all this time, you've been living this double life? Boxing champion by night, exchange student by day?"

"Not exactly," I explained, grateful for the change of subject. "I took a break from boxing after the Frosta fight. The injuries were... significant. I came to Brightfall to recover, to have some space from being She-Ra." I ran my hand through my money tail. "I wasn't going to fight for a while but then I was invited to this event the last weekend and couldn't say no. Even if it was small fights, I wanted to feel again."

"The exhibition matches." She nodded, understanding dawning. "That's why you couldn't go with your friends. You were fighting."

"Yep. And now I am conflicted and frustrated at the fact that Frosta is here." I said, unable to keep the dismay from my voice. "For a month."

"Does she know? About you being Adora?"

I shook my head. "No one knows. Except you, now." At that comment my tone and face became serious. "Look Catra. I'm not going to get mad at you for finding me here and finding out I am

She-ra. I am mad at myself for being so out of it that I decided to risk it and now I have exposed myself. That's on me not you." Catra started to say something when I cut her off. "Please just listen."

I sighed and rubbed my hands on my face. "I am Adora. Right now I am Adora. While I am here, I am Adora. Do you get what I'm saying?" Catra nodded. "If anyone finds out who I really am, I can just say goodbye to my normal college life. The whole reason no one knows my true identity is for the fact that I can walk the streets and be a normal person without all the crap that follows. Without the special treatment from people who want to be friends or be near me." I used the finger quotations on the word special.

"To be honest, even tho you are WAY into my business." I pointed at Catra and she scoffed. "The fact that the way you were treating me made me kinda happy." Catra gave a little laugh "You enjoy how mean I am to you? Wow didn't take you for someone who enjoys masochism." It took me a second to register what she just said and I had to throw my head back and laugh.

"HAHAHA. One I am not a masochism and two it's the fact you were you and treated me like you do anyone else. There was no special treatment and it is normal." I smiled and laid down. "Hey." I looked at catra as she spoke.

"I won't tell anyone." She said, her voice soft but firm. "I promise."

"Why not?" I asked, genuinely curious.

"Because it's important to you." She said simply. "And because..." she hesitated, seeming to choose her words carefully, "maybe I've been wrong about you. Maybe I've been wrong about a lot of things."

The admission seemed to cost her, vulnerability not coming easily to her. We sat in silence for a moment, the atmosphere between us charged with something new and undefined.

"What are you going to do with Frosta here?" She asked eventually. "She'll be all over campus."

"I don't know." I admitted. "I'm still processing that she's actually here."

Catra nodded thoughtfully. "We'll figure something out."

"We?" I repeated, surprised by the pronoun.

She looked almost as surprised as I felt, but didn't retract it. "Yes, we. I know her fighting style better than most fans. I've analyzed all her matches. And now..." she gestured between us, "I'm involved, whether either of us planned it or not."

The idea of Catra as an ally rather than an adversary was so novel, so unexpected, that I hardly knew how to respond. Yet something about it felt right, as if the universe had been nudging us toward this moment all along.

"Thank you." I said finally, the words inadequate for what I was feeling but all I could offer.

She shrugged, a hint of her usual nonchalance returning, though softened now. "Don't thank me yet."

"Why does that almost sound like a threat?" I joked. "It's not!" Catra retorted.

"Yeah yeah, one step at a time." I said, echoing Coach Huntara's advice.

We fell into a comfortable silence, the tension that had defined our previous interactions replaced by something more complex and, in its way, more intimate. Catra's eyes occasionally drifted to my arms, now covered again by the sweatshirt but clearly occupying her thoughts.

Finally, she seemed to gather her courage. "Can I..." she began, then paused, uncharacteristically hesitant. "Can I see your

tattoos?"

"What?" I asked, genuinely startled by the request.

Chapter 16: The story on her skin

"Can I see your tattoos?"

The question hung in the air between us, unexpected and strangely intimate. I stared at Catra, trying to process her request.

"What?" I repeated, unsure if I'd heard her correctly.

A faint blush colored her cheeks, but she didn't back down. "Your tattoos." She said, gesturing toward my covered arms. "I caught a glimpse before you put your sweatshirt back on. They looked... intricate."

I hesitated, suddenly self-conscious in a way that had nothing to do with hiding my She-Ra identity. Showing someone my tattoos felt personal, perhaps even more personal than revealing my secret career. These markings told the story of my journey as a fighter, but they were also connected to something deeper, more ancestral.

"You don't have to." Catra added quickly, misinterpreting my silence. "It was just..."

"No, it's okay." I said, surprising myself. "I just... haven't shown them to anyone here. They're part of what I've been hiding."

Slowly, I raise my arms and pushed up the sleeves of my sweatshirt, revealing the artwork that covered both arms. On my right arm, a series of geometric patterns interwoven with symbols of strength and perseverance; on my left, flowing designs that represented speed and adaptability—the balanced qualities every fighter needs.

Catra leaned closer, her eyes wide with appreciation. "Woah, these are beautiful." She murmured, studying the details. "Did they hurt?"

"Some more than others," I admitted. "The ones near the elbow and inner arm were the worst."

Her fingers hovered over a particularly intricate section on my right bicep, a stylized lion surrounded by ancient glyphs. "May I?" she asked, her voice uncharacteristically hesitant.

I nodded, holding my breath as her fingertips lightly traced the pattern. Her touch was gentle, almost reverent, sending an unexpected shiver up my spine.

"This one means courage." I explained, trying to focus on the tattoo rather than her touch. "I got it after my first professional win. But the design itself..." I paused, wondering how much to reveal. "It's actually based on my family's heritage."

Catra looked up, curiosity clear in her mismatched eyes. "Your family's heritage?"

I nodded. "My father's side of the family has been in Brightfall for generations. One of the founding families, actually."

"Seriously?" Her eyebrows rose in surprise. "So when you said you grew up here..."

"It wasn't just that my parents moved here for work," I confirmed. "My roots in this place go deep. My great-grandfather was a historian who collected and preserved a lot of the traditional art and symbolism of the region."

I traced a particular pattern on my arm. "These designs, they're adaptations of drawings he made. When I started boxing and wanted my first tattoo, my dad showed me his old journals. Something about the imagery just... connected with me."

"So all these symbols, they're traditional Brightfall designs?"

I nodded. "Modified for my journey, but yes. The foundation is from my family's history here."

Catra studied the tattoos with renewed interest. "That's... actually really cool. So they're not just about boxing. They connect you to this place."

"Exactly." I smiled, touched by her understanding. "When I'm fighting as She-Ra, I'm also carrying this part of my heritage with me. It's like having my ancestors in my corner, in a way."

Her eyes lifted to meet mine, something unreadable in their mismatched depths. "Is there more? Beyond what I can see?"

My heart skipped a beat. "Yes." I admitted. "My back has the largest piece. It ties everything together."

Her gaze remained steady, questioning but not demanding. I knew what she was asking, and the implications made my pulse quicken. To show her that tattoo, I'd need to...

"I'd have to take off my shirt..." I said, the words coming out more abruptly than I'd intended.

Realization dawned on Catra's face, and the blush that had been fading returned with greater intensity. "Oh," she said. "You don't have to. I didn't mean to make you-"

"It's fine." I interrupted, making a decision before I could overthink it. "I mean, if you want to see it, I don't mind."

The truth was more complicated. Part of me was nervous, not just about revealing more of my body, but about the strangely charged atmosphere that had developed between us. Yet another part, a part I hadn't acknowledged until this moment, wanted her to see, wanted to share this aspect of myself that had been hidden for so long.

Catra seemed equally conflicted, her usual confidence momentarily abandoned. "Only if you're comfortable." She said finally.

I nodded, I sat up and turned away slightly as I gathered my courage. Then, in one fluid motion, I pulled the sweatshirt over my head, followed by my tank top, leaving me in just my sports bra. The cool air of the basement raised goosebumps on my exposed skin.

I heard Catra's soft intake of breath and resisted the urge to cross my arms over myself. Instead, I turned my back to her, revealing the centerpiece of my tattoo collection.

Down the length of my spine ran a sword, its blade detailed with ancient script and symbols of power. From it extended intricate patterns that spread across my shoulder blades and lower back, a tapestry of images that represented my journey as She-Ra. Hidden within the design were elements that told my story: a small crown for my first championship, three stars for my title defenses, a broken chain for overcoming limitations, and at the base of my spine, a phoenix rising from ashes. The piece I'd added after beginning my recovery from the Frosta fight.

"The sword design," I explained softly, "was something my great-grandfather found in an ancient text about Brightfall's founding legends. According to him, the first settlers here believed in a warrior goddess who carried a sword of light and protected the innocent. He sketched it in his journals, and when I was looking for something to represent She-Ra, it just... felt right."

For several long moments, Catra said nothing. The silence made me increasingly self-conscious, and I was about to reach for my discarded shirt when I felt it, the whisper-soft touch of fingertips against my skin.

I froze, a shiver that had nothing to do with the cold running through me as Catra's fingers traced the outline of the sword down my spine. Her touch was feather-light, almost reverential, as she followed the intricate patterns across my back.

"This is..." she began, her voice low and slightly husky. "Adora, this is incredible."

The way she said my name sent another shiver through me. Cautiously, I glanced over my shoulder to find her face mere inches from mine, her eyes focused on the tattoo but filled with an expression I'd never seen in them before, a mixture of wonder and something deeper, more intense. Desire.

"The detail is amazing!" She murmured, fingers still tracing the patterns. "It's like your whole story is written on your skin."

"That was the idea." I said, my voice barely above a whisper. "Boxing has been my life for so long, and connecting it to my family's history here... it made sense."

Our eyes met, and suddenly the air between us felt charged with electricity. She was close enough that I could feel her breath against my skin, could see the subtle flecks of gold in her blue eye, the depth of color in her amber one. Neither of us moved, caught in a moment of suspended possibility.

I turned slowly to face her fully, the movement bringing us even closer. Her gaze dropped briefly to my lips, then back to my eyes, a question in her expression that I wasn't sure I knew how to answer or perhaps was afraid to.

The space between us seemed to shrink, though I couldn't tell if she was leaning closer or if I was. My heart pounded so loudly I was certain she must hear it.

The metallic sound of the doorknob turning broke the spell.

We froze, panic replacing whatever had been building between us. Someone was coming in where I was half-dressed with my tattoos fully exposed, where Catra and I were sitting far too close for any casual explanation.

Before I could react, Catra grabbed my arm and yanked me toward the corner of the room. "Supply closet." She hissed, already pulling me toward a narrow door I'd barely noticed before.

We tumbled inside just as the main door opened, Catra pulling the closet door closed behind us. The space was tiny, barely large enough for cleaning supplies, let alone two people. We stood pressed together in the darkness, hardly daring to breathe, my bare skin dangerously close to hers.

I could hear multiple voices now, not just one person, but a group entering the room. Their footsteps echoed as they moved around the space we'd just vacated.

"Hey, check this out!" A male voice said, sounding surprised. "There's a heavy bag down here. Was this always here?"

"No way." another voice responded. "This is supposed to be storage. Someone's set up their own little gym."

"Look at the wraps on the floor." a female voice pointed out. "Someone was just here."

My heart hammered against my ribcage. My discarded hand wraps, I hadn't had time to grab them before we'd rushed into hiding. Worse, my shirt and sweatshirt were still out there somewhere.

"Should we report this?" one of them asked.

"For what?" another countered. "It's just some equipment. Probably a fitness student getting in extra practice."

"It's pretty cool, actually." the first voice said. "Maybe we could use it too."

The conversation continued, the group debating whether to leave things as they found them or report the unauthorized use of space. All the while, I remained acutely aware of Catra pressed against me in the darkness. Her hand still rested lightly on my waist, her fingers inadvertently brushing against my bare skin with each breath I took.

I couldn't see her clearly in the dim light, but I could feel her. Every point of contact between us sending currents of awareness through my body. Her breath was warm against my neck, slightly uneven despite her apparent outward calm.

The voices outside seemed to reach a consensus. "Let's just leave it. Not our business if someone found an empty room to work out in."

"Yeah, we've got enough to do setting up for tomorrow's orientation without worrying about this."

Footsteps moved toward the door, voices fading as the group prepared to leave. I should have been focusing entirely on whether they would discover us, on what excuse I could possibly make if they opened the closet door to find me half-dressed with Catra.

Instead, all I could focus on was Catra herself, the subtle scent of her perfume, the warmth radiating from her body, the almost imperceptible trembling of her fingers against my skin. Was it fear of discovery making her tremble or something else entirely?

Finally, the main door closed, and silence fell over the room outside our hiding place. Neither of us moved immediately, perhaps waiting to be certain the intruders were truly gone.

Or perhaps, like me, Catra was reluctant to break whatever spell had fallen over us in this tiny, hidden space.

When she finally spoke, her voice was barely a whisper, her lips so close to my ear that I felt rather than heard the words: "I think they're gone."

But she didn't move away and I found I didn't want her to. For this suspended moment, politics and rivalries and complications didn't exist, there was only the darkness, the closeness, and the inexplicable feeling that something significant was happening between us.

My entire awareness narrowed to Catra. Her hand on my waist, Catra's breath against my skin, Catra's eyes reflecting what little light filtered through the cracks in the door as they remained fixed on mine.

Chapter 17: A new Complication

"Can I see your tattoos?"

The question hung in the air between us, unexpected and strangely intimate. I stared at Catra, trying to process her request.

"What?" I repeated, unsure if I'd heard her correctly.

A faint blush colored her cheeks, but she didn't back down. "Your tattoos," she said, gesturing toward my covered arms. "I caught a glimpse before you put your sweatshirt back on. They looked... intricate."

I hesitated, suddenly self-conscious in a way that had nothing to do with hiding my She-Ra identity. Showing someone my tattoos felt personal—perhaps even more personal than revealing my secret career. These markings told the story of my journey as a fighter, but they were also connected to something deeper, more ancestral.

"You don't have to," Catra added quickly, misinterpreting my silence. "It was just-"

"No, it's okay," I said, surprising myself. "I just... haven't shown them to anyone here. They're part of what I've been hiding."

Slowly, I pushed up the sleeves of my sweatshirt, revealing the artwork that covered both arms from wrist to shoulder. On my right arm, a series of geometric patterns interwoven with symbols of strength and perseverance; on my left, flowing designs that represented speed and adaptability—the balanced qualities every fighter needs.

Catra leaned closer, her eyes wide with appreciation. "These are beautiful," she murmured, studying the details. "Did they hurt?"

"Some more than others," I admitted. "The ones near the elbow and inner arm were the worst."

Her fingers hovered over a particularly intricate section on my right bicep, a stylized lion surrounded by ancient glyphs. "May I?" she asked, her voice uncharacteristically hesitant.

I nodded, holding my breath as her fingertips lightly traced the pattern. Her touch was gentle, almost reverent, sending an unexpected shiver up my spine.

"This one means courage," I explained, trying to focus on the tattoo rather than her touch. "I got it after my first professional win. But the design itself..." I paused, wondering how much to reveal. "It's actually based on my family's heritage."

Catra looked up, curiosity clear in her mismatched eyes. "Your family's heritage?"

I nodded. "My father's side of the family has been in Brightfall for generations. One of the founding families, actually."

"Seriously?" Her eyebrows rose in surprise. "So when you said you grew up here..."

"It wasn't just that my parents moved here for work," I confirmed. "My roots in this place go deep. My great-grandfather was a historian who collected and preserved a lot of the traditional art and symbolism of the region."

I traced a particular pattern on my arm. "These designs, they're adaptations of drawings he made. When I started boxing and wanted my first tattoo, my dad showed me his old journals. Something about the imagery just... connected with me."

"So all these symbols, they're traditional Brightfall designs?"

I nodded. "Modified for my journey, but yes. The foundation is from my family's history here."

Catra studied the tattoos with renewed interest. "That's... actually really cool. So they're not just about boxing—they connect you to this place."

"Exactly." I smiled, touched by her understanding. "When I'm fighting as She-Ra, I'm also carrying this part of my heritage with me. It's like having my ancestors in my corner, in a way."

Her eyes lifted to meet mine, something unreadable in their mismatched depths. "Is there more? Beyond what I can see?"

My heart skipped a beat. "Yes," I admitted. "My back has the largest piece. It ties everything together."

Her gaze remained steady, questioning but not demanding. I knew what she was asking, and the implications made my pulse quicken. To show her that tattoo, I'd need to...

"I'd have to take off my shirt," I said, the words coming out more abruptly than I'd intended.

Realization dawned on Catra's face, and the blush that had been fading returned with greater intensity. "Oh," she said. "I didn't mean to-"

"It's fine," I interrupted, making a decision before I could overthink it. "I mean, if you want to see it, I don't mind."

The truth was more complicated. Part of me was nervous—not just about revealing more of my body, but about the strangely charged atmosphere that had developed between us. Yet another part, a part I hadn't acknowledged until this moment, wanted her to see, wanted to share this aspect of myself that had been hidden for so long.

Catra seemed equally conflicted, her usual confidence momentarily abandoned. "Only if you're comfortable," she said finally.

I nodded, turning away slightly as I gathered my courage. Then, in one fluid motion, I pulled the sweatshirt over my head, followed by my tank top, leaving me in just my sports bra. The cool air of the basement raised goosebumps on my exposed skin.

I heard Catra's soft intake of breath and resisted the urge to cross my arms over myself. Instead, I turned my back to her, revealing the centerpiece of my tattoo collection.

Down the length of my spine ran a sword, its blade detailed with ancient script and symbols of power. From it extended intricate patterns that spread across my shoulder blades and lower back. A tapestry of images that represented my journey as She-Ra. Hidden within the design were elements that told my story: a small crown for my first championship, three stars for my title defenses, a broken chain for overcoming limitations, and at the base of my spine, a phoenix rising from ashes—the piece I'd added after beginning my recovery from the Frosta fight.

"The sword design," I explained softly, "was something my great-grandfather found in an ancient text about Brightfall's founding legends. According to him, the first settlers here believed in a warrior goddess who carried a sword of light and protected the innocent. He sketched it in his journals, and when I was looking for something to represent She-Ra, it just... felt right."

For several long moments, Catra said nothing. The silence made me increasingly self-conscious, and I was about to reach for my discarded shirt when I felt it—the whisper-soft touch of fingertips against my skin.

I froze, a shiver that had nothing to do with the cold running through me as Catra's fingers traced the outline of the sword down my spine. Her touch was feather-light, almost reverential, as she followed the intricate patterns across my back.

"This is..." she began, her voice low and slightly husky. "Adora, this is incredible."

The way she said my name sent another shiver through me. Cautiously, I glanced over my shoulder to find her face mere inches from mine, her eyes focused on the tattoo but filled with an expression I'd never seen in them before, a mixture of wonder and something deeper, more intense. Desire.

"The detail is amazing," she murmured, fingers still tracing the patterns. "It's like your whole story is written on your skin."

"That was the idea," I said, my voice barely above a whisper. "Boxing has been my life for so long, and connecting it to my family's history here... it made sense."

Our eyes met, and suddenly the air between us felt charged with electricity. She was close enough that I could feel her breath against my skin, could see the subtle flecks of gold in her blue eye, the depth of color in her amber one. Neither of us moved, caught in a moment of suspended possibility.

I turned slowly to face her fully, the movement bringing us even closer. Her gaze dropped briefly to my lips, then back to my eyes, a question in her expression that I wasn't sure I knew how to answer—or perhaps was afraid to.

The space between us seemed to shrink, though I couldn't tell if she was leaning closer or if I was. My heart pounded so loudly I was certain she must hear it.

The metallic sound of the doorknob turning broke the spell.

We froze, panic replacing whatever had been building between us. Someone was coming in—to a room that officially didn't exist as a training space, where I was half-dressed with my tattoos fully exposed, where Catra and I were sitting far too close for any casual explanation.

Before I could react, Catra grabbed my arm and yanked me toward the corner of the room. "Supply closet," she hissed, already pulling me toward a narrow door I'd barely noticed before.

We tumbled inside just as the main door opened, Catra pulling the closet door closed behind us. The space was tiny, barely large enough for cleaning supplies, let alone two people. We stood pressed together in the darkness, hardly daring to breathe, my bare skin dangerously close to hers.

I could hear multiple voices now—not just one person, but a group entering the room. Their footsteps echoed as they moved around the space we'd just vacated.

"Hey, check this out," a male voice said, sounding surprised. "There's a heavy bag down here. Was this always here?"

"No way," another voice responded. "This is supposed to be storage. Someone's set up their own little gym."

"Look at the wraps on the floor," a female voice pointed out. "Someone was just here."

My heart hammered against my ribcage. My discarded hand wraps—I hadn't had time to grab them before we'd rushed into hiding. Worse, my shirt and sweatshirt were still out there somewhere.

"Should we report this?" one of them asked.

"For what?" another countered. "It's just some equipment. Probably a fitness student getting in extra practice."

"It's pretty cool, actually," the first voice said. "Maybe we could use it too."

The conversation continued, the group debating whether to leave things as they found them or report the unauthorized use of space. All the while, I remained acutely aware of Catra pressed against me in the darkness. Her hand still rested lightly on my waist, her fingers inadvertently brushing against my bare skin with each breath I took.

I couldn't see her clearly in the dim light, but I could feel her, every point of contact between us sending currents of awareness through my body. Her breath was warm against my neck, slightly uneven despite her apparent outward calm.

The voices outside seemed to reach a consensus. "Let's just leave it. Not our business if someone found an empty room to work out in."

"Yeah, we've got enough to do setting up for tomorrow's orientation without worrying about this."

Footsteps moved toward the door, voices fading as the group prepared to leave. I should have been focusing entirely on whether they would discover us, on what excuse I could possibly make if they opened the closet door to find me half-dressed with Catra.

Instead, all I could focus on was Catra herself, the subtle scent of her perfume, the warmth radiating from her body, the almost imperceptible trembling of her fingers against my skin. Was it fear of discovery making her tremble, or something else entirely?

Finally, the main door closed, and silence fell over the room outside our hiding place. Neither of us moved immediately, perhaps waiting to be certain the intruders were truly gone.

Or perhaps, like me, Catra was reluctant to break whatever spell had fallen over us in this tiny, hidden space.

Silence hung in the darkness of the closet, broken only by our breathing. The intruders had left, but neither of us moved to leave our hiding place. My mind told me we should hurry out, I needed to retrieve my clothes, we needed to make sure the coast was clear but my body seemed unwilling to break contact with Catra's.

Slowly, I reached for the doorknob, my fingers just brushing the metal when Catra's hand covered mine, stopping the movement. She shifted almost imperceptibly, pressing closer to me in the confined space. The small adjustment brought us fully against each other, her body fitting against mine in a way that sent electricity racing beneath my skin.

I froze, hyperaware of every point of contact, her palm over my hand, her body against my bare torso, her breath warming my neck. Time seemed to suspend itself as we stood perfectly still, neither advancing nor retreating, caught in a moment of pure possibility.

Without conscious decision, I found my free hand moving upward, fingers gently cupping her face in the darkness. I felt her sharp intake of breath, the slight tremor that ran through her at my touch. For a heartbeat, I hesitated giving her time to pull away, to break whatever spell had fallen over us.

She didn't move.

The last of my restraint dissolved. I leaned forward, closing the small distance between us, and pressed my lips to hers.

For one terrible second, she remained perfectly still, and I feared I'd horribly misread the situation. Then her lips softened, moving against mine as her hand left the doorknob to slide around my waist, pulling me closer.

The kiss deepened, transforming from tentative exploration to something more certain, more urgent. Her lips were impossibly soft, the taste of her intoxicating in a way that made the strongest boxing adrenaline seem mild by comparison. My fingers threaded into her hair as I guided her back until she was pressed against the wall, my body following, unwilling to allow any space between us.

When my tongue traced the seam of her lips, she opened to me with a soft, breathy sound, half sigh, half moan that vibrated through both of us. The small noise seemed to snap us partially back to reality, and we broke apart, though our bodies remained pressed together, both of us breathing heavily.

"I'm sorry." I whispered automatically, though every cell in my body protested the apology. "I shouldn't have-"

"Don't." Catra interrupted, her voice low and slightly ragged. "Don't apologize."

"But-"

Her finger pressed gently against my lips. "Stop saying sorry. This isn't a bad thing."

The confession hung between us, honest and vulnerable in a way Catra rarely allowed herself to be.

"What is this?" I asked softly, giving voice to the question that had been building since that moment in the alley when she'd first seen past my disguise. "What's happening here?"

I felt rather than saw her shake her head in the darkness. "I don't know." She admitted. "All I know is that I can't stop thinking about you. Even before... before I knew about She-Ra. You've been driving me crazy since the day you arrived."

"I thought you hated me?" I said, confusion evident in my voice.

She let out a small, humorless laugh. "I tried to. God, I tried. You were so... perfect. Smart, kind, everyone immediately liked you. And there was something about you, something I couldn't place that kept drawing me in, even when I wanted to push you away."

Her honesty deserved my own. "I thought you were the most frustrating person I'd ever met." I confessed. "But also... the most fascinating."

"Fascinating?" I could hear the surprise in her voice.

"You're so unapologetically yourself. You don't try to make people like you. You're brilliant and sharp and... I don't know. There's a fire in you that I recognized somehow. Even when you were making my life difficult, I couldn't look away."

She was quiet for a moment, absorbing my words. The vulnerability in this shared darkness emboldened me to voice the fear I hadn't fully acknowledged.

"Is it because I'm She-Ra?" I asked softly. "Is that why you're... interested now? Because you admire that part of me?"

The question hung between us, exposing my own insecurity about whether what was happening was based on her fascination with my alter ego rather than with me as a person.

Catra didn't respond immediately, I reached for the doorknob again, this time without interference. Light spilled into our hiding place as I opened the door, allowing me to see Catra's face clearly for the first time since our kiss.

She looked almost fragile in the sudden brightness, her usual sharp edges softened by uncertainty. A pink flush colored her cheeks, her lips slightly swollen from our kiss, her mismatched eyes watching me with a vulnerable intensity that made my heart ache.

"It's not about She-Ra." She said softly, holding my gaze. "Whatever this is... it started before I knew."

She took a deep breath and ran a hand through her hand. "From day one, there was something about you, Adora. Something that got under my skin and wouldn't leave. I just didn't know how to handle it, so I..." she trailed off, looking away.

"So you channeled it into antagonism." I finished for her.

A small, almost shy smile tugged at the corner of her mouth. "It seemed safer than the alternative."

"And now?" I asked, hardly daring to breathe.

Her eyes returned to mine, that familiar determination I'd always admired now focused in a new direction. "Now I'm not interested in playing it safe."

The declaration sent a shiver through me, equal parts excitement and trepidation. This was uncharted territory for both of us, complicated by our history, by my dual identity, by the web of secrets and half-truths that still existed between us.

We stepped out of the closet together, the spaciousness of the room a stark contrast to our previous confinement. I spotted my tank top where it had been kicked under the weight rack, thankfully overlooked by our intruders.

As I retrieved it and began to dress, an awkward silence fell between us, as if neither of us quite knew how to act in this new reality where we'd crossed from adversaries to... whatever we were now.

"So," Catra said finally, attempting a light tone that didn't quite mask her uncertainty, "are you going to tell them? Sparkles, Arrow Boy, and the purple-haired scientist?"

I paused in the act of pulling my tank top over my head, considering the question. "About She-Ra or about... this?" I gestured vaguely between us.

"Either. Both." She shrugged, trying to appear nonchalant, though I could see the tension in her shoulders.

"I don't know..." I admitted, finishing dressing. "I've kept the She-Ra secret for so long, it's hard to imagine telling anyone. You knowing is already more than I planned."

I stepped closer to her, drawn by some magnetic pull I couldn't resist. "As for this..." I turned to Catra, using my finger to point between her and I. "I'm not sure what 'this' is. But..." I paused, trying to find the words. Do I really want to put more on my plate? Can I trust her? How will my friends feel? "We can figure it out as we go? That sound alright?"

Catra just kinda stood there for a moment, maybe shocked that I didn't jump straight into asking her out on the spot even though I had to fight the urge to. She shuffled around and then looked me dead in the eye as she said, "Wow, Adora," she purred. "I didn't think you were going to say that, but I have no problem with figuring it out. But..."

She took slow steps towards me, and a small mischievous smile started to spread on her lips. A strong shiver ran through my whole body as she got to me and pressed up against me, whispering in my ear. "It's more fun to tease you anyway. Let's see how long you can last." She softly bit the edge of my ear.

In that moment I wasn't sure if I was willing to wait. The rational side of me knew that Catra had just found out a very personal and deep secret I had been hiding. I couldn't say she wouldn't slip and tell somebody, but the very aware Adora in the moment just wanted to say fuck it and grab her and pin her underneath. To spend the rest of the day tangled together.

We stood there for a moment, bodies pressed onto each other, the air between us charged with possibility and uncertainty in equal measure. Then Catra grinned, a flash of her usual mischievous self returning, and softly pushed herself off me. "Besides, can you imagine Sparkles' face if she knew her perfect new friend was making out with her nemesis in a supply closet?"

I laughed, the tension breaking. "She'd never believe it. But can I ask you something?"

"Sure," she said as she turned and went to pick up my sweatshirt.

"Why do you go after them?" That question froze Catra. She just stood there for a moment playing with my hoodie, and I saw her take a deep breath before she looked at me with almost sad eyes.

"Believe it or not, Sparkles and I grew up most of our childhood together." I didn't mean to, but I must've let my mouth fall open as she walked over to me and put the sweatshirt in my hand and used her finger to close my mouth.

"Honestly, I'm surprised that she hasn't told you. I figured the reason you weren't fond of me was because she told you." She stepped back. "But I think you should ask her. If I tell you now and she finds out, well, I can already see her start pouting about it." She gave a small chuckle before patting my chest. "Anyway, it's almost as unbelievable as you being She-Ra." She changed the conversation, then grew more serious. "Your secret is safe with me, Adora. Both secrets."

The sincerity in her voice touched me deeply, even though I still had many more things I wanted to ask her. "Thank you." I said

simply.

As we gathered our things and prepared to leave, I found myself filled with a strange mix of emotions. Fear about Frosta's presence on campus still lingered, and uncertainty about what was developing between Catra and me created its own kind of nervous energy. On top of that, I'd just found out that there was a deeper connection between my friends and Catra.

But beneath it all was something else, something that felt surprisingly like hope. For the first time since arriving at Brightfall, I didn't feel like I was choosing between two separate identities. With Catra, somehow, I could be both Adora and She-Ra and perhaps in time, something more integrated than either.

"See you tomorrow?" Catra asked at the door.

I nodded. "Tomorrow."

As I walked home in the fading afternoon light, my lips still tingling from our kiss, I realized that in trying to escape one complication, I'd found myself in the middle of another. But this complication, this unexpected connection with someone who knew all of me, didn't feel like a burden.

It felt like the beginning of something I hadn't known I was looking for until I found it.

Chapter 18: Childhood background

The revelation about Catra and Glimmer's shared childhood haunted me all evening. After dinner with my parents, during which I barely spoke, my mind elsewhere, I retreated to my room and stared at my phone, debating whether to text Glimmer.

Why had she never mentioned knowing Catra before college? And not just knowing her... growing up with her. The tension between them had always seemed like typical campus rivalry, but now it appeared to have deeper roots.

And why had Catra been so reluctant to tell me the story herself? The sadness in her eyes when she'd mentioned it suggested something painful had happened between them.

I flopped back on my bed, thoughts swirling. The day had been overwhelming, showing Catra my tattoos, the kiss, discovering this connection between her and my friend. And all of this against the backdrop of my ongoing identity crisis.

After an hour of indecision, I finally texted Glimmer: *Can we talk tomorrow? Just the two of us?*

Her response came quickly: *Sure! Everything ok?*

Just need some friend time, I replied, not wanting to give away my real purpose over text.

Coffee at Whispering Woods, 10am?

Perfect.

Sleep came fitfully that night, my dreams a confusing tangle of boxing rings and supply closets, of Catra's lips against mine and Glimmer's potential reaction if she ever found out.

The next morning, I arrived at the café early, securing a quiet corner table away from other students. When Glimmer bustled in, pink hair slightly windblown, she immediately noticed my serious expression.

"Okay, what's wrong?" she asked, sliding into the seat across from me. "You've got your worried face on."

I fiddled with my coffee cup, suddenly unsure how to begin. "I... learned something yesterday that confused me, and I was hoping you could help me understand it."

Her brow furrowed with concern. "Of course. What is it?"

Taking a deep breath, I asked the question directly: "Did you and Catra grow up together?"

Glimmer froze, her coffee cup halfway to her lips. A series of emotions flashed across her face, surprise, confusion, then something that looked like deep shame and old pain.

"Where did you hear that?" she asked quietly, her voice barely above a whisper.

"...Catra mentioned it the other day..." I said, watching her carefully. "But she wouldn't tell me details. She said I should ask you."

Glimmer set her cup down with trembling hands. "We did," she confirmed after a long moment. Her eyes refused to meet mine, focusing instead on the table between us. "After her parents died in a car accident when she was eight, my family took her in. She lived with us for almost four years."

"You were foster siblings?" I asked, surprised by how deep the connection ran.

Glimmer nodded, a sad smile ghosting across her lips. "More than that. We were inseparable. Shared a room, shared clothes, shared everything. My mom was working on officially adopting her."

"What happened?" I asked gently, sensing we were approaching the painful part.

Glimmer was quiet for so long I thought she might not answer. When she finally spoke, her voice was thick with emotion.

"We had a fight. A stupid, childish fight that got out of hand." She swallowed hard. "I was twelve, she was almost thirteen. I was jealous because my mom was spending so much time helping Catra with her trauma therapy. It felt like Catra was getting all the attention."

She wrapped her hands tightly around her coffee cup. "I said... terrible things. Things no one should ever say to someone who's lost their parents. I told her she wasn't really part of our family, that she was just a charity case my mom took in because she felt sorry for her."

"Glimmer," I breathed, shocked by the revelation.

"It gets worse," she continued, her voice now barely audible. "I told her that her parents probably wouldn't have wanted her anyway, that's why they left her. I knew it wasn't true... they died in an accident but I wanted to hurt her."

Tears welled in Glimmer's eyes. "The look on her face, Adora. I'll never forget it as long as I live. It was like something broke inside her."

"What happened after that?" I asked, my heart aching for both of them.

"She ran away that night. They found her two days later, hiding in an abandoned building near where her parents' apartment had been." Glimmer wiped at her eyes. "She refused to come back to our house. Refused to even see me. A distant relative was located—a woman named Sharon Weaver who I guess was her mother's cousin. She adopted Catra and moved her across town."

"And you never got to apologize?" I asked.

Glimmer shook her head. "I tried. For months, I tried. I wrote letters, I called, I even showed up at her new school once. But she wouldn't speak to me. Eventually, Sharon told my mom to keep me away, that I was making Catra's trauma worse."

She looked up at me, her eyes red-rimmed. "By the time we ended up at Brightfall together, years had passed. I tried to approach her during freshman orientation, but she looked right through me like I didn't exist. And then the next day, the snide comments started, the little digs, the subtle sabotage of anything I was involved in."

"And you just... accepted it?" I asked, struggling to reconcile this with the confident, assertive Glimmer I knew.

"What choice did I have?" she asked simply. "I deserved it. I destroyed something precious because of childish jealousy. So yes, I let her take her shots. If it gives her some peace, some closure..." she trailed off.

"Does Bow know?" I asked.

"Yes, but not all the details. He knows we grew up together and had a falling out. He doesn't know exactly what I said to her." She looked at me with sudden intensity. "Please don't tell him, Adora. It's the worst thing I've ever done, and I've never forgiven myself for it."

"I won't," I promised. "But maybe you and Catra should talk about it, after all this time."

Glimmer let out a hollow laugh. "She'd never agree to that. And honestly, what could I possibly say? 'Sorry I traumatized you when you were already grieving your parents'? Some things can't be fixed with an apology."

Her words hung heavy between us. I reached across the table and squeezed her hand. "We all make mistakes, especially as kids."

"Some mistakes leave scars," she said quietly. "I look at who Catra is now—always on guard, never letting anyone close—and I know I helped create that. Not just with what I said, but by never finding a way to make it right."

I thought about the Catra I'd glimpsed yesterday, vulnerable, open, capable of tenderness. "I think there's more to her than you see," I said carefully.

Glimmer studied me with sudden interest. "Why did she tell you we knew each other? You two aren't exactly friends."

The question caught me off guard. I couldn't exactly explain everything that has happened.

"We... had a moment," I said vaguely. "A conversation where she was less... Catra-like than usual."

Glimmer's eyes narrowed suspiciously. "Since when do you and Catra have conversations where she's not being awful?"

"It's complicated," I hedged. "We've been... interacting more lately."

"Interacting?" Glimmer repeated, her tone making it clear she wasn't buying my evasiveness. "Adora, what's going on? There's something you're not telling me."

The hurt in her voice made my chest tighten with guilt. She was right, I was keeping major parts of my life from someone I considered a close friend. But how much could I reveal without everything unraveling?

"I'm sorry," I said, meaning it. "I'm... figuring some things out right now. About who I am here, what I want. And Catra's somehow become part of that."

Glimmer reached across the table, taking my hand. "You know you can tell me anything, right? Whatever's going on with you, I'm here."

The sincerity in her eyes made my guilt deepen. "I know," I said. "And I promise, when I can explain everything, I will."

She didn't look entirely satisfied with this answer but nodded anyway. "I trust you, Adora."

Those four words felt like a weight on my chest. Trust. Something I was testing with every day I maintained my secret.

As we finished our coffee and moved on to lighter topics, my mind kept returning to Catra. How much pain she must have carried all these years. The isolation of losing her parents, then losing her foster family, then being uprooted again with a distant relative. It explained so much about her guarded nature, her reluctance to let people in.

Except she had let me in, just a little, but enough to change everything between us.

I left the café with my head spinning, torn between sympathy for both Glimmer and Catra. Neither was the villain in this story—just two children who had been hurt and whose pain had calcified over time into the complex dynamic I witnessed now.

As I headed toward the library to study, my phone buzzed with a text. Catra: *Rooftop of the science building. 20 minutes. Come alone.*

My heart skipped a beat. After everything I'd just learned, the prospect of seeing Catra carried new weight. What did she want? Had she somehow known I'd be talking to Glimmer today?

As I changed direction toward the science building, I realized I was walking toward not just Catra, but toward a deeper understanding of the complicated web of relationships I'd unwittingly stepped into at Brightfall. And despite my better judgment warning me to protect my own secrets, I found myself hoping that this meeting might bring some healing, for Catra, for Glimmer, and perhaps even for the parts of myself I'd been keeping separated for so long.

Chapter 19: Fever Pitch

The week after my rooftop conversation with Catra passed in a haze of irritability and restlessness. We'd left things in a fragile, undefined new place—not quite friends, no longer enemies, teetering on the edge of something I didn't have the emotional bandwidth to name. I found myself snapping at innocent questions from my parents, avoiding social interactions, and spending more time alone in my secret training room than in class or with friends.

I'd been actively avoiding Catra, too. I ignored the two texts she sent—one asking if I wanted to study for our shared economics class, the other a simple "You good?"—and took alternate routes between buildings to minimize the chance of running into her. I couldn't fully explain why, even to myself. A part of me had been relieved, even thrilled, by her knowing my secret. But the reality of it, the fact that this one person held the key to my entire carefully constructed life, felt like a weight I couldn't bear. The intimacy we'd shared in the supply closet felt both exhilarating and terrifying. It was a complication I didn't know how to navigate.

The pressure was mounting from the other side of my life, too. Over the weekend, I'd had a video call with my parents and Coach Huntara to discuss the future.

"The promoters were blown away, kid," Coach had said, her voice booming with pride. "That comeback in the Octavia fight? Legendary. They're talking about a European tournament next month. A big one. This could set you up for the Frosta rematch."

"You handled it all so well, sweetheart," my mom had added, her smile warm but her eyes carrying a familiar worry. "We were so impressed with how you managed the fights and still have a plan to get back to your studies without anyone knowing. We're so proud you can keep both worlds separate."

Separate. The word had echoed in my mind ever since. They were proud I could keep my two lives apart, but they were bleeding into each other. Catra knew. My friends had been in the front row. And now, I was being pulled back toward the ring, back toward a life that demanded all of me, just as I was finding something real in the one I was supposed to be keeping separate. It was a life crisis, brewing just beneath the surface.

By Thursday, the cracks were starting to show. Bow had started giving me concerned looks across the classroom, Glimmer was sending check-in texts every few hours, and Entrapta had compiled a detailed analysis of my "behavioral anomalies" that she helpfully shared over lunch.

"YOUR SOCIABILITY METRICS HAVE DECREASED BY 63.7% SINCE LAST WEEK," she announced loudly as I picked at my salad. "AND YOUR IRRITABILITY INDICATORS HAVE INCREASED BY—"

"I know, Entrapta," I cut her off more sharply than I'd intended. "I'm fine. Just tired."

"Tired for a whole week?" Glimmer asked skeptically. "You've been acting weird ever since our coffee date. Did I say something wrong?"

The guilt twisted in my gut. It wasn't her. It was everything. "No, it's not that," I sighed, pushing away my barely-touched food. "I'm just dealing with some stuff."

"What kind of stuff?" Bow asked gently. "Maybe we can help."

My secret identity as a world-champion boxer has been discovered by my nemesis-turned-potential-love-interest, and now I have to choose between a normal life and a career-making tournament.

"Just family stuff," I said vaguely. "Nothing important."

Bow and Glimmer exchanged a look that clearly said they didn't believe me, but they let it drop. For now.

After lunch, I sat through two more classes barely registering the lectures. When the final bell rang, I headed for the bus stop, wanting only to get home and maybe run until my brain shut off.

The campus bus was crowded. I squeezed in, finding a spot to stand near the back, and gripped the overhead rail. Three stops from mine, the bus made an alarming clanking sound, then shuddered to a halt.

"Sorry folks," the driver's voice crackled. "Mechanical issues. Everyone needs to exit."

Collective groans filled the bus. It would be faster to walk the remaining distance home. I shouldered my backpack and joined the stream of disgruntled students. I turned away from the group and began walking, needing the time alone.

The route home took me through a quieter part of Brightfall, along a tree-lined path that followed a shallow stream. The late afternoon sun filtered through autumn leaves. In another mood, I might have found it beautiful. Today, it just felt like terrain to cover.

I was so caught up in my own anxious thoughts that I didn't notice the footsteps behind me until a voice broke my reverie.

"So this is why you haven't been answering my texts. You're too busy speed-walking through parks."

I whirled around to find Catra a few paces back, hands in the pockets of her red jacket, watching me with an expression caught between annoyance and concern.

"What are you doing here?" I demanded, my carefully constructed solitude shattered.

"Same as you. Bus broke down, decided to walk." She fell into step beside me, uninvited. "Figured I'd see why you've been ghosting me all week."

"I haven't been ghosting you. I've been busy."

"Bullshit," she said, her voice losing its light tone. She stopped walking, forcing me to stop too. "You've been avoiding me since the other day. Don't lie, Adora. I know when I'm being avoided."

"I've been busy," I insisted, feeling my irritation rise. Why couldn't everyone just leave me alone? "Not everything is about you, Catra."

"Never said it was." She crossed her arms. "But something's clearly going on with you, and it started right after we... talked."

A flush of heat rose to my face. "Can we not do this right now? I just want to get home."

"Fine," she shrugged, falling back into step beside me. "We can talk about why you look like you haven't slept in days. Or why you're sweating when it's barely sixty degrees out."

She was right. I could feel perspiration beading on my forehead. "I'm not sweating."

"Yes, you are. And you're flushed." Catra's tone shifted from annoyed to fully concerned. She moved to stand in front of me, forcing me to halt. "Adora, are you sick?"

"No, I'm fine," I said automatically, but a wave of dizziness washed over me. The path seemed to tilt. Catra's face blurred.

"You don't look fine. You look like you're about to—"

That was the last thing I heard before the world went dark.

I woke to the scent of amber and spice and the vague awareness of an unfamiliar ceiling. My head pounded. A cool, damp cloth

rested on my forehead. I turned my head, taking in the minimalist decor, the vinyl records, the dark burgundy sheets I was tucked under. I was in Catra's bed.

A jolt went through me. I tried to sit up, but a wave of dizziness and a full-body ache pushed me back down. Looking around more carefully, I saw Catra across the room, sitting in an armchair with a sketchbook in her lap, though she wasn't drawing. She was just staring at the wall, lost in thought.

"Where am I?" My voice was a weak croak.

Her head snapped up, her expression unreadable. "You're awake," she stated, setting her sketchbook aside. She walked over and stood by the bed, arms crossed. She didn't look soft or gentle; she looked annoyed, and underneath that, deeply worried.

"What happened?" I asked.

"You fainted. Face-planted on a public walkway," she said bluntly. "You have a fever. You're sick."

"How did I get here?"

"I carried you," she said, as if it were an obvious inconvenience. "You're heavier than you look, by the way."

"Oh." My mind raced. "Sorry... um..."

"Oh, by the way I called your best friend squad," Catra said with a humorless smirk. "That was fun. They showed up ready to take my head off. Sparkles was about two seconds from accusing me of poisoning you."

"They were here?"

"For a while," she confirmed, walking over to the window and looking out. "They calmed down once they realized you were just sick and not, you know, kidnapped. I had to convince them not to call an ambulance." She glanced back at me. "They told me your

parents weren't home and you couldn't exactly be left alone with that high of a fever, so they suggested I let you stay here... I even offered them the couch, but they had to go study or whatever. Said they'd be back later."

The image of Catra negotiating with a frantic Glimmer and a worried Bow was almost impossible to comprehend. "I wish I was there to see that. Why didn't you just leave me and call my friends instead?"

"Leave you? I couldn't exactly leave you passed out on the sidewalk, could I? What would that do for my reputation?" The sarcasm was a familiar shield, but her eyes gave away her concern. She walked back to the bed. "But you are right. I could've called them and had them get you, but I don't know... Besides the point. What is wrong with you? Are you going to tell me what the hell is going on? And don't give me that 'family stuff' bullshit. You don't get a 102-degree fever from 'family stuff'."

I sighed, the fight going out of me. "They want me to fight again," I whispered. "A big tournament. In Europe. Next month."

She absorbed that, her expression tightening. "Okay?"

"It's a huge opportunity. A title shot. But it means leaving, choosing that life over this one." I looked at her, the conflict spilling out of me. "And I started thinking about... everything and how for the first time in my life i actually have true friends and.. it's too much. I can't keep it separate anymore. I don't know what I want to do." I trailed off, realizing I was doing it again, unloading all my chaotic feelings onto her without thinking. I pressed my lips together, stopping myself.

"That's all your gonna say?" Catra prompted, her voice softer now, seeing my distress.

I shook my head, turning to look at the wall. "Nothing. It's just... a lot."

I avoided her eyes and saw the sketchbook laying on the chair. "What were you drawing?" I asked, deflecting, nodding toward the closed sketchbook on her chair.

There was a pause. "Nothing important," she said, her voice flat, shutting down that line of inquiry completely. The brief moment of vulnerability was over. "Adora, why'd you stop talking?"

"I just need to think for a moment," I mumbled into the pillow, overwhelmed by the fever, the cold sweats, and the sheer complexity of it all. I was too tired to talk, too tired to even process the surreal fact that I was having this conversation in Catra's bed.

My body ached, my head pounded. I closed my eyes, the exhaustion pulling me under like a tide. Just before sleep claimed me, I heard Catra let out a soft, frustrated sigh. I was leaving her in the dark again, and a part of me felt guilty, but the rest of me was just too tired to care. I surrendered to the feverish darkness, leaving Catra alone to watch over me in the quiet of her room.

Chapter 20: Catra's Watch

Catra's POV

"Adora?" I whispered into the quiet of the room. No response. I waited a beat, watching the slow, even rise and fall of her shoulders. "Adora?" I tried again, a little louder. Nothing. She was completely out.

A frustrated sigh escaped my lips. She'd done it again. Pulled me in, let me see the chaos swirling behind her perfect blue eyes, and then slammed the door shut, leaving me on the outside. I should have been furious. I *was* furious. And worried. And something else, something warm and tight in my chest that I refused to name.

I reached over, my fingers hesitating for a fraction of a second before gently touching her forehead. She was burning up. The damp cloth I'd put there earlier was already warm and dry. I got up, the springs of the old armchair groaning in the silence, and went to the bathroom to re-wet the cloth.

When I came back, I stood over her for a moment. Her blonde hair was a mess against my dark pillowcase, strands clinging to her damp temples. Even in her feverish sleep, there was a furrow of tension between her brows. I gently brushed the hair back from her face and replaced the cool cloth on her forehead. She let out a soft sigh in her sleep, the sound twisting that unnamed feeling in my chest.

That's when I noticed it. The dark fabric of her long-sleeved shirt was clinging to her, damp with sweat. She couldn't be comfortable like that. And if she was this sick, sleeping in sweat-soaked clothes was a good way to get even sicker.

The thought of changing her clothes sent a jolt of heat through me that had nothing to do with her fever. It was a completely

practical, necessary thing to do. And yet, the idea of it, the intimacy of it, made my hands feel clumsy and my face flush.

Get a grip, Weaver, I chided myself. *She's sick. You're just helping.*

I tried to distract myself. I went to the kitchen, made a simple soup that I wasn't even sure she'd be able to eat later, and ate my own dinner in front of the TV, the noise of some dumb action movie doing little to quiet the roaring in my head.

But I couldn't ignore it. I couldn't just leave her like that.

With a deep breath, I went to my dresser and pulled out a pair of soft, grey sweatpants and one of my larger, looser band t-shirts. They'd probably be a little short on her, but they were clean and dry. Holding them in my hands, I walked back into the bedroom, my heart pounding a ridiculously fast rhythm against my ribs.

She hadn't moved. I took a moment to just look at her, really look at her, without the walls, without the witty comebacks or the secrets. The fever seemed to have smoothed the tension from her face, leaving her looking peaceful. Her eyelashes were ridiculously long, casting faint shadows on her high cheekbones. Her face, even with the faint, fading bruises I now knew were from a championship fight, was perfectly sculpted. And her lips... my gaze lingered there, remembering the impossible softness, the taste of moonshine and desperation and something more.

Shaking my head to clear the memory, I got to work. My hands trembled slightly as I gently unbuttoned her jeans and slid them off, trying my best to be clinical, to not notice the long, powerful line of her legs. I managed to get the sweatpants on with minimal fuss, my cheeks burning the entire time.

The shirt was harder. It meant sitting her up, peeling the damp fabric off her skin. I was as careful as I could be, my movements practiced and efficient, but I couldn't stop the way my fingers brushed against her warm skin, couldn't ignore the solid, defined muscle of her back and shoulders under my hands. For a dizzying

second, I remembered the feel of my fingers tracing the ink on her back, the story of She-Ra written there.

Once she was dressed in my clothes, I gently laid her back down and pulled the heavy blanket over her. She looked... small, somehow. Vulnerable. And so damn beautiful it made my chest ache.

I checked my phone. 10:15 PM. I should go to sleep. My couch was uncomfortable, but it would do. I couldn't exactly sleep in the same bed as her, could I? That would be crossing a line.

As I stood up, Glimmer's parting words from earlier echoed in my head. *"You have to watch her, Catra. Her fever could get worse. Text me if anything changes, I mean it. Wake her up every few hours to make sure she's coherent."*

She'd said it with the bossy authority only Sparkles could muster, but underneath it was genuine, terrified concern for her friend. I'd promised I would. And I couldn't do that from the living room.

With a sigh that was part resignation, part something else, I quietly crawled into the other side of the bed, on top of the covers. I kept as much distance as the mattress would allow, my back to her. It was fine. This was just practical. Responsible.

I pulled out my phone, scrolling aimlessly through social media, the blue light a harsh contrast to the soft lamp glow in the room. The bed was big enough. I wouldn't even know she was there.

A little while later, just as I was starting to drift off, I heard Adora make a soft noise, a pained grunt. I turned over to see her shifting in her sleep, her face scrunched up as if in a bad dream. She was muttering something, words too slurred by sleep and fever to make out.

Glimmer's voice again: Wake her up if she seems distressed.

"Adora?" I whispered, leaning over her. "Hey, you okay?"

I reached out, intending to just gently shake her shoulder, to pull her out of whatever nightmare had her in its grip. But the second my fingers made contact with her arm, she moved.

It wasn't a conscious action. It was pure, sleep-fogged instinct. Her arm shot out, her hand closing around my wrist. And then she pulled.

I tumbled toward her with a startled gasp, and before I could react, her other arm was around my waist, pulling me tight against her body. She buried her face in the crook of my neck, let out a long, contented sigh, and just... held me. Her grip was strong, uncompromising, and incredibly warm.

My entire body went rigid with shock. My heart felt like it was going to beat its way out of my chest. She was holding me. Asleep. As if I were a lifeline, a comfort she'd reached for in the dark.

I should have pulled away. I should have untangled myself and gone straight to the couch. It was the smart thing to do, the safe thing to do.

But I didn't move.

Her breathing evened out, deepening into the rhythm of sleep. The tension slowly drained from my own body. Cautiously, I let my head rest back on my pillow. Her arm was a heavy, warm weight around my waist. Her breath was a steady, soft puff against my neck. It was overwhelming. It was terrifying.

And it was the safest I had ever felt in my entire life.

After a long while, my own exhaustion won out. My eyes drifted shut, and with Adora's arm wrapped around me, her body a solid, grounding presence against mine, I finally fell asleep.

Chapter 21: The Morning After

I woke slowly, drifting up from a deep, feverish sleep into a state of profound comfort. I was warm. Safe. For the first time in what felt like forever, the anxious knot in my stomach was gone, replaced by a quiet sense of peace. I snuggled deeper into the source of the warmth, burying my face against a soft curve that smelled of amber and spice. A slow, steady heartbeat thumped a soothing rhythm against my ear.

My eyes fluttered open.

The first thing I saw was a curtain of messy brown hair. The second was a slender arm draped possessively over my waist. The third was the slow, even rise and fall of a shoulder just inches from my face.

My brain rebooted with the force of a system crash.

I'm in Catra's bed.

And she's holding me.

Every muscle in my body went rigid. I didn't dare move, didn't dare breathe. The memories of the previous day came flooding back—the bus, the walk, the confrontation, fainting into darkness. She must have brought me here. She must have put me to bed. But how did we end up like this?

I was acutely aware of every point of contact: her arm a heavy, warm bar across my middle; my face tucked into the space between her shoulder and neck; our legs tangled together under the heavy blanket. Her soft, steady breathing ghosted across my forehead. She was fast asleep, completely relaxed in a way I'd never seen her.

Panic and a completely inappropriate sense of contentment warred within me. I needed to get out of here. Now. Before she

woke up. Before this impossibly complicated situation got any more complicated.

Slowly, carefully, I tried to untangle myself. I shifted my leg an inch. She stirred, her arm tightening around my waist with a soft, sleepy murmur. I froze again, my heart hammering against my ribs. After a moment, her breathing evened out, and I tried again, attempting to lift her arm.

Her eyes fluttered open.

For a moment, her mismatched gaze was soft and clouded with sleep. Then, recognition dawned, and her eyes widened slightly. But instead of jumping back, instead of the sarcastic comment I expected, she just... looked at me.

I pulled back abruptly. "I— I'm sorry, I fell asleep, I didn't mean —"

"Hey," she mumbled, her voice thick and gravelly with sleep. She tightened her grip, effortlessly holding me in place as I tried to scramble away. "S'okay. Stop moving."

"Catra, I need to get up. I need to go."

"No," she said, her voice a low, sleepy purr. She shifted, pulling me back down until my head was on her pillow, our faces inches apart. "You're still sick. Stay."

"I can't," I whispered, my resolve melting under her warm, sleepy gaze.

"Shhh," she murmured, her thumb stroking my side in a lazy, soothing motion. "Tournament," she said, the word slurred. "You should do it. 'S important."

I stared at her, stunned. "What?"

"The Europe thing," she mumbled, her eyes already starting to drift closed. "You gotta do it. Be She-Ra. Be Adora. 'S okay to be

both." Her words trailed off into a soft sigh, and just like that, she was asleep again, her arm still holding me securely against her.

I lay there, completely still, my mind reeling. In the space of thirty seconds, she had woken up, held me captive, given me her blessing to pursue my boxing career, and fallen back asleep. It was the most surreal and unexpectedly comforting moment of my life. The war in my head quieted. It's okay to be both. Coming from her, the one person who knew both sides of me, the words felt like an absolution.

A wave of warmth, entirely unrelated to the fever, washed over me. I looked at her sleeping face—the long lashes, the soft curve of her lips—and a feeling I'd been fighting for weeks finally broke through my defenses. I was completely, irrevocably, falling for Catra.

The thought was so overwhelming that my own exhaustion took over. My eyes felt heavy. I let my head rest against her pillow, and with her arm still wrapped around me and her quiet breathing a steady presence beside me, I drifted back to sleep.

The next time I woke, it was to the sound of a key in the lock, followed by the front door opening.

"Catra?" Glimmer's voice called out. "We brought breakfast! And some actually effective fever reducers, not whatever herbal stuff you probably have."

My eyes shot open. Catra was still asleep beside me, her arm thrown over my waist, my back pressed against her chest in a tangle of limbs. We were, for all intents and purposes, cuddling.

Panic, sharp and absolute, seized me. I tried to move, to detangle myself, but Catra just mumbled in her sleep and pulled me closer.

"I'm in the bedroom!" I heard myself call out, my voice thick with a mixture of sleep and sheer terror. Maybe if I warned her, she

wouldn't just—

The bedroom door swung open.

Glimmer stood in the doorway, a bag of pastries in one hand, her mouth falling open in a perfect 'O' of shock. Bow, right behind her, froze mid-step, his eyes widening to the size of dinner plates.

Silence. A thick, horrified, deeply awkward silence.

"I can explain," I started, my voice a weak squeak.

Glimmer just pointed a trembling finger at us. "You... she... what... CATRA?"

The sound of her name, spoken with such strangled disbelief, finally roused Catra. She stirred, lifting her head and blinking sleepily at the figures in her doorway. "Wha's goin' on?" she mumbled, her brain clearly not yet processing the scene. She then seemed to realize where her arm was, and that I was awake and rigid with terror beside her. Her eyes widened.

"Oh," she said. "This probably looks bad."

"Bad?" Glimmer finally found her voice, which was several octaves higher than usual. "Bad doesn't cover it, Adora! You're in bed! Cuddling! With the She-Devil herself!"

I finally managed to wiggle out of Catra's grasp and sat up, throwing my legs over the side of the bed. "Glimmer, it's not what you think. I was sick, she was just making sure—"

"By sleeping with you?!"

"I can attest that all parties remained fully clothed and on opposite sides of the bed for the majority of the night!" Entrapta's voice announced cheerfully as she popped her head into the room from behind Bow. "My thermal imaging scan from the hallway confirms it!"

"Entrapta!" we all shouted at once.

"Okay, everyone calm down," Bow said, ever the peacemaker, though he still looked deeply confused. "Adora, are you okay? She didn't, like, force you to stay here, did she?"

"No! Of course not!" I said, standing up and running a hand through my messy hair. "I fainted, I had a fever, my parents weren't home. Catra took care of me. That's all." I gestured to my clothes. "See? Nothing happened."

It was the wrong thing to do.

As I stood there, gesturing to the grey sweatpants and the loose band t-shirt Catra had dressed me in, Glimmer's gaze sharpened. Her eyes moved from my face, to the clothes, and then to my arms. The sleeves of the t-shirt were short, ending mid-bicep.

Her gasp was sharp, audible. Her eyes were locked on the intricate, flowing patterns tattooed on my left arm. The symbols of speed and adaptability. The ones that were always visible when She-Ra fought.

"Adora," she whispered, her voice trembling. "Your... your tattoo..."

Bow's gaze followed hers. I saw the moment the recognition hit him, the way his jaw went slack. He looked from my arm, to my face, to my bruised eye, and back to my arm. The pieces clicked into place with horrifying speed.

"No," he breathed, taking a step back. "It... it can't be."

My blood ran cold. I looked down at my own arm as if seeing it for the first time. The shirt. I had completely forgotten Catra changed my clothes. The tattoos were exposed. The secret was out.

"Glimmer..." I started, taking a step toward her.

She shook her head, her eyes wide with a mixture of awe, confusion, and a deep, gut-wrenching hurt. "The fight... the knockdown... the shirt you threw to me..." Her voice cracked. "All this time... it's you?"

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!